Transformation from the Periphery:
Emerging Streams of Church and Mission

By

Paul E. Pierson

Foreword

by

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Dedication

This book is dedicated to the memory of my parents, who first taught me to love the world mission of Jesus Christ.

Foreword

"The Church in this decade has gone through more change than at any other time since the Reformation. This is also bthe most productive and creative era in missions since the first century." Dr. Paul E. Pierson, Dean Emeritus, Fuller School of World Mission, 1999

As a church historian and former dean of Fuller Seminary's School of World Mission, Paul Pierson makes the provocative observation that in the history of every movement of spiritual renewal in the institutional church, there are recurring trends. He points out that one habitual trend is that *the distance between clergy and laity is decreased, with an emphasis upon the fact that every Christian is gifted by the Spirit for ministry.* Second, *there is a re-contextualizing of the gospel, and with that re-contextualization comes a burst of innovations.*

He notes that as we look across the world today, churches experiencing the most rapid decline, numerically speaking, tend to be those that are flexible in their theological convictions but rigid in their methodologies; such churches are relatively closed to innovation with regard to ministry and mission structures, worship practices, and so on. In effect, the denominational "culture" stifles this spirit of creative innovation and gospel re-contextualization.

These insights are only a sample of the wisdom gleaned as an ongoing learner of church history. Two of his courses that have had a lasting impact on countless students are *The Dynamics of Expansion of the People of God* and *The History and Theology of Evangelical Awakenings*. In these courses, he develops a series of theses regarding emerging streams of church and mission.

Yet, this is the first time in these many years that he is writing on the subject in book form. One of the anecdotes that impressed me the most about Pierson was the comment of one of his respected colleagues on the faculty at Fuller School of Intercultural Studies, who said that Pierson did not publish many books in his tenure as dean because he was always more concerned about seeing that they—the other faculty members—were doing the publishing. It is in that spirit, of considering others more important, that Pierson looked across the pages of church history to contemplate God's servants who were riding the waves of emerging streams of church and mission. Like Gamaliel, he has never been one to judge new movements too quickly. Rather, he has encouraged his students to take a posture as Gamaliel did, when he spoke to the secular leaders of his day concerning the new spiritual movement of Christians:

> . . . consider carefully what you intend to do to these men. . . . Leave these men alone! Let them go! For if their purpose or activity is of human origin, it will fail. But if it is from God, you will not be able to stop these men;

> you will only find yourselves fighting against God (Acts 5:34-35, 38b-39).

I met Paul Pierson for the first time at Wheaton '83 while I was serving as pastor of a church in El Salvador, in Central America. That was the event which marked a beginning point for a new paradigm of "mission as transformation." It was an emerging stream of mission in 1983.

Twenty years later, almost to the day, we were meeting again at an event that for him affirmed that mission as transformation has fully emerged. In the preface to his book, Pierson observes from his participation in the World Inquiry International Coalition in May 2003 in Seoul: "A remarkable consensus about the agenda has emerged from this process. It can be summed up in one word, transformation." Significantly, to him, that meeting in Seoul ". . . symbolized the passing of the torch of mission to a new, younger generation that comes mainly from Asia, Africa, and Latin America."

In this book, he develops his theses on emerging streams of church and mission in chapters one and two, and then he illustrates these by mostly contemporary case studies in the succeeding chapters and in the appendix. Thank you, Paul Pierson, for writing this book that we too may learn how to discern the ways of God as His Spirit moves to transform individuals, churches, and cultures.

Luis K. Bush

Preface

We live in an extraordinary time. Never before has the Christian faith grown as rapidly, and become as widespread as it is today. While many of the older churches in the West are in decline, we see new movements of the Spirit springing up in Asia, Africa, and Latin America. At times they create new forms of the Church. Often, upon examination, these new movements look much like the New Testament Church. Sometimes they help to renew older Christian communities.

There are interesting parallels in history. As we look to the past we can see periods in which there was a remarkable new burst of creative activity among the People of God. The Holy Spirit called men and women to embrace a greater vision for the world and gave them the power to communicate and implement that vision. One of those periods began with William Carey in 1792. A number of missionary societies were established in Europe and the United States in the following two decades. The period that followed has been called, 'the great century of missions.' A second burst of creativity, led primarily by laypersons, began with the Student Volunteer Movement in 1886, and continued with the Welsh, Korean, and Pentecostal revivals after the turn of the century. These movements increased the total missionary force more than ten-fold. We are all heirs of these movements.

Today I believe we are witnessing a similar burst of the Spirit's creativity. But there are differences! The first two originated primarily in the West. Today the movement is worldwide, but the new initiatives are coming principally from Asia, Africa, and Latin America. And often the new Christian communities are quite different from traditional western churches. We should expect this as we examine the contexts in which they arise. Often they are born in situations of poverty, persecution, and corruption in which the Gospel is heard as incredible Good News, a word of hope and meaning to people who have lacked both. And usually they grow in contexts where the world-view is much more similar to that of the Bible than that of the post-enlightenment West. That is, they take seriously the powerful work of God today and the victory of Jesus Christ over evil and death.

Already these groups constitute the cutting edge of the growing missionary movement today. And they may well point the way toward renewal in the older churches in the West.

I am not unaware of the challenges that the Church faces today; growing secularism, militant Islam, fundamentalist reactions in Hinduism and Buddhism, and political oppression. The positive and negative aspects of globalization are another factor. This leads to growing affluence in some areas while other regions continue to lie in desperate poverty. And often the new Christian movements are springing up in the poorest

areas of the world. The vast numbers of immigrants and refugees are another new factor.

At the same time, it has never been as easy for followers of Jesus Christ to travel and live in other places of the world as it is today. Nor has communication ever been as rapid. While the Christian mission does not change, the changing contexts bring both new opportunities and new challenges.

Hence the importance of this World Inquiry process as it seeks to hear from God through followers of Jesus from many countries and cultures. The Edinburgh Conference of 1910 brought together around 1500 church and mission leaders. But only seventeen were from Asia, none from Africa or Latin America. The Lausanne Conference in 1974 was important in forming the new Evangelical network. It included a much larger number of people from the Majority world but the leadership was still primarily western. We rejoice in the fact that subsequent conferences have begun to reflect much more adequately, the world wide Church.

Another issue is the agenda for this conference. The agenda of Edinburgh and a number of other conferences focused on the concerns of mission agencies. This is easy to understand when we look at their contexts. But the significant difference in the World Inquiry is that it seeks to discover the agenda that God has for His people by consulting with Christian leaders worldwide. I recall meeting with a group of Koreans in Pasadena in the first consultation. Since then there have been one hundred and ten such events and six thousand leaders from over six hundred cities have participated. Thus unlike many meetings in the past, there has been a strong attempt to hear from the church all over the world and discover what God is saying to all of us through His people.

In May 2003, the World Inquiry International Coalition met in Seoul to help prepare for the 2004 conference in Bangkok. One hundred and twenty participants from forty countries attended. The largest number came from India, the second largest from Korea and there were seventeen from the United States. For me, that meeting symbolized the passing of the torch of mission to a new, younger generation that comes mainly from Asia, Africa, and Latin America. For this we all praise God! And the primary leader at this conference was a missionary statesman from Argentina!

A remarkable consensus about the agenda has emerged from this process. It can be summed up in one word, transformation.

This concept includes many aspects and often will mean different things in changing contexts. However we believe that biblically based transformation involves both personal and social dimensions. The perceived dichotomy between evangelism and ministries of compassion and social change has often plagued mission. But it is clear that many people today are waiting

to see how the Gospel and the Christian community address the poverty and hopelessness in which they live. There is no doubt that the core of the Christian mission must always be the communication of the Good News of Jesus Christ, His death and resurrection, and invitation to new and eternal life. This is to result in the formation of worshipping, witnessing, serving communities of His followers. But while rejoicing in their salvation, these communities are called to demonstrate Christ's compassion to the world just as He did. This is an essential aspect of serious Christian discipleship. And when God's Kingdom is demonstrated to the world many will be drawn into it.

There is ample historical basis for this. Carey, rightly called the 'father of modern missions,' was not only an evangelist. He worked to end the practices of infanticide and 'suttee,' the burning of young widows with the bodies of their husbands. He established Serampore College, initiated horticultural research, and with his colleagues, translated all or part of the Scriptures into over thirty languages. No dichotomy there! He believed the Gospel could bring genuine transformation to Indian culture and worked to that end. The other early missionaries had similar goals. Thus the focus on transformation is really a return to emphases of the earliest Protestant missionary movement. As Van Engen has said,

> My thesis is that an evangelical missiology of transformation builds on classical concepts of mission as developed over the last 100 years, overcomes the dichotomies between evangelism and social action that arose 50 years ago, and re-shapes itself in a trinitarian praxis of mission appropriate to the global/local needs, challenges, and opportunities of church and world in this new century. (Van Engen 2004:84)

We will see that the renewal movements that gave birth to the missionary movement all had strong social concerns within their own cultures. And they expressed these in their missions as well. Not all of the movements we will examine show this same commitment. The focus on social transformation is very strong in the ministry in India described in chapter three. The remarkable mission movement described in chapter six is clearly holistic. But social concern is not as strong, because of both theological and contextual factors, in the movements in China and Ethiopia described in chapters four and five. We can hope that as time passes these vital movements will recognize the need for ministries of social action without losing their emphasis on evangelism.

The factors described in the first two chapters are descriptive, not prescriptive. They can be seen in movements of renewal and mission throughout history but this is not to say that every new movement will exhibit all of the characteristics listed. However usually they will. An examination of over forty emerging streams of mission listed in the Evangelizing our World Inquiry of 2003,

noted a high degree of correlation between the factors described in this book and the new movements (Bush et al 2003:IV 1-102).

I have only described four movements, two from Asia, one from Africa, and one from Latin America. None of the exhibits all of the characteristics, or theses, described in Chapter two. And I have not called attention to these factors at every point. But the reader will easily see the strong correlation with the theses in each movement. But these are only a small sample of the new movements of the Holy Spirit today. He is moving in unexpected ways through unexpected people in diverse parts of the world. Some groups must remain underground for reasons of security. Others are not on the radar screen of traditional churches and mission agencies because they do not fit their preconceived ideas. But there are many and we will see more in the near future.

As we discover new movements we will be called to develop criteria to evaluate their theology. Without going into detail I suggest that our criteria must begin with the authority of Scripture and the person and work of Jesus Christ. The work of the Holy Spirit, salvation as a gift of grace received by faith, the nature of Christian discipleship, the Church and its mission, and eschatology are also essential. It is clear that all of the movements examined here fit our criteria.

I believe it is important to examine the characteristics of past movements because so often, when similar groups arise on the periphery today, they are ignored or rejected by the institutional church. Thus an examination of these factors is important, both for emerging movements and for traditional churches. When adherents of new groups find that they are not the first to exhibit such characteristics, it helps them discover their legitimacy and kinship with similar creative movements in the past. As for the more traditional churches, I hope this study will enable them to be constantly open to the surprises of the Spirit. How impoverished the history of the People of God would be without such surprises!

Chapter 1

The Importance of the Periphery

It is clear that from the beginning, God's work of redemption began on the periphery of the most powerful human institutions of its time and has continued in that mode throughout history. We see this in Abraham leaving his father's house, a group of slaves fleeing from Egypt, and a handful of exiles returning to Jerusalem from Babylon, Jesus Christ came from Nazareth and most of his disciples were Galileans, perceived as inferior by leaders in Jerusalem. And the early Church grew up, not only on the geographical and cultural edge of the Roman Empire, but also as a marginalized sect of the Jewish community. My primary thesis is that movements of renewal and mission, have normally risen on the periphery of the broader Church and usually existed in some tension with it even as they have resulted in new streams of life and outreach, Eventually, but not always, their values have been recognized and embraced by the broader church, However as this has happened such movements have often fallen into the dangers of institutionalization and lost their original zeal. That is a major dilemma for all of us. But I believe that the study of such movements in the past and even more, the vital new streams of mission in the present may point the way toward renewal in the older, traditional churches of the West. The new movements in Asia, Africa, and Latin America are especially important.

As we examine the history of such movements, we define periphery in a number of ways. At times it has referred simply to geography. Examples are Galilee, the Great Awakening in North America in the seventeenth century, and the Welsh revival early in the twentieth. All three of those areas were far away from what would have been defined as the geographical center of political or churchly power. Nearly always, as far as I can discover, movements have also arisen at some distance from the ecclesiastical centers of power. We see this in the Antioch breakthrough, the early Franciscans, the Pietists, Moravians, Methodists, and others. Jerusalem was somewhat suspicious of the movement in Antioch, Rome was disdainful at first of the Franciscans, and the German Lutheran Church accused the Pietists of heresy and saw the Moravians as a marginal sect. Canterbury rejected the Methodists. In other cases the periphery has been sociological in nature, as movements have arisen among marginalized persons. Often they have been led by those with little or no status in either church or society and have reached out to the poor or others considered racially or socially inferior. The early Pentecostal movement is an especially striking example. So are many of the newer movements in Asia, Africa, and Latin America.

There are profound theological and historical reasons for this phenomenon. The rise of peripheral movements is a clear indication of the sovereignty of God and the fact that the gifts of the Spirit that are given to all believers, as Peter announced on the day of Pentecost. But as churchly institutions grow older they soon come to see themselves both as the preservers of orthodoxy and the centers of power through which the Spirit must work. In this process they develop elitist, often rigid, models of leadership selection and training. Thus they implicitly deny the declaration in Acts 2, "I will pour out my Spirit on all flesh," where young and old, men and women, and even slaves, are said to receive the gifts of the Spirit. These gifts are given primarily for ministry within the People of God and in the world beyond. Thus the rise of movements of renewal and mission on the periphery is first of all, a demonstration of the freedom of the Spirit to call and use whomever he will. Secondly it is a demonstration of the creativity that God has placed in every human being, gifts of vision and leadership that are brought alive and developed especially as a result of a powerful, life transforming encounter with Him.

A recent description of the 'edge' by EFMA President Paul McKaughan, points to the same phenomenon.

> The edge is a monumental place. People used to think the edge was the place where one fell off into the abyss. Today we know the edge is the place where innovation takes place. The edge is the place where the impetus for renewal always starts. It is at the edge that transforming mission happens. The edge is that location where Biblical faith encounters the belief systems of those who do not acknowledge Christ as Lord. This same faith also impacts its own culture. In that encounter the Holy Spirit applies his word and we as instruments of his grace are enriched with new understanding of what it means to be followers of our Lord and at the edge whole societies are being transformed by the power of the good news. (Bush 2003:1).

Church history gives us many examples of this. In the medieval period the Church rejected two of the most powerful streams of evangelism and mission. The first, the Waldensian movement was initiated by a layman with little formal education, while the Lollard movement in fifteenth century England was started by John Wyclif, an Oxford professor. Two of the three greatest Roman Catholic missionary orders, the Franciscans, Dominicans, and Jesuits, were initiated by laymen. Francis of Assisi and Ignatius Loyola were both laymen when they established their orders. St. Dominic was a well-educated priest. I am sure that an examination of history would show that at least half of the movements of renewal and/or mission have been initiated by laypersons.

Peripheral movements are always a challenge to the status quo, whatever that

may be, both in the church and the broader society. The challenge comes not only from their origin on the margins, often by men and women with little or no status. It also comes from their message that seeks to reach and empower people on the margins as they go to those outside the traditional church, and addresses them in their common idiom. Thus their style usually violates the accepted modes of speech. One commentator wrote regarding the Puritan, John Bunyan, whose Pilgrim's Progress has been more widely translated than any book other than the Bible.

> In literature, no less than religion, Bunyan has always offended the establishment. The appeal of his coarse, speech-patterned English is not polite, he breaks the canon. It is obvious that his goal was not to follow contemporary canons of style, but to speak to the people of his day by using a variety of common expressions that came from their daily life (Sharrock 1965:vii).

It is worth noting that the creativity of those on the periphery can be seen in almost every area of human endeavor, including technology. In the recent celebrations of the feat of the Wright brothers (sons of a pastor) who invented the first airplane in 1903, an interesting fact has come to light. The United States government made a grant of $50,000, to Samuel Langley, Secretary of the Smithsonian Institution, to finance the invention of a 'heavier than air' craft. But his aircraft, launched nine days before that of the Wrights, crashed and was never successful. However the two bicycle repairmen, dreaming and experimenting in their shop in Dayton, Ohio, succeeded where the well financed man from the prestigious institution failed. Perhaps there is a lesson for the Church here.

We can also argue that the Church has shown the greatest vitality and creativity when it has remained on the periphery of the broader culture, and resisted the all too human tendency to focus inward on itself, instead of looking outward toward the world. And the fact that such movements have arisen on the periphery has led them to have much greater contact with the world around them, leading them to be more effective in evangelism and often more sensitive to social problems. Now, as we see how movements of renewal and mission have arisen on the edge of the established churchly structures in the past, we discover that this continues to be the case today. Indeed, this phenomenon which we observe throughout history, can be seen even more today as we observe new growing streams of church and mission in the latter part of the twentieth and into the new century.

I believe that as these new movements emerge, the Church is being reshaped to an extent not seen since the sixteenth century and perhaps even more so. This is especially true in Asia as well as Africa and Latin America. I suspect it will take place more and more in North America and Europe in the future. This shift is taking place as we move into a post-

christendom, post-denominational and post-western period of church history. This will seem threatening to members of more traditional churchly structures. But it is clear that we are witnessing a creative new burst of the work of the Holy Spirit today. We see it primarily in new movements like those we will examine later. These groups seek to return to a simpler model of the Church, similar to what they believe they find in the New Testament. Their flexibility and success in communicating the Gospel with greater relevance to their cultures help them serve as examples for the more traditional churches.

THE EARLY CHURCH

After Pentecost the early Church began to take shape as part of the Jewish community in Jerusalem and understood itself primarily as the New Israel. Apparently at first it did not understand its mission in universal terms. It was Philip, a Hellenistic Jewish convert, rather than one of the Apostles, who first took the message beyond the Jewish community. Led by the Spirit, he went first to the despised Samaritans, then to the Ethiopian eunuch. The conversion and baptism of Cornelius and his household in Acts 10 were brought about by a special word of the Holy Spirit, both to Peter and the Roman centurion. This was important. However because of the prominence and piety of Cornelius, a 'God fearer,' the church probably considered that to be a unique and not necessarily repeatable event. But it opened the way for the most important missiological breakthrough in history when unnamed Hellenistic Jewish believers from Cyprus and Cyrene told the message to Gentiles as well as Jews in Antioch. This resulted in the formation of a church that included both groups. That was a scandal to many Jewish believers since it violated Jewish law, which prohibited Jews from eating with Gentiles. Yet the formation of this Jewish/Gentile church initiated the mission to the rest of the world. This seminal event eventually led to the world wide missionary movement that has led to the existence of churches now flourishing among peoples we could not have imagined a century ago.

Soon Saul/Paul, a former persecutor of the Church, considered suspect by Jerusalem, entered the picture at Antioch, brought there by Barnabas. It was from that church, not Jerusalem, that the first intentional mission to the Gentiles was launched, led by these two. Paul, who soon became the greatest missionary/theologian of the early church and indeed in all of church history, was one of the greatest surprises of the Holy Spirit. He was a marginal person, not one of the original twelve, having been 'born out of due time.' Furthermore he had been a Pharisee, a member of the group that opposed Jesus most vehemently.

The mission of Barnabas and Saul to Asia Minor led to the first theological crisis of the early Church, described in Acts 15. The issue was whether Gentile converts to Jesus, the Jewish Messiah, should be required to follow Jewish law and become

circumcised in order to become His disciples. There were really two issues at stake here. The first was theological. Were Gentiles (and Jews) saved by faith plus the works of the law, or by faith alone? The second issue was missiological. Was it necessary for Gentiles to become culturally Jewish in order to become authentic followers of Jesus? The answer wisely affirmed salvation by faith alone. The Church also asserted that Gentiles did not have to leave their own cultures as they followed Jesus, but it insisted that they avoid the sexual immorality rampant in those cultures and asked them to be sensitive to their Jewish brothers in questions of diet. This is an example of the way in which the Christian community has often been forced to reexamine and reevaluate its theology when the Gospel has moved across new cultural barriers. It also raised the question of contextualization. How much of the culture of the missionary should be imposed on new groups who respond to the Gospel message.

THE CONSTANTINIAN ERA

While new initiatives in mission had arisen on the periphery of the Church even at the beginning, this phenomenon became even more necessary after the beginning of the Constantinian era early in the fourth century. That was followed by the recognition of the Church as the official religion of the Roman Empire in 380. This established the christendom model of the Church that assumed that the state would be Christian and all of its citizens would be baptized. An advantage of this model was the hope that the state would be guided by Christian principles. The disadvantages were the temptations of corruption among leaders in the Church as it became powerful, and widespread nominalism among the people. And it brought about a radical change in the Church's understanding of its nature and mission.

> As the church became established it lost its sense of missionary purpose. Increasingly, the claim was made that lands governed by Christian kings were Christianized. The church was seen as an institution responsible for the pastoral care of the citizenry and to help maintain public order (Shenk 2003:I-20),

Consequently, except for mission through military conquest, virtually all extension of the Christian faith beyond the Roman Empire was led by groups that were not recognized as legitimate by Rome or Constantinople.

The Celtic movement arose in Ireland around 430 and spread to Scotland, England, and then to the continent. It constituted the most vital and effective missionary endeavor of the early Middle Ages. In earlier monasticism, the cloister was a place of retreat from the world where the monks were to concentrate primarily on achieving their own salvation. But the Celts were different. For them the monastery was the place where young men and women were prepared spiritually and intellectually for mission. In addition to

their missionary passion the Celts and their spiritual descendents demonstrated great intellectual and devotional vitality and sensitivity to the indigenous cultures that they encountered. Not only did the movement arise on the geographical frontier of Christendom, but its relationship to Rome was tenuous at best. Celtic leaders were finally persuaded to accept the authority of Rome at the Synod of Whitby in 664. Yet the Celts, not Rome, were responsible for the evangelization of Ireland and the tribes of Scotland, as well as the non-Romanized inhabitants of England. Moving on to the continent they became a renewing element in the church of the 'Holy Roman Empire' and led to the evangelization of new peoples in Friesland and Germany.

The Nestorian movement in the East was considered heretical by Rome and Constantinople after the christological controversies. But it demonstrated far greater missionary passion than leaders at either center. In the sixth century the Nestorian missionary school in Mesopotamia numbered over 1000 students. Nestorians spread the faith, working as merchants and physicians as well as monks and priests. They arrived in India in the sixth century. Their mission to the Huns and Uighurs in central Asia evangelized, reduced the languages to writing, and improved agriculture. Alopen, a Nestorian, arrived in China in 635 where he established churches and monasteries. This heroic movement was finally all but exterminated by the Islamic conquests and the massacres of Tamerlane.

The twelfth century Waldensians constituted a third group in which a new concept of the church and its mission emerged. Like many such movements, it was led by a layman and persecuted for centuries by the dominant church. In its attempt to return to a simple New Testament model of the Church it developed new forms of worship and leadership, and recognized the gifts of lay women as well as men. Waldensians were ardently missionary as they spread their understanding of the Gospel across much of southern and central Europe. Although the movement was nearly destroyed by persecution, remnants of the group later joined with the spiritual descendants of John Huss and became the nucleus of the eighteenth century Moravians. The tiny Moravian community, with roots in the two medieval movements lived as a committed community on the periphery of the German Lutheran Church, and became the primary catalyst of the Protestant missionary movement.

Also arising on he periphery were two thirteenth century missionary movements that were endorsed, perhaps reluctantly, by the medieval Church. One was led by Francis, a relatively uneducated layman, the other by Dominic, a priest who had been mentored by a reforming bishop. Some scholars doubt that Francis of Assisi and his group of unconventional followers would have been accepted by the church if it had not been for the lessons learned by the rejection of the Waldensians and the fact that the powerful Cardinal and future

pope, Ugolino, endorsed the order. It was probably easier for the hierarchy to accept the Dominicans even though their methodology of winning the "heretic" with the word instead of the sword, was contrary to the practice of much of the church in that period.

These two groups formulated a new understanding of the monastic ideal, similar to that of the Celts. The monastery would not be primarily a place to retreat from the world, it would be a center where men (and soon women) would be prepared spiritually and theologically and sent into mission. Before long, Franciscans, including St Francis himself, went to Muslim lands where a number of them were martyred. By the end of the century, another Franciscan, John of Montecorvino, arrived in China. Soon there was a chain of mission stations established by Franciscans and Dominicans stretching from Europe to China and into India. Raymond Lull, a dissolute member of the court until his conversion, joined the Franciscans late in life. His concern was to see all persons won to the Christian faith. He wrote voluminously and called on the Church to establish an institution where future missionaries would study 'oriental' languages. This was the first call to the Church to begin to prepare missionaries who would study the languages and cultures of non-Christian peoples. Lull made three missionary trips to North Africa where he was finally stoned to death.

The third great Roman Catholic missionary order was established by Ignatius Loyola, also a layman. After the former soldier was rejected in his attempts at ministry (and even imprisoned) in Spain and Palestine, he finally enrolled in the University of Paris in 1534. There he gathered around him six others who formed the nucleus of the future Jesuit order. The missionary purpose of this group, originally led by a layman, was explicit. Once approved by the Pope they vowed to be obedient to him 'for the good of souls and the propagation of the faith in whatever countries he might wish to send them, whether to Turks or other infidels, India, lands of heretics, schismatics, or faithful Christians.' Three of the greatest Roman Catholic missionaries were Jesuits: St. Francis Xavier, who went to India and Japan, Ricci in China, and de Nobili in India.

THE REFORMATION ERA

How did the Protestant Reformation of the sixteenth century and the churches which resulted from it, fit into this pattern? Its two greatest leaders were a hitherto obscure German monk and a French would-be humanist scholar. We can understand why the Reformers insisted that pastors had university education. They were theologians and the rediscovery of biblical theological insights was essential in the Reformation. They were also reacting against the ignorance of most medieval priests. But this did lead to a more institutionalized, elitist model of training. And it ran the risk of making pastors functionaries of the state.

It is not correct to say that neither Luther nor Calvin demonstrated any missionary passion. A number of Luther's former students took the Lutheran Reformation to the Scandinavian countries where they translated the Scriptures and produced theological literature in the vernacular languages. And Calvin prepared over 160 pastors in Geneva who were sent to France, the Low Countries, Hungary, and Poland. Many were martyred. However the Reformers did not send any missionaries beyond Europe except for the abortive French Huguenot mission to Brazil in 1555. We can understand some of the reasons for their lack of mission outside of Europe. Protestants were struggling for survival in a hostile and dangerous environment. And Spain and Portugal, both Catholic nations, were the maritime powers at the time. But a more fundamental reason was that the Lutherans, Anglicans, and Calvinists still operated with a christendom understanding of the Church, seeking to continue the Constantinian pattern in the areas where they were dominant. Their theology and church structures would be different from those of the Medieval Church, but the older concept of the Church, which included all of the citizens, continued.

The 'left wing' of the Reformation, the Evangelical Anabaptists, rejected the christendom model. Instead the Church was to be composed of highly committed, gathered communities of adult believers existing within, but separate from the dominant culture. This different understanding of the Church and the Christian life motivated them to great missionary activity within Europe, despite terrible persecution. A number of emphases of this group would be picked up in subsequent renewal movements in the dominant Reformation churches. They included the insistence on the necessity of conversion, greater stress on an authentic life of discipleship, and the importance of committed Christian communities. And in contrast to the university system of the Reformers, Anabaptists used more contextualized, grassroots models of training their leaders. In this they were similar to the earlier Waldensians. It is important to note that we see many of their most important characteristics in the emerging streams of mission and church today.

A century after the Reformation the dominant Protestant churches showed no interest in mission outside of their own geographical boundaries. Indeed some Lutheran theologians taught that the Apostles had offered the Gospel to the whole world in the first century and that consequently the church had no more missionary obligation. The classical Reformation definition that the true Church existed 'where the Word is rightly preached and the Sacraments properly observed,' was also a factor. Tragically it left out the missionary dimension of the church. It was logical then that there was no place in classical Protestantism for mission structures that would be analogous to the Roman Catholic

monastic communities. Pastors were functionaries of the state, ordained to local parishes and were to maintain the christendom model as they cared for their people.

This helps us understand why the four movements that formed the foundation for the Protestant missionary movement all arose on the periphery of the established churchly structures and experienced considerable opposition from them.

THE BEGINNING OF PROTESTANT MISSIONS

Puritanism arose in England in an attempt to 'purify' the church and move the Anglican reformation in a more Calvinistic direction. Puritans sought conversion and a serious Christian life over against the nominalism of most in England. They advocated greater lay participation in church governance and wanted godly, well-trained pastors living in each parish. In their concern for Christian community and the study of Scripture, they established small groups, or 'conventicles' to meet these needs. Their conviction that a converted and renewed Christian community should transform society led them to establish schools for the poor. Puritanism eventually fragmented between Anglicans, Presbyterians, Congregationalists, Baptists, Quakers, and others. But the movement produced the first Protestant missionaries to the New World. Three generations of the Puritan Mayhew family worked on Martha's Vineyard, off the coast of Massachusetts. They established an 'Indian' church and advocated the ordination of indigenous pastors. John Eliot arrived in Roxbury in 163l, learned the language of the Algonquin people, and saw the church among them grow to over 3000. His translation of the Scriptures into their language was the first Bible printed in North America. Eliot and other missionaries often became advocates of the rights of the Native Americans over against European settlers. And the missionary and anti-slavery work of the Quakers is well known.

Pietism arose in Germany in the latter third of the seventeenth century, influenced in part by Puritanism.
Its primary leaders were Philip Spener and August Hermann Francke, The movement was severely criticized by most of the leadership of the established Lutheran Church. But Spener recovered Luther's understand of faith, defining it as personal trust as well as correct belief. This led to a more activist understanding of the Christian life. Consequently, like the Puritans, the Pietists preached the necessity of conversion and serious discipleship. Their primary means was the small group for Bible study, prayer, and mutual encouragement. They were often criticized because in that class conscious society, a nobleman and a servant might sit around the same table as they studied together. At a time when much of the preaching involved theological polemics, Pietists wanted pastors to be spiritual leaders who would nurture their flocks. Especially under Francke, the movement

took steps to change society and engage in mission to Asia. Francke established schools for poor children, including girls, an orphanage, and an organization to distribute the Bible inexpensively. In 1702 he established the Theological College for Oriental Studies, the first Protestant institution devoted to missionary education.

In 1706, with the support of the King of Denmark, two Pietist graduates of the University of Halle, Bartholomeu Ziegenbalg and Heinrich Plutshau, became the first Protestant missionaries to India. Up to this time chaplains were sent by the colonial powers to minister only to Europeans in Asia. Protestant missionaries were not sent to the Asian peoples. When the German church refused to ordain the two men as missionaries they were ordained in Copenhagen. The other Europeans in India, including the chaplains, rejected them. Nevertheless, Ziegenbalg, especially, had a remarkably holistic ministry. Before his death in 1719. He translated the New Testament and part of the Old into Tamil, saw the church grow to over 300 converts, and began the preparation of Indian pastors. As a result the first Indian Protestant pastor was ordained in 1733. In their concern for social change the Pietist missionaries established schools for girls as well as boys. They also encouraged economic development and established an industrial school. After Ziegenbalg died in 1719, the mission continued, sending over fifty workers to India during the century. These included the first two medical missionaries to Asia. At a time when denominational walls were very high, with some Lutherans denouncing Calvinists as heretics, Pietism demonstrated a remarkable ecumenical spirit. This can be seen in the correspondence between Francke, Cotton Mather, a New England Congregationalist, the Anglican chaplain in the Court of St. James in England, and Ziegenbalg. The focus of their correspondence was the dawn of the missionary era and cooperation in world mission. This prefigured later movements of cooperation.

'Religious societies' were formed beginning in 1671 in England under the leadership of Anthony Horneck a German who was appointed to the Savoy Chapel in London. Thomas Bray, an Anglican priest and friend of Francke, was closely associated with them. In 1699 Bray and a group of laymen established the first Anglican missionary society, the Society for the Propagation of Christian Knowledge (SPCK). It worked among English settlers, slaves, and 'Indians,' primarily in North America. Two years later Bray and his associates established the Society for the Propagation of the Gospel (SPG), which had a more international focus. Both groups evangelized, established schools for poor children, and were involved in various social ministries. The SPCK also published Christian literature, especially for youth. The father of John and Charles Wesley participated in one of the 'religious societies.' They

became the precursor of the 'Holy Club' at Oxford.

The Moravians exhibited many of the characteristics of the earlier movements that we see in emerging streams today. Zinzendorf, their great leader, was raised by a Pietist grandmother. Spener was his godfather. At the University of Halle he was the leader in organizing the 'Order of the Mustard Seed' after the visit of Ziegenbalg in 1713. Two of its goals were to take the Gospel where it had never been heard, and to work for the renewal of the Church. In 1722 a group of religious refugees, spiritual descendants of the Hussites and Waldensians, settled on his estate and named their community Herrnhut, the Lord's Watch. Others joined them from various traditions and soon they were divided and quarreling over various issues.

Zinzendorf and the Pietist pastor began teaching on the importance of unity as they studied the first letter of John. They visited each home. This was followed by a period of prayer and fasting. On August 13, 1727 they experienced their 'Pentecost' as they celebrated the Lord's Supper. They initiated a prayer watch around the clock that lasted one hundred years. They were transformed into a highly disciplined community, committed to the world mission of Christ. They became a unique fellowship of men and women, laity and clergy. The goal of the group as a whole was the spread of the Christian message to the whole world. A report in 1739 mentioned sixteen locations where they served in Asia, Africa, North America, and the Caribbean. In addition they served in several areas in Europe, including the Baltic States and Russia. By 1760 the number of missionaries had grown to 226. They served with great sacrifice, some were imprisoned, and many died. Missionaries were expected to support themselves, and most were laypersons, with women as well as men in leadership roles. They purposely refrained from establishing Moravian churches in areas where others existed. They preferred to work for renewal in existing Lutheran and Anglican communities.

In their concern for contextualization they encouraged indigenous music. Converts from many cultures were encouraged to write their own hymns and these were published in Moravian hymnbooks and celebrated in multi-cultural worship back at Herrnhut. They taught slaves to read, cared for widows and orphans, nursed the sick, and translated the Scriptures and other Christian literature into many languages. They encouraged converts to become teachers and elders. But they made their greatest contribution as the primary catalyst of the Protestant missionary movement. Their influence on John Wesley is well known. The Basel and Leipzig missionary societies, the Methodist missionary enterprise, and the London Missionary Society were all stimulated and to some extent guided by the Moravians. And in 1792 William Carey cited their example when he proposed the formation of the Baptist Missionary Society.

The Evangelical awakenings on both sides of the Atlantic in the eighteenth century continued the emphases of the previous movements and led to what has been called 'the great century of mission' in the nineteenth century. The most prominent leaders of this multi-faceted movement were John Wesley in England and Jonathan Edwards in New England. George Whitfield itinerated in both areas. But it was really Wesley, the Oxford don, who began to construct a new form of the church. This devout, austere Anglican priest came to a new understanding of the Gospel and experience of grace through the influence of Moravians.

Soon most Anglican pulpits closed to him because of his 'enthusiasm.' Then, as he wrote, he resolved to become 'vile' and preach outside the walls of the traditional church buildings. But in the streets and fields, the poor, alienated from the institutional church, heard him gladly. Wesley was soon presented with a serious dilemma; how to nurture the new converts and prepare leadership for the growing movement. Converts could find no place to meet their needs in the existing church, nor could the Anglican system produce the kind of leadership needed. Thus without intending to do so, he began to reinvent the church. It would consist of networks of small groups, or classes, communities of believers who cared for each other. The classes, adopted from the Moravians, fulfilled three primary functions: the nurture and discipline of new converts, stewardship, (since each contributed a penny a week), and leadership training. In some cases women as well as men served as class leaders. And as the movement grew and there was need for more preachers, those who had demonstrated the necessary gifts became itinerant evangelists. Eventually they were ordained to baptize and serve Communion. Although Wesley refused to admit it, this constituted a de facto separation from the Anglican Church.

Thus, like the Moravians the early Methodist movement went beyond Puritanism and Pietism as it blurred the line between clergy and laity, and began to select and train its leaders from the grassroots. In doing so it rejected the more elitist system of leadership training used by the traditional Reformation churches. This reshaping of the church represented a significant degree of re-contextualization. As we noted in some earlier movements, (Waldensians, Anabaptists), the Gospel message was communicated by those with little or no status in the institutional church. And the message was taken to those on the margins of society, often in the streets and fields. New music was created, especially in the many hymns written by Charles Wesley. Methodism and the broader awakening of which it was a part brought significant social reform to England. And soon Methodist missionaries were sent to the West Indies and North America.

These four movements originated in different contexts but had similar emphases. And they formed the foundation of the modern Protestant

missionary movement. Without intending to do so they all began to move toward a post-christendom model of the Church. All four arose on the periphery of the dominant ecclesiastical structures of their day; they all focused on the necessity of conversion and an authentic Christian life, and each one demonstrated special compassion for the poor. The latter two movements demonstrated two additional factors that are very important in new movements today: great flexibility in church structures and new methods of selecting and training leaders that did not depend on older institutional models. Here the Reformation slogan of the priesthood of all believers moved from doctrine to practice as the distinction between clergy and laity was blurred and the gifts of the latter, men, and at times, women, were recognized. Finally, all four of these movements initiated mission beyond their own shores. The Protestant missionary movement began here.

Thus at the end of the eighteenth century, motivated by the revivals, a number of Protestant mission societies were formed in the British Isles, on the Continent and later in the United States. Because none of the classical forms of church government had any place for mission structures, these groups were formed as 'voluntary societies,' supported and governed by interested clergy and laymen. None was sponsored by any official church body. A minority of English Baptists supported Carey's Baptist Missionary Society, established in 1792. The London Missionary Society, founded in 1795, was sponsored by a group of Congregationalists, Presbyterians, and Anglicans. And the Anglican Church Missionary Society, established in 1799, by a group of clergy and laity motivated by the revivals, would not be recognized as legitimate by the bishops for fifty years. The same characteristics were seen in the various Scottish and continental societies, and the Tract and Bible societies, established early in the next century.

Indeed, William Carey, rightly called the Father of the Protestant missionary movement, would not have been ordained in any of the older churches. This cobbler and self-taught schoolmaster was rejected for ordination on his first two attempts by, the Particular Baptists, the group to which he belonged. This genius, who overcame incredible obstacles and accomplished so much in Bible translation, evangelism, social reform, and educational work in India, stands as one of the greatest examples of the creativity of the Holy Spirit through a person and movement from the periphery.

The missionary movement from the newly formed United States was motivated by a student prayer meeting under a haystack in 1806. This led to the establishment of the American Board of Commissioners for Foreign Missions (ABCFM) in 1810 It came in response to the initiative of the students, now at Andover Seminary. Congregationalists and Presbyterians cooperated in the board, which appointed its first missionaries to Asia in 1812. The Baptists formed their board in 1814 after

Judson and Rice, two of the original ABCFM missionaries became Baptists on their voyage to India. Rice returned to the United States to tell American Baptists that since they now had a missionary couple, the Judsons, in Burma, they should support them. Feeling the need for greater denominational control, the Presbyterians formed their own board in 1837. Soon most American churches established their denominational mission boards and set standards for educational preparation and ecclesiastical loyalty. The period that Latourette called 'the great century of mission' was well underway. Through great sacrifice and devotion the early missionaries established churches, educational institutions, hospitals, and other social ministries, first in Asia, then in Africa and Latin America.

Most denominations in the United States embraced the concept of mission beyond their shores and formed their own boards but mission societies in Europe remained outside of the official church structures. However creative new initiatives continued to arise on the periphery of the older mission societies. The China Inland Mission, established in 1865 became the forerunner of a host of new "faith missions," which in most cases focused their attention on unreached geographical areas. The Sudan Interior Mission and the African Inland Mission are other examples. These and similar groups were multi-denominational at the beginning, even though most formed their own 'denominations' in areas where they worked. They were also more flexible in their standards of selection of personnel. Coming out of Victorian England, J. Hudson Taylor, founder of the China Inland Mission, accepted single women as well as married couples and 'manned' some mission stations in the interior of China with these women. Another factor in the formation of the 'faith missions' was the fundamentalist reaction against the perception of growing theological liberalism in the older denominational groups.

The most remarkable new impulse toward mission in the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries came from the lay led Student Volunteer Movement (SVM). Born out of a student conference in Northfield, Massachusetts in the summer of 1886, it was motivated primarily by recent college graduates, Grace and Robert Wilder, and a YMCA secretary, Luther Wishard. The Wilders were son and daughter of former missionaries to India who had been motivated to service by the earlier student movement. The major speaker at the conference was D.L. Moody, the lay evangelist, the other was a Presbyterian pastor, A.T. Pierson. Its greatest leader was John R Mott, a Methodist layman. In 1890 there were 934 Americans serving as Protestant missionaries in foreign lands, by 1915 the number had increased nearly ten-fold, to 9072, primarily as a result of the SVM (Hogg,1976:374).

The Welsh revival from 1904 to l905, was unique as it arose in a economically depressed corner of the United Kingdom among people who spoke a strange

language and were generally disdained by the dominant majority. Its key figure was a young layman with little formal education. Yet the revival brought 100,000 additional people into the churches, stimulated the sending of missionaries, and influenced movements in distant places, ranging from Los Angeles, to Korea, to Northeast India.

The Pentecostal movement arose in 1906 in a broken down livery stable on Azusa Street in Los Angeles. Led initially by an African American Holiness preacher with little formal training, it soon began to plant the most rapidly growing churches among the urban poor in Latin America and elsewhere. Interracial at first, the movement grew out of the conviction that the Holy Spirit was active and available to all believers today. As its name implies, it focused heavily on the events of the day of Pentecost described in Acts 2. This led to a remarkable surge of missionary activity led by laypersons, both men and women, most of whom had little or no training or status in the organized churches. This remarkable movement often led to unusual manifestations of people being 'slain in the Spirit,' and glossalalia, much like revivals of the past. Often there were claims of healings and other miraculous activity. The Methodists and Baptists had roots in somewhat similar movements earlier, but had now become quite institutionalized and respectable. They were disdainful of Pentecostalism and predicted its early demise. Yet most scholars would agree that this has been the most rapidly growing form of the Christian faith in the twentieth century.

Without necessarily intending to do so, Pentecostalism picked up many emphases of the earlier peripheral movements. Its leaders were motivated by a powerful new experience of the reality of God in their lives, in this case, focusing on the role of the Holy Spirit. Thus it rediscovered the New Testament belief that all believers are gifted, and encouraged ministry by those who were not formally trained. In most cases this included lay men and women who were not considered eligible for leadership by the existing churches. An impressive example was the ministry of Gunnar Wingren and Daniel Berg, two Swedish-American Baptists who were caught up in the movement. In response to a prophecy, they arrived in Belem, Brazil, in 1910. There they initiated the work that led to the establishment of the Assemblies of God in Brazil. It now numbers around twelve million adult members. The movement has been spread primarily by laymen with little or no formal training who have sacrificially demonstrated gifts and perseverance in evangelism. And the growth has taken place among the marginalized urban and rural poor who constitute a large proportion of Brazil's people.

Often those who were previously illiterate began to read the Bible avidly. They found in its pages the stories of men and women with whom they could identify. Especially in the Book of Acts they discovered the God who still works in the lives of His people, even the poor and marginalized.

From the beginning Pentecostals contextualized their worship. They were not afraid to write their own music, using guitars and other popular instruments in worship at a time when most other Protestants used European and North American hymns with piano or organ accompaniment.

Pentecostals in Latin America often found the recently arrived urban immigrants to be open to their message of a God who was alive and active in their lives here and now. Men and women who had fled from difficult circumstances in the hinterlands, only to be disillusioned with the poverty in the shantytowns of the cities, found hope in the Pentecostal message. People who had left their traditional communities behind discovered a new fellowship in the churches. And in hierarchical societies dominated by great class distinctions and Roman Catholic concepts of clergy-laity differences, the poor encountered a new sense of identity and self-worth as children of God. This made it possible for many to turn away from a fatalistic sense that they were helpless victims of forces beyond their control, and believe that they could be agents of change in their own lives. It is interesting to note that perhaps the most common saying in Brazil is 'Se Deus quiser,' (if God wills), which reflects a deep strain of fatalism among the poor in that society. The change in outlook from fatalism to hope naturally has implications for the kind of upward social mobility that had characterized the earlier Methodist movement. The danger is that it can also lead to the same kind of problems that have plagued Methodists and others, the drift toward institutionalization, rigidity, and a loss of zeal.

Other twentieth century revivals took place in Korea from 1903 to 1907, and East Africa, beginning in 1929. The first began among missionaries and soon the leadership passed to Korean laymen. The second was initiated primarily by a lay missionary and an African hospital worker. Both had far reaching effects in their own nations and beyond.

The discussion of the rise of peripheral groups in mission could be continued by examining the twentieth century and now the beginning of the twenty-first. The many new American mission agencies established since World War II, especially those of the last two decades, show many of the same characteristics. Groups such as Youth with a Mission and Operation Mobilization, which have called thousands of youth into short term and career missionary service are but two examples. The growth of new mission structures in Asia, Africa, and Latin America in recent decades is even more striking and now constitutes the most rapidly growing thrust of mission today.

What lessons can we learn from this survey of movements from the periphery? It is clear that we must be open to the surprises of the Holy Spirit who is infinitely creative! More often than not His initiatives have worked through unexpected people who have reached out

to marginalized groups using non-traditional methods. But if we look closely we will discover that whenever there has been an outburst of new life among the People of God, the methods that appeared non-traditional to the organized church have often been the norm, rather than the exception. To be open to the creative but surprising work of the Spirit is simply a way of affirming our belief in the sovereignty of God. Clearly He is not limited to our traditional ways of doing things. This also implies flexibility in how the Church is structured and leadership is selected and prepared.

Andrew Walls has written, "the voluntary (mission) society, by its very success, subverted the classical forms of church government while fitting comfortably into none of them." He continued, "From age to age it becomes necessary to use new means for the proclamation of the Gospel beyond the structures which unduly localize it" (Walls 2000: 247, 253). In the movements we have studied we have seen how constantly the new wine of mission has altered and at times, burst, the older wineskins of the institutional church. Furthermore in them we see a number of characteristics in common that I believe will be helpful in analyzing and guiding emerging streams of mission and church in the new century. Could it be that these emerging streams, arising today primarily in Asia, Africa, and Latin America will point the way to the renewal and restructuring of the Church in areas that were once called Christendom?

As we examine history we observe certain periods in which there seemed to be an extraordinary burst of power, in which the creativity of the Holy Spirit has led to renewal and mission. The Protestant Reformation was one such period, the end of the eighteenth and beginning of the nineteenth centuries, another. The beginning of the twentieth century was, I believe, another. Each of these was built on a foundation, when many were seeking a deeper understanding of faith and discipleship. The underground streams of piety in the fifteenth century, the revivals in the eighteenth century, and the holiness and other movements in the nineteenth century all helped prepare for the new missionary thrusts. I believe that late twentieth century missions, along with the Pentecostal/Charismatic movement, have built the foundation for an explosive expansion of the Gospel among previously marginalized and unreached groups in the new century. And the case studies that we will examine are typical of many such movements that are, for the most part, unknown to many. The most important lessons they teach us are to be flexible in our structures of church and mission, and above all, to be open to the surprises of the Spirit

In the next chapter we will examine in more detail, the characteristics of renewal movements in the past before we study some of the emerging streams today.

Chapter 2

Factors in Movements of Renewal and Mission

As we study movements that have resulted in renewal and mission in the past we can identify a number of characteristics that with few exceptions, all have in common. Here I will list them briefly and then expand and illustrate them.

1. They arise on the periphery of the institutional church.

2. They are motivated by a transforming experience with God, renewal at a personal or group level.

3. The result is the desire for a more authentic Christian life that often leads to concern for the Church and the world.

4. New spiritual dynamics are important, almost always in the form of face-to-face groups for prayer, study, and mutual encouragement.

5. As movements grow, new models of leadership selection and training become essential. These are more lay oriented and less institutionalized.

6. There are 'theological breakthroughs,' that is, rediscoveries of aspects of the Christian message that have been forgotten or ignored. These 'breakthroughs' usually involve a rediscovery of the gifts of every believer.

7. There is a leveling effect, distance decreases between clergy and laity, social classes, races, men and women, and denominations.

8. The movement is counter-cultural in some aspects, often because it reaches out to those who have not been valued by their societies.

9. As a result there will be opposition by many in the dominant culture and church.

10. There will be various manifestations of spiritual warfare. That is, such movements sense the reality of evil and the need to recognize the victory of Christ in the cross and resurrection.

11. At times there will be unusual manifestations of the power of the Holy Spirit, healings, prophecies, visions, glossalalia, etc.

12. More flexible structures of church and mission will be needed, different from the traditional ones.

13. The movement will be led into significant re-contextualization of the Christian message. This is seen as the Christian message is communicated, often by lay persons, outside the traditional church structures, to marginalized people. New music is often a characteristic, and the common language of the people is

used. Biblical concepts ignored by the traditional church but especially relevant to the hearers are rediscovered.

14. There will be growing concern for the marginalized, often expressed in ministries of compassion.

15. At a later stage this often leads to concern for broader social transformation.

16. The concern for mission leads to outreach beyond one's own culture, ethnic group, or nation.

17. As the movement matures, there will be concern for renewal of the broader church.

18. As the movement continues to mature, many will begin to see themselves, not only as part of their particular movement, but as citizens of the Kingdom of God, transcending their own movement.

19. Finally, every movement is less than perfect, and will be 'messy' around the edges and at times, at the center. This is inevitable as long as sinful human beings are involved in it.

Since chapter one discussed the importance of the periphery, we begin here with the second issue.

It is clear that mission flows out of renewal. I define this as a profound experience in which men and women have new encounter with God, focusing especially on His grace in their lives. This often comes during a crisis or after a long period of struggle. As a consequence they begin to feel God's heartbeat for the world. This leads them to seek a more authentic Christian life for themselves, and for the Church of which they participate. At times it leads to concern for the broader Church, but usually only after time. Such experiences have often motivated them to leave their places of security and comfort in order to take the Good News to others, often of other races and cultures. Like Abraham, they have gone to the new places that God would show them. They have also been able to communicate their vision to others and initiate growing movements.

Their experiences often follow the order of Isaiah 6:1-8. There the prophet entered the temple and had a powerful vision of the Holy and Transcendent God. This led to a deeper understanding of his own sin and that of his people. As he contemplated the reality of sin the heavenly messenger touched him with the reality of forgiveness and grace. We note the order here. It was after that experience that Isaiah overheard God saying, 'Whom shall we send, and who will go for us?'

As we have seen, this quest for God has often led to dissatisfaction with the nominalism and superficiality of much of the life of the dominant church. We see this especially in the early Puritans and Pietists.

Often we can see a definite order here. First, the person or group has concentrated on a deeper life of communion with God in prayer. Then they have begun to understand and respond obediently go His redemptive purpose for the world. Thirdly they have sought renewal in the broader Church, stressing the need of conversion and authentic Christian discipleship among church members. The fourth focus has been outward toward the broader society. As time has passed, such movements have led to ministries of compassion to the marginalized, and eventually attempts at social transformation in their own cultures. Finally, although not always in that order, these movements have resulted in mission beyond their own nations and cultures. Usually the concern for evangelism has taken precedence followed by ministries of compassion with the concern for broader social transformation coming somewhat later. However we recognize that often movements have not gone all the way through this process. At times persecution has been a factor. This was the case with the Waldensians and early Puritans, for example. At other times inadequate theology has been a reason, as we will see in some of the movements we examine.

Peter Waldo's conscience bothered him, A cloth merchant, he had charged usury, which violated the laws of the Medieval Church. As he sought forgiveness he commissioned a translation of the Gospels and other books into the vernacular language. These included works of Augustine, Jerome, Ambrose, and Gregory. Reading them led him to give his possessions to the poor, begin to preach in the streets, and initiate his twelfth century movement. We see the same dynamic in the young Zinzendorf, who contemplated a painting of the crucified Christ, and responded, 'I have but one passion, it is He, and He alone.' Then as he led the struggling, quarreling community at Herrnhut, into a period of study of I John, prayer, and fasting, they experienced the 'Moravian Pentecost' on August 13, 1727. That event led the community into widespread, sacrificial missionary activity with few, if any parallels in the history of the Church.

John Wesley was a zealous and devout leader of the 'Holy Club' at Oxford. But he wrote in his Journal that he went to Georgia as a missionary with the hope of 'saving his soul.' The transforming experience that led to the Methodist movement came in a small group meeting under the influence of Moravians at Aldersgate Street. Wesley wrote that as the leader read the preface of Luther's Commentary on Romans,

> I felt my heart strangely warmed, I felt I did trust in Christ, Christ alone for salvation, and an assurance was given me that He had taken away my sins, even mine, and saved me from the law of sin and death (Walker 1959:459)

That experience motivated him to go outside the structures of the traditional

church, to take his message to the poor in the streets and fields. Jonathan Edwards was raised in a stern New England Calvinistic home. After a long period of youthful struggle, he again read a familiar passage, I Timothy 1:17. 'Now unto the King eternal, invisible, the only wise God, be honor and glory forever and ever.' He wrote that as he read those words,

> There came into my soul, and was as it were diffused through it, a sense of the glory of the divine being, a new sense, quite different from anything I had ever experienced before.

Soon afterward he wrote that as he was walking in the field and "looked up on the sky and clouds, there came into my mind a sweet sense of the glorious majesty and grace of God, that I know not how to express" (Marsdon 1999:41,42).

Edwards became the primary spiritual and intellectual leader of the Great Awakening in colonial America. This led to the beginning of the American missionary movement seventy years later. Edwards was also the spiritual and intellectual mentor of Samuel Hopkins, one of the earliest leaders of the anti-slavery movement in the United States.

Often such experiences have come during a time of crisis and change. In Isaiah's case, it was the year that King Uziah died, ending a long period of peace and relative prosperity. As a cloth merchant, Peter Waldo symbolized the beginning of the transition from feudalism to the new economy of manufacturing and trade in Western Europe. It is not coincidental that the father of St. Francis was also a cloth merchant. Pietism and Moravianism arose in Germany over a century after the Protestant Reformation. The Thirty Years War had devastated most of Germany and most of the original vitality of Luther's movement had been lost. England in Wesley's day saw great distinctions of class and wealth, with large numbers of the poor living in the most miserable circumstances in the cities. And in general the Anglican Church was in a deplorable state.

The original Puritan dream in New England was to be a 'city set on a hill' that would demonstrate to the world a society whose goal was to glorify God. By the time Edwards began his ministry the dream had faded. Puritanism had lost its original vitality, leaving behind a legalistic shell with little understanding of grace. As one writer put it, for Puritan New England, the goal had shifted from 'sainthood to respectability.' At the same time most European immigrants to colonial North America had left their Christian faith behind when they crossed the Atlantic. Only 6.9% of the population was church members.

Thus it was clear in each situation that a simple continuation of the older patterns of church life would be inadequate to respond to the needs of the new context. But in each case the traditional churches seemed either unwilling or incapable of doing so. Often they neither led their own

people to authentic discipleship nor could they reach out to those outside of their membership. Hence the need for new ways to communicate the Faith and new structures for discipleship.

But in every case, whether or not we can identify the particular crisis, we see the sovereign hand of God. The Holy Spirit has raised up new, unexpected leaders, who first sought to go deeper in their relationship with God, then begin to look at their churches and societies with new eyes. This would lead them, but not without mistakes and faltering steps, into new initiatives of renewal and mission.

Often there were specific aspects of the Gospel message that needed to be recognized and embraced in that particular context. For the Moravians, it was the need for unity. Hence Zinzendorf led his community in the study of the first letter of John, followed by periods of fasting and prayer. Wesley's movement rose during a period in which the Church of England was dominated both by sacramental theology and rationalism. The level of Christian understanding and life was extremely low among the masses as well as the nobility. Thus the rediscovery of salvation by grace alone and the call for an authentic Christian life, or 'scriptural holiness,' were essential aspects of Wesley's ministry. Edwards was concerned about the semi-Pelagianism he observed in New England. It was the tendency to identify the Christian faith and life with respectability. Hence his strong focus on justification by faith which triggered the awakening in Northampton. In both the Korean and East African revivals the need to overcome feelings of racial and cultural superiority on the part of missionaries and the consequent resentment by national believers had to be addressed. The 1929 prayer meeting in which Dr. Joseph Church, a Cambridge trained physician, and Simon Nsibambi, an African hospital worker, shared an experience of the 'power of Pentecost,' and had their 'hearts knit together,' was a significant trigger of the revival in East Africa.

Normally an immediate result has been a renewed focus on the study of Scripture by the laity. Where Scripture had been seen primarily as the source and authority for theology, its study became more personal and devotional and essential in private as well as public worship. Packer asserted that it was the Puritans who initiated the practice of family worship. The father was to be a priest in his home. Participants discovered that God still spoke to His people personally, guiding them in their daily lives and decisions as they sought to become serious and faithful disciples. Usually Bible study has been combined with small groups in which the men and women encouraged, challenged, and prayed for each other as they continued their Christian pilgrimage. We see examples in the Puritan 'conventicles.' the Pietist 'churches within the Church,' the Moravian 'bands,' and the Methodist 'classes.' The Korean revival from 1903 to 1907 resulted in thousands of men and women coming together for weeks at a time to study the Scriptures. They did so

during the period when the rice fields lay fallow and did not require much work.

Thus alongside the larger, more inclusive, formal worship of the Church, smaller face to face groups have been an essential feature. Such groups have provided greater opportunities for the ministry of lay men and women. The doctrine of the priesthood of all believers has become a reality. Often they have provided a place where laypersons and clergy met as equals as they prayed and worked together. And as those in the groups have shared with and prayed for each other, they have sensed the immediacy and relevance of God's activity in their lives at a profound level. Max Warren, former General Secretary of the Anglican Church Missionary Society, observed that such structures utilized in the East African Revival provided a 'middle term.' They were groupings of men and women in units large enough to overcome individualism but small enough to be flexible and creative in ways not possible for the larger church. Often as participants have studied Scripture and prayed together, the Holy Spirit has led them into new ministries. Over and over again they have repeated the experience of the Antioch church described in Acts 13.

A core value of all such movements as far as I can discern, has been the concern for effective leadership. It was essential that such leaders be deeply committed to Jesus Christ and His Gospel, and willing to be innovative and flexible in communicating the Gospel to those outside the Church. The Puritan and Pietist movements were concerned for godly, well-trained pastors. Both movements assumed the Christendom model of the Church and accepted the practice in which all pastors were prepared using the university model common in England and Germany at the time. But they went beyond the traditional concern for academic preparation alone, and stressed the cultivation of the life with God, primarily in small groups. And in a period when many Anglican priests did not live near their people and seldom if ever visited them, the Puritans stressed the importance of having well-prepared pastors resident in every parish. Thomas Bray, founder of the SPCK and SPG, worked to renew the quality of pastoral leadership for England and North America, in addition to sending missionaries to the unevangelized.

As movements moved beyond the Christendom understanding of the Church and reached new peoples either in their own culture or beyond it became clear that the traditional university model of leadership preparation was inadequate. It was far too limiting and elitist and tended to isolate the Church from the marginalized. The old wineskins could not possibly contain the new wine of new movements. The new criteria for leadership selection were not primarily social status or formal training. They were the recognition of demonstrated gifts, effectiveness in ministry, and on the job training.

Thus the Moravian and Methodist movements soon found it necessary to go beyond Puritanism and Pietism in recognizing the gifts of the laity. Much more than the classic Reformation churches, they put into practice the doctrine of the priesthood of all believers. While some Moravians were ordained to avoid conflict with Church and state in Germany at the time, the great majority of their leaders were lay persons, and women played prominent roles along with men. Perhaps the example of Zinzendorf's grandmother, who read her Bible in Hebrew and Greek, was an important influence! Zinnzendorf wrote about the ministry of Leonard Dober, a potter, who taught in his workshop. He said that many, learned and unlearned, commoners and nobles, came to hear Dober teach on the resurrection of the dead and the necessity of renewing the heart. The great majority of Moravian missionaries were laypersons.

This became even more important in early Methodism. Wesley, an Oxford don with the MA degree, was caught in the tension between continuing as a loyal Anglican priest, and initiating a movement among the poor that the traditional Church was unprepared and even unwilling to accept. Thus he was forced, almost against his will, to follow the leading of the Holy Spirit and meet the needs of the people. To do so he had to create new, more flexible forms of the Church and its leadership. He recognized that when his hearers expressed the desire in public to follow Christ, that was only the beginning of their Christian pilgrimage. Having borrowed the idea from the Moravians, he formed 'classes' of twelve believers, each with a leader and an assistant. It was in these 'classes' that the Christian journey continued. The groups had three primary functions. They led new believers into a life of discipleship, they encouraged stewardship as each gave a penny a week, and they provided the most significant means of leadership selection and training.

As the movement grew it soon became clear to Wesley that more preachers were needed. Encouraged by his mother, Wesley began to appoint laymen as preachers and eventually ordained them to baptize and serve the Eucharist. Even though Wesley did not want to admit it, this constituted a de facto break with the Anglican Church. But it is clear that the movement would have been greatly limited in its outreach and growth if Wesley had not done so. Even so, this did not mean that he did not recognize the need for adequate preparation for his pastors. Rather he created a model of selection and training from the grassroots up, rather than the top down. Indeed Wesley wrote a number of works to instruct his evangelists and expected them to study constantly. He even asserted that he believed they were better prepared for ministry than the men he had known at Oxford!

The rapid growth of the Methodist movement on the American frontier would have been impossible without the itinerant Methodist evangelists whose gifts had been recognized first in the classes before

they became itinerant preachers. They traveled widely, preaching their message wherever they found hearers. The Methodists, who numbered about 15,000 in the United States in 1784, grew to 1,361,000 by 1850. The Baptists, who selected their leaders mainly from 'farmer-preachers,' also grew rapidly during that period. We could make similar observations about the early Pentecostals and other movements today. The East African revival was spread primarily through laypersons. 'Bible women,' who were really unordained lay evangelists, played an important role in the early Korean Christian movement. A retired missionary once told me that many of the earliest churches in that country were established after someone was sick, a godly woman prayed, the person was healed, and the church was planted.

Thus it is clear that the issue of how leaders are selected and trained has been critical for vital new movements of church and mission. As time has passed however they have tended to become institutionalized and imitate the older churches in requiring more formal preparation for their leaders. While this has brought advantages in terms of biblical content and theological reflection, it has usually distanced such movements from their origins among the poor and marginalized, led to slower growth, and even stagnation. I believe that this is one of the most serious dilemmas that new movements must face. One issue is keep the doors open to leadership from the 'grassroots.' This will normally help to maintain vitality and contact with the poor and marginalized. The other is to encourage serious biblical/theological study, without moving away from the original values of the movement.

Theological 'breakthroughs' or rediscoveries often characterize new movements. One of the most important is the recognition of the continuing work of the Holy Spirit in the lives of individual believers as well as the Church today. Tragically the traditional church has often believed that the work of the Spirit was limited to the usual channels of ecclesiastical life. But renewal movements rediscover the Spirit's activity and relevance through unexpected persons, often in surprising ways. A corollary is that the movement begins to recognize and affirm the gifts of each layperson. The inclusiveness of the prophecy of Joel, quoted by Peter in Acts 2, becomes a reality. Old and young, men and women, even slaves, receive the Spirit and His gifts. And since the function of the gifts is primarily to contribute to the work of Christ within history, all believers are encouraged to share in that mission. This of course contributes to the new, more flexible methods of selecting and training leaders mentioned in the previous paragraph.

As a consequence, when the gifts of all believers for ministry are recognized, we see a leveling effect. Distance often decreases between clergy and laity, men and women, social classes, races, and denominations, especially when they reach out to the marginalized. The

institutional Church nearly always has a difficult time accepting this, preferring to maintain distance. The early Waldensian movement is a fascinating example. In the report of the Inquisition in France in the thirteenth century we read the following. Speaking of Waldo, it stated

> With little education, he ended up by usurping the prerogatives of the apostles. He dared to preach the gospel in the streets, where he made many disciples, both men and women, and compounded the arrogance by sending them out, in turn, to preach. These people, ignorant and illiterate, went about through the towns, entering houses and even churches, spreading many errors everywhere (Tourn 1989:11,12).

Their desire was simply 'to preach freely, according to the grace given by God to us.' For them, to preach freely meant that God had the liberty to choose those who would be His witnesses (Tourn 1989:15). And they included women as well as men among their preachers, which offended the clerical establishment of their time.

In a similar manner the early Pentecostal movement in Los Angeles scandalized many in church and society because William Seymour, an African American preacher who had little formal instruction, led it. Equally scandalous in that context was the fact that black and white, men and women, worshipped and ministered together. One white Holiness preacher from the southern part of the United States, said he was offended when a black deacon laid hands on him and prayed. Repentant, he added, 'The color line was washed away in the blood of the Lamb.' And many of the early Pentecostal leaders were women. However we must recognize that the movement quickly divided racially into two primary denominations, one white, the other black, as they began to conform to their surrounding culture. And the role of women in leadership declined significantly during the years.

The early Pietists were criticized because commoners and nobles sat together around the same table, along with their pastors, as they studied the Scriptures. The Duchess of Buckingham wrote to the Countess of Huntington, a supporter of Wesley, saying, 'These Methodist doctrines are most repulsive and strongly tinctured with impertinence and disrespect toward their superiors in a perpetual endeavor to level all ranks and do away with all distinctions.' And after his first wife who was a member of the nobility, died, Zinzendorf married a commoner. She served as an elder in the Moravian Church.

George Whitefield, an Anglican, was important in tying together the different geographical areas and denominations in the Great Awakening in colonial America. He worked especially with Edwards, a Congregationalist, and Gilbert Tennent, a Presbyterian. Most Anglicans in New England repudiated Whitefield and his ministry. But his message clearly

transcended denominational concerns and emphasized the necessity of conversion. We see this in one of his sermons when he addressed 'Father Abraham' in heaven. He asked, 'Whom do you have in heaven? Anglicans? Congregationalists? Presbyterians? Baptists?' The answer was no to all of these. 'Then whom do you have in heaven?' he continued, 'Only those who are washed in the blood of the Lamb,' was the reply.

Such movements are counter-cultural in most if not all, contexts. They threaten any established hierarchical orders in church and society that assumes an inalterable role for men and women that is determined by race, social class, or gender. Thus they fulfill to a significant extent the words of Mary. "He has...lifted up the lowly, he has filled the hungry with good things, and sent the rich away empty" (Luke 1:52,53). So it is not hard to understand why they bring opposition from the surrounding society and the dominant church. An aristocratic critic of the Waldensians wrote, "if we admit them, we shall be driven out." (Stark 2003:57) The Bishop of London criticized the Wesleyan movement, saying it was "guilty of annoying established ministers and drawing to itself the lowest and most ignorant people."

Those who find new life in such movements often move against the grain of their culture, discover their identity as sons and daughters of God through Christ, and begin to demonstrate upward social mobility. The story of Benedita da Silva is a powerful example. Granddaughter of a slave, with semi-literate parents, she was raised in poverty in a slum of Rio de Janeiro. After she had an experience of conversion and the power of the Holy Spirit in a Pentecostal church, she became active in community affairs and in 1986 was the first woman of African descent to be elected to the Brazilian congress. Later she was appointed a cabinet minister in the federal government (Cox 1995: 163ff).

Because we fight not only against flesh and blood, but against cosmic powers of this present darkness, against spiritual forces of evil (Eph. 6:12) we often see various aspects of spiritual warfare in new movements. This may take the form of persecution that seems totally irrational, increased demonic activity, unexpected illness, or even the death of key persons. On the other hand, it is not unusual to observe special manifestations of the power of the Holy Spirit such as healings, dreams, visions, exorcisms, clear words of guidance, and various physical manifestations, including glossalia, or tongues. These seem to occur especially where the Gospel is breaking through a major cultural or religious barrier, into a new group of people. We find these phenomena especially in cultures where traditional religion has been primarily associated with power. This has been an important aspect of Pentecostalism world wide, but not limited to that movement. The early Presbyterians in Korea, coming from a theological framework that taught the cessation of miracles after the Apostolic age, wrote of numerous accounts of healings and exorcisms in

their reports and letters back to the United States. And current research on conversions from Islam to Christian faith indicate that a large number of these have been motivated by visions, dreams, or healings (Woodberry 2003)

The re-contextualization of the Christian message coupled with more flexible structures of church and mission, are also characteristics of new movements. The older, more rigid structures assume the people will come to the institutional church to hear the message and worship in a traditional style. Newer movements seek to find the people where they are, often distant from, and even hostile to, the church. This implies greater flexibility of church structures and also the methods used to communicate the messge. A simple definition of contextualization deals with the following questions. Who communicates the Christian message? Where? To whom? How? And what aspects of the message become the main focus?

We have already looked at new, flexible forms of leadership. But when we ask who has communicated the message, two other examples are significant. In Korea, a woman had virtually no role outside her home. The exception was that 80% of the mudangs, practitioners of shamanism, were women. So the only acceptable function for women outside their home was religious in nature. This made it quite logical for the 'Bible women' to assume their role in evangelization. Small groups for planning and prayer were important in spreading the East African revival. They included both clergy and laity and worked alongside the more formal institutional structures of the Church. They were similar to the kinship groups that already existed in the culture. Thus their ministry was a logical outgrowth of a pre-existing structure.

When we discover where the message has been communicated, there are many examples. Of course the first is the early church, which had no buildings and normally met in homes. John Wesley's experience is helpful. He was raised in a culture where the established church and its ways of worship were assumed to be the norm. At first he could not imagine himself preaching outside the walls of the traditional church. As he wrote in his Journal,

> I could scarcely reconcile myself at first to this strange way of preaching in the fields, of which Whitefield set me an example on Sunday; having been all my life (till very lately) so tenacious of every point relating to decency and order that I should have thought the saving of souls almost a sin, if it had not been done in a church.

But the great majority of his sermons were given in the streets and fields where the poor, who would not normally enter the churches, heard him gladly. There are many more examples. Peter Waldo's lay preachers went out two by two through the European countryside, often disguised as

cloth merchants, preaching in the streets and homes. And their worship took place in homes, led by laypersons, with both men and women serving the sacraments. Wyclif's Lollards also went out two by two, wearing common clothing, to the villages of fifteenth century England. Even though the movement was terribly persecuted and eventually suppressed, it made a significant contribution and helped prepare for the more biblical aspects of the English Reformation.

We have already seen that renewal movements have typically taken the Good News to people alienated from the church in nominal Christian cultures in Europe and North and South America. But we have seen similar movements in cultures without a long Christian tradition, such as Korea and East Africa. Thus the dynamic of these movements is not limited to Christendom but also has important lessons for new, non- traditional movements in other societies. Often those who have accepted the message have been the poor, or those considered lower class. But there is evidence that they have also included others who were dissatisfied with the rigid status quo in their churches and societies and consequently seeking change in their lives.

The question of how the message is communicated is another important issue. During the Middle Ages there was almost no preaching. Only bishops and those to whom they gave permission, could preach. Very few bishops and even fewer priests did so. Consequently the preaching of the Waldensians and Lollards took place in a religious vacuum, at least as far as any meaningful understanding of the Gospel. Exposition of Scripture was the center of Puritan worship both in the church and conventicles. At a time when Anglican worship was rigid and liturgical, Whitefield was called 'the divine dramatist' as he portrayed Christ powerfully. And a Pentecostal sermon in Brazil often becomes a dialogue between preacher and hearers.

But perhaps even more important is the role of music in the communication of the Gospel and its relevance. Anthropologists have discovered that music plays an essential role in communicating traditions and values in most cultures. It is clear that it often communicates at a deeper level than the spoken word alone. It is powerful. It also differs from culture to culture. Hence music is needed that is genuinely indigenous. This means it must use the scales, rhythms, and instruments of the people, speak to their concerns, and express the message clearly in an idiom they can understand. The 1500 hymns of Charles Wesley were probably as important in the Methodist movement as the sermons and leadership of his brother. Often using popular tunes, the hymns communicated the theological themes just as powerfully as the sermons. And they became a channel through which the converts expressed the joy of their new faith. Pietism in Germany, Norway, and Denmark stimulated the writing of many hymns, and we have already noted the importance of music in the Moravian

movement. The chorus, 'We praise you Jesus,' became a trademark of the East African movement.

I was once invited to preach on a festive occasion in a large Assembly of God church in the interior of the state of Pernambuco, in Brazil. Plantations that cultivated sugarcane surrounded the town. During the worship celebration, various singing groups, composed of young men who worked on the plantations, came up and performed. They played homemade guitars and sang songs, many of which they had composed themselves. These had biblical themes, sung to simple tunes. It was genuinely indigenous music, expressing their own concerns and praising the God they had come to know in their fellowships and in Scripture. As we will see in some of the case studies, new music is often an important characteristic of the new streams of church and mission today.

As for the aspects of the message that received emphasis in these movements, I suggest that there are both generic elements, essential in any movement of renewal, and along with them, aspects of the Gospel especially relevant to the specific context. The generic elements always include as central themes, Jesus' Incarnation, cross, and resurrection, with its victory over death and evil. Then comes the offer of grace and salvation as a free gift. Often this has been a new discovery for those involved. Many have come from religious traditions that have forgotten or obscured this central aspect of the Gospel. The elements more specific to the culture will often vary. But almost always they include a strong focus on the value of every individual, created in the image of God, called to be His sons and daughters in Jesus Christ. This has often stood in contrast to the message of inferiority that their cultures have given them. It has been an essential theme in movements directed to the marginalized. The implication is that the poor will no longer be mere victims of forces beyond their control, but can become active agents in beginning to change their lives. For example, a common way of referring to the poor in Brazil is 'Jose Ninguem,' or 'Joe Nobody.' An important part of the Pentecostal message in the favelas (slums) of Brazilian cities was that Joe or Maria Nobody could become 'Somebody,' a person of value, with hope for the future, in Jesus Christ. The early Methodist preachers on the American frontier went to westward moving settlers. They were seeking land and the opportunity to carve out their own economic and political destiny, something not possible in Europe. The Arminian Methodist message, in contrast with Calvinism, was that these settlers could determine their spiritual destiny as well.

A different issue arose in the East African revival. The contrast was made between the blood of goats and the blood of Jesus. The sacrifice of goats was important in traditional religion and was revived as a test of anti-imperialism during the Mau Mau revolt against the British. Christians, often caught in between the two rival forces, wished to remain loyal to their tribe

and nation, but insisted that only the blood of Jesus was sufficient to bring salvation. Some died because they refused to offer the sacrifice of goats.

We have seen how renewal movements have often begun to reach out to the marginalized, not only in evangelism, but also with ministries of compassion. These have often focused both on immediate needs. But they have often had implications for greater changes in unjust social and economic structures. John Wyclif wanted every ploughboy in England to be able to read the Bible. The Puritans established 60 schools for poor children in Wales, and Baxter, one of the greatest Puritans, organized a program to prepare people to work in the clothing industry. The Pietist leader, Francke, taught that seeking the glory of God meant seeking the good of one's neighbor. As a logical result he established an orphanage and schools for girls as well as boys, and his student, Ziegenbalg, did the same in India. The Puritan, John Eliot, worked to protect the Native Americans or 'Indians against the exploitation of the other European settlers, even as he evangelized and organized churches among them. Jonathan Edwards and his disciple, David Brainerd, did the same.

As time passed and some of the movements gained momentum and numbers, social change came. A great wave of laws improved the situation of the poor in England as a result of the eighteenth century awakenings. Most important of course was the abolition of slavery. But there were many other laws as well, such as those regulating child labor and prison reform. And Samuel Hopkins, a disciple of Edwards, became one of the early voices against slavery in North America, even though he had men in his church who profited from the slave trade.

Where new movements have occurred primarily among the poor, usually the works of compassion have taken place primarily among their own people. There have been two aspects of this. First, the new faith has led many to stop seeing themselves as helpless victims of superior forces, and led them to believe they could become agents of change in their own lives. This, of course, has led to upward social mobility. And often those in the group have helped each other as the whole community worked together. The concern for the broader society has come later, if it has come at all. David Martin in Tongues of Fire, his book on Latin American Pentecostalism, suggested the possibility that as it matured, that movement might begin to show concern for change in the greater society. Recently Douglas Peterson in his book, neither by Might nor by Power, describes an impressive system of primary schools in Central America, established by the Assemblies of God. Their purpose, he asserts, is not simply to help the children who enroll but to begin a process of change in their societies. (Peterson 1999, cf. also Martin 1990)

We have already seen how mission beyond their own ethnic groups and nations has been a characteristic of nearly all renewal movements. There is clearly a logical order here, theologically as well as culturally. As the understanding and commitment to the Gospel deepens, the mandate to go beyond one's own people becomes clear. Thus the Waldensians went to various areas of southern and central Europe. The Puritans went to North American 'Indians,' the Pietists to India, and the Moravians to over twenty countries. The modern Protestant missionary movement has its roots in these movements along with the revivals of the eighteenth century in Europe and North America. The earliest Pentecostals left Azusa Street and other places in the United States within a year or two after the movement began. They went out as 'missionaries of the one way ticket,' to Asia, Africa, and Latin America. The infant Korean church, coming out of 1903-1907 revival, sent its first missionaries to Cheju Island, to China, Siberia, and Japan, beginning in 1907. And those caught up in the East African revival scattered to many surrounding countries and tribal groups.

A more problematic issue has been the concern for the renewal of the wider church. We find this in Luther and Calvin. We also see it in the Puritans and Pietists at first, at least. But the rejection suffered at the hands of the broader church has often led renewal movements to turn toward a more sectarian direction. It is difficult to overcome this tension, but it is a task to which genuine movements of the Spirit are called if they are to be faithful.

While renewal is never complete, either in the specific movement or in the broader church, often the work of the Spirit in the peripheral movement has penetrated the larger body to a significant extent. Pietism had a positive impact on much of the Lutheran church in Germany, Norway, and Denmark. Methodism made an impact on contemporary Anglicanism, turning it in a more evangelical direction and stimulating social reform. The Great Awakening in North America set the direction of much of Protestantism in the United States for a century and a half, and continues to have influence today. And it is clear that many of the emphases of the Pentecostal/Charismatic movement have found their way into the more traditional churches as well as newer movements all over the world.

Andrew Walls has suggested that the Church always needs to recognize two aspects of its life. He calls them the 'indigenous' and the 'pilgrim' principles. The first refers to the importance of the Christian faith putting down deep roots in each context, so that people from that culture will feel 'at home' in the Christian community. They will know that they are among their own people, those to whom they belong. But if that is all that happens the church easily falls into tribalism and denies the universality of the Gospel message. Hence the importance of the 'pilgrim principle,' in which all are called to see themselves as citizens of the Kingdom

of God, and the universal Church, That Church transcends tribe, ethnic group, denomination, and nation. This of course is a long slow process, never totally complete. All of us constantly live in some tension between the two. New movements of necessity begin stressing the uniqueness of their own contexts and the importance of being genuinely indigenous in styles of leadership, communication, worship, and structure. But if such movements are to make their greatest impact, both in evangelization and social transformation, they must follow that 'pilgrim principle.' That will lead them to look beyond themselves and their own people, to the broader church. They will ask how they, as citizens of the Kingdom of God, can work together to take the message of Christ to others. And that, I believe, will make the whole Body of Christ more effective in working for the transformation of society.

A final observation. No movement is perfect, even though it is initiated and led by the Holy Spirit. Every one will exhibit flaws, and will be messy on the edges and even at the center at times. This is to be expected as long as the Spirit chooses to use sinful humans in the work of redemption. Many historical examples could be cited but it is not necessary. We are all too aware of them.

I conclude these observations of characteristics of renewal movements throughout history with the words of Jonathan Edwards, who was certainly the greatest theologian of revival that the western world has seen. He recognized that the awakening in which he took part had its defects. But then he laid down criteria by which to evaluate what he called a 'genuine work of God.' First, he said, it exhalts Jesus Christ. Secondly it attacks the kingdom of darkness. Thirdly, it honors the Scriptures. Fourth, it promotes sound doctrine. And fifth, it results in an outpouring of love to God and humans expressed in practical ways. I think it is clear that the movements we have examined so far have met these criteria to a significant extent. And it will become equally clear that those we study in the next chapters do so as well

This rapidly growing movement among the most oppressed people of India exhibits to a remarkable degree most of the characteristics we have discussed in the first two chapters. It is known as the Rural Presbyterian Church of India in the United States but different, non-western terms are used in India. In order to understand its remarkable growth we must first describe the plight of the people among whom it is growing.

THE BHANGIS

According to Hindu caste regulations codified in the Laws of Manu, God created people from his own body in four major occupational groups or castes. The first three were the Brahmins, who are to be priests and scholars, the Kshatriyas, the warriors and keepers of law and order, and the Vaisyas, the merchants and traders. These three groups were designated 'twice born' castes because they had the right to receive religious instruction from the Brahmins and undergo a spiritual rebirth in a special ceremony. These first three castes together make up 17% of India's population. The fourth caste, the Sudras, was created to serve the three higher castes. They make up nearly 45% of the population.

The fifth group consists of the Panchmas, or untouchables. According to Hindu tradition God did not create them. The reasoning is that because they are so filthy and defiled that they could never have been created by a pure and holy God. This circular reasoning condemns them to their fate. The Hindu books are silent regarding their origin but there is an unstated belief that they came from the bodily excretions of God or that they were created by animals. For this reason they are assigned the most menial tasks, including that of handling human waste. They number approximately 200 million people and are taught that their unalterable fate has been fixed at birth. This system has been in place for three thousand years.

Untouchables are shunned, insulted, and banned from Hindu temples. It is said that they are unworthy to have a religion. The gods will have nothing to do with people so degraded and worthless. They are forced to eat and drink from separate utensils in public places. Normally they cannot draw water from wells used by others, and often are physically mistreated. This ancient belief system is more powerful than India's constitution, which specifically forbids caste discrimination and theoretically abolished untouchability. Consequently this rigid Hindu social system still governs daily life. Under its code an untouchable parent gives birth to an untouchable child who is condemned as unclean from the beginning of life. Thus untouchables are trapped at the bottom of their society without any hope of change.

But there is a descending order of sub-groups among them. The lowest are the Bhangis, numbering around 30 million. Among the jobs assigned to them are the disposing of human waste, the removal of dead animals, and the cleaning and unclogging of sewers. They do so without safety measures and the simplest of tools. The worst task is normally assigned to he women. Many are required to take human waste and carry it in baskets on their heads to be used as fertilizer in the fields. They are of course considered inferior to men. After they have performed these tasks, the Bhangis must beg for leftover food from the families for whom they have worked. Because they are forced to live such tragic lives they are segregated, even by other untouchables, who will not take food or drink from them. This is especially true in rural areas, where three-fourths of India's population lives. Crimes of violence against them are common but are rarely investigated by the police who of course, belong to a higher caste (O'Neill 2003).

One can only imagine the effect of this system on its victims. They are told that their fate is the result of their own sins in previous incarnations and that it cannot and should not be changed, In most places their children cannot go to the village schools, and if they do, they are ridiculed and assumed to be incapable of learning. This is even more the case with girls. Their society tells untouchables from the beginning of their lives that they are inferior to other humans and even to animals. There is no hope that things will ever be different. They are not given genuine names but are called by terms meaning dung, unclean or worse. Half of them will die before reaching the age of 15 because of the filth in which they are forced to live and the lack of the simplest medical care. Any wonder that they call themselves 'Dalits,' oppressed, or literally, the 'ground down' people.

Hence the challenge! How can the Dalits hear the Gospel of Jesus Christ as Good News for them? Can it possibly liberate them from lives of such despair and degradation and begin to transform their communities in the present and give them hope for the future? That was the challenge faced by the Rev. Philip Prasad when he returned to his homeland, the state of Uttar Pradesh, in Northern India, in 1984.

THE STORY OF PHILIP PRASAD

Philip's grandfather became a Christian when a Presbyterian missionary came to his village. His visit changed the history of one family and eventually thousands of others. However the grandfather was beaten and expelled from his village, and died of his wounds six months later. Philip's father became a pastor and cared for fifty small village congregations. But he still carried the stigma of being a Bhangi. As a child Philip often accompanied his grandmother as she cleaned her daily quota of 22 latrines. But when Philip was eight, his father humiliated himself before the village schoolmaster and begged for permission for the boy to attend the school. Philip was allowed to sit in the

corner, behind the teacher, on a heap of cow dung while he listened to the lessons. He mastered three years' work in one, then received a scholarship to study in a mission school where he completed high school.

There, he said, he learned to dump his heavy burdens on the mercy of Jesus Christ. And he

> learned how to lead others to transfer their heavy yoke of destitution, ignorance, darkness and evil teachings, to Jesus Christ and place themselves under his lighter yoke of faith, education, discipline, facing ridicule for faith, and love for the enemies (Witnessing Ministries of Christ (WMC) 1998-99:39).

For six years he participated in summer programs in untouchable communities, teaching Bible lessons, adult literacy, and community development. While doing so he learned valuable lessons for the future.

Early in his life Philip had witnessed the faithfulness of God through his remarkable parents. Although his father was a pastor, the family lived in abject poverty. But, he wrote,

> One solid lesson I learned from my parents...was that utter destitution could lead the believers to an inner spiritual state of total dependence on God. When we did not have food or clothes and faced insurmountable problems of survival, my father read…from chapter six of the Gospel of Matthew. When there was nothing to eat we prayed…and somehow our actions brought forth food. I do not remember going hungry in the worst of times for more than three days (WMC 2000-2001:32}.

During several occasions of special need, money appeared in ways that can only be described as miraculous. Thus as a child he experienced the reality of God's presence and power.

Upon graduation from high school he assumed he would find a job, never dreaming he might be able to do further study. But his own pastor insisted he go on to college. Philip replied that he had no resources and that only God could make it happen. The pastor replied, "Yes, God will make that happen. Here, take these five rupees (his entire month's salary) and go to college" (WMC 2000-2001:35). Neither knew that five rupees were not even enough for two days stay at the college.

This pastor was the first of at least eleven persons whom Philip termed 'angels.' They helped him at different steps along his remarkable journey. With their help he graduated from Ewing Christian College in Allahabad in 1957, then received a scholarship to attend the theological school at Dubuque University in Iowa in the United States. At a number of points when it appeared totally impossible for him to continue his journey, these 'angels' helped him on his way. In 1958 he arrived in New York with one dollar in his pocket and no way to get to Iowa, halfway across

the country. There an African American church took a special offering and gave him funds to pay his travel to Dubuque.

At the university Philip met Elizabeth, the remarkable woman who became his wife in 1962. She soon learned to love India and the poor as he did. They became involved in various ministries. Working among Navahos in Arizona Philip soon realized that the requirements for Presbyterian ordination barred almost all Navahos from ministry, even though it was nearly impossible for Anglos to learn their language and work effectively among them. Clearly a different model of leadership training was needed. After graduation from seminary Philip worked ten years in ecumenical ministries to Hispanic migrant agricultural workers and African Americans near Bakersfield, California. There he saw terrible poverty and exploitation among minorities in the United States.

Philip learned a number of important lessons during those years. He had to raise funds, work with local sponsoring boards, and administer programs. A 'head start' school was organized and he saw changes in the community as extremely poor people were treated with respect and found hope for their future. Perhaps most importantly, Philip worked to discover and empower local leadership, knowing that to be the crucial key to community development. In 1970 the Prasads moved to Fresno, also in central California, where Philip worked with the state to establish service centers in the poorer areas of the city. This led eventually to an appointment as Director of Housing and Community Development, and finally to Deputy City Manager for Fresno.

Through the years a number of untouchables had been able to study and find careers for themselves either in India or abroad. This often happened because of their Christian faith and the aid of mission institutions. Unfortunately in most cases, after achieving success outside the Dalit community, they distanced themselves from their own people. That was true of the traditional churches in India that in most cases had their own roots in the untouchable community. But while he was in college, Philip and three others determined that someday they would initiate ministry among their own people, the Bhangis. His friends, still in India, had not taken steps to do so. And as he continued in his career in California, it appeared that Philip had also forgotten that earlier pledge. But, he said, he had never lost the goal of returning to India and the Bhangis.

In 1983 he became ill, was hospitalized, and spent a month in bed. At that time he became convinced that God was calling him to resign from his secure position in Fresno and go back to India. That was obviously a difficult decision for Elizabeth and their children. But in 1984, with no support from any official Presbyterian body, Philip returned to Uttar Pradesh. Although he had been ordained in the American Presbyterian Church, he

returned without any denominational support. Only a few individuals and local churches helped him.

There he found about 4000 Dalit Christians and a ten older pastors, remnants from the era of the missionaries, who had been forced to leave India years earlier. The people had suffered from severe pastoral neglect for three or four decades. Their mentality was still one of dependency, despair, and hopelessness. Some social, political, and economic changes had taken place in India, but nothing had changed for the Dalits. They had no concept of being oppressed. They assumed that was the way it was supposed to be, that life would continue as it always had, with the women cleaning latrines and the families subsisting on the leftover food thrown at them. Thus Philip recognized the necessity of raising up a new generation of leaders and creating a new mentality.

He knew that Bhangis were a special case, having no ability to change within themselves. It would not be enough simply to alter their external circumstances. A profound transformation had to take place within them. From his own experience he was convinced that change would come only when Jesus Christ entered their lives and brought a new understanding of their identity as children of God.

THEOLOGICAL DISCOVERIES

At first he preached the Christian message in traditional western terms. The younger people who heard him raised a key question. Was this Jesus Christ a foreign god? This led Philip to two significant theological breakthroughs. He began to look at the Hindu gods, and the concept of avatar. An avatar was the incarnation of a god who had entered history for some specific purpose. Soon Philip began to teach that Jesus was the true Avatar. Then as he read Luke 4:18 in his Hindi Bible, he found that the word for the poor, to whom Jesus came, was Dalit. Thus he began to teach that Jesus was the True Avatar, the "Dalit Avatar (suffering incarnation), who unlike the Hindu avatars suffered humiliation, loneliness, insults, injustice, and cruelty, like the Bhangis suffer" (WMC 2002-2003:5). He did so in order to free the Dalits from oppression and lift them up to new life. While their culture spoke of many Hindu avatars who would have nothing to do with Dalits.

> They begin to recognize that the incarnation of God as revealed in Jesus Christ alone reaches out to touch them in their wretched condition. Dalits recognize deep in their souls that Jesus Christ understands their despair, and they must accept Him as Savior to overcome the degradation of their core existence (WMC 1998-1999:1).

In other words the focus of the message was this. 'You are Bhangis and Jesus can transform you, spiritually, economically, and socially. The work of God in Jesus is to bring salvation in two parts; a life of dignity here and eternal life on the other

side.' So the message was relevant for both time and eternity.

This remarkable step in contextualizing the Gospel changed Jesus from a distant, western deity in the minds of the Bhangis, to the God who had become one of them. Thus they would not call themselves Christians, a word associated with Western Christianity and with foreigners, they would be 'Dalit Avataris,' people of the Dalit Avatar, Jesus Christ. They would not use the usual Hindi word for church, they would use the term 'mandal,' circle, or encirclement. The term refers to protected territory in which the people can gather safely. It is used to refer both the local and regional body. So the name of the movement is the Gramin (rural) Prachin (elders) Mandal (GPM) This can be translated into English as the Rural Presbyterian Church, but that translated name is not used in India. Furthermore the people listened to Philip because he always spoke in the rural language of the Bhangi people. A non-Bhangi would not know that language and an educated Bhangi would be ashamed to use it. But Philip not only spoke as they did, he told jokes in it, and he dressed and lived much as they did.

These discoveries initiated a continuing process of contextualization as the Gospel was communicated in terms and concepts to which these 'ground down' people could relate. This process, that Philip calls 'dalitization' or de-westerization has two other motives. On the one hand it is designed to protect the movement from fundamentalist Hindu attacks on those who take the message of the Gospel to the Bhangis and thus threaten to overturn Hindu social structure. It also wants to avoid leading the people to take on the garb of a foreign culture with its names, and nomenclature that would appear to make them less Indian. Thus Dalit Avataris are encouraged to maintain family relationships with other untouchables and continue to identify themselves as Bhangis, considering it a badge of honor, not shame.

In the twenty years since Philip returned over 700,000 have been baptized into the movement and the total community, including children and adults awaiting baptism, numbers 1,500,000. The number of new converts increases annually, and in the most recent year for which we have statistics, over 125,000 were baptized. It is easy to expect the movement to double in the next five years. (WMC 2002-2003:1)

I believe it is correct to say that early Methodism created a new form of the church as Wesley moved, unwillingly and perhaps unwittingly, from a Christendom concept to a 'people of God' model. Even though the Methodist Church lost most of Wesley's original emphases, its descendents have continued to proliferate in the twentieth century, primarily through various types of Pentecostalism. These have been the most rapidly growing forms of the Church, especially in Asia, Africa, and Latin America. Some estimate that

400 million have come to Christian faith during the twentieth century through such movements. Thus a comparison might be in order here. During John Wesley's ministry, from 1738 to his death in 1791, Methodism grew to 72,000 members in England and 15,000 in the United States. But in twenty years this movement among Bhangis in India has grown to nearly ten times that number. This raises an interesting question. What will be the long-range implications of this and similar movements for the growth of the Church, in this new century? If the two billion desperately poor of the world can hear the message of Jesus Christ as transforming, empowering good news for them in their contexts, the positive implications are staggering.

While we affirm that this is obviously a unique work of the Holy Spirit, we also recognize that the Spirit uses methods of communication, leadership training and church structures that are appropriate to the context and make sense culturally to the people.

WORSHIP AND CONTEXTUALIZATION

First we want to discover how the message of the Dalit Avatar is being communicated to these people who have lived without hope for centuries. Next we will look at the issue of leadership. How does this movement select and train anywhere enough pastoral leadership for such a rapidly growing movement. Thirdly, how is the Church, the People of God, structured? Fourthly, how do the believers, the Dalit Avataris, understand the new life? Fifth, what difference has this movement made among its adherents, socially and economically? And finally, what is the impact, positively and negatively, in the broader community, both Christian and Hindu?

The movement's philosophy of ministry is expressed in its major symbol, a tree with six green branches topped by a cross that emits rays of light. The light around the cross symbolizes the resurrection and the hope of new life for Dalits through the sacrifice of Jesus Christ, the Dalit Avatar. A common greeting among them is "Praise Jesus." The branches represent a growing tree, and each one represents an essential area of the new life.

The first is the spiritual branch, representing the Word of God through which their souls are watered and grow so their lives can bring forth fruit. Here they receive a sense of safety and security in God even though their culture has degraded them. The second branch represents a member's mental duties. The movement is committed to the education of all believers, an essential factor in escaping from poverty. This is strongly counter-cultural in India where traditionally the upper castes have denied education to untouchables. The third branch symbolizes the responsibility to care for their physical bodies. They understand that salvation is for both body and soul. The fourth is the economic branch of the tree. The movement is committed to bringing the people out of economic destitution. The

dominant society has used its wealth to keep them weak and poor, and make them 'dance on a string,' as one of their hymns says. But even as they escape from poverty they are not to forget their Dalit identity and their obligation to the whole untouchable community. This also implies support for the church. The fifth branch represents their social concern. The pastors teach the people that the Gospel is the means of salvation for the entire society and that they have an obligation to love their neighbors, even those who have mistreated them. Faith is to lead to good works. The sixth branch represents their commitment to evangelism. That is the task of all believers so that all may come to understand and embrace Jesus, the Dalit Avatar.

This reflects a remarkably holistic and I believe, biblical, understanding of the Greek word for salvation, 'sozo,' which means 'wholeness.'

Many biblical stories take on new meaning when they are read through the eyes of the Dalits. The exodus motif is important. They understand that Moses was the leader who led the Israelite Dalit people from bondage to their Promised Land. Indian Dalits cannot go to a new land but they can escape from social and economic bondage in their own country. Another important story is that of the man who lay by the pool of Betsaida for 38 years. When Jesus asked if he wanted to get well, he did not answer but launched into a litany of excuses, justifying his helplessness. He probably lived on the leftover food given to him by those who visited the pool just as Dalits must do. But Jesus ordered him to get up and walk. From the beginning Philip began asking the Bhangi elders the same question, 'Do you want to get well?' The question indicated respect for their ability to determine their own spiritual, social, and economic destiny. And the response has been overwhelmingly positive.

The people engage in corporate worship once a week. This can be on any day, since the pastors each cover twelve village congregations, leading worship twice a day. No congregation can be larger than forty families. When they arrive the pastors visit the believers house to house, inviting them to worship. They also do pastoral work and receive offerings at that time. Then the people come together and draw a circle, or mandal. The sanctuary, or worship center can be created in a few minutes. It is built around the Hindu concept of a shrine where God is honored and respected. Even though it is temporary place set up with a rug thrown on the ground it is considered holy ground and no one stands on it without taking off his or her shoes. This reminds the people of Moses who took off his shoes in the presence of God. The first worship symbol is the tent of the Exodus. This reminds them that they are on a journey from a life of no worth to a life of oneness with God, from slavery to freedom. The cross includes a wheel, indicating that Jesus calls them to a continuous journey of progress and development. That ties in with the tree of six branches. Three items are placed on the altar. The first is a Bible.

The second is an empty bowl symbolizing the blood of the suffering incarnation. The third is a plate with unleavened bread, symbolizing the broken body of the Dalit Avatar.

There is a prescribed agenda for worship. The people, who are 95 per cent illiterate, learn to participate in the Lord's Prayer, confession of sin, prayers for the offering, and a pledge for the education of the children. The pastors teach a curriculum established for each year. The content of the preaching seeks to cover the entire Bible with special focus on the Gospels of Luke and John. The pastors also teach the articles of faith of the Graman Prachin Mandal, and the Apostles' Creed. Non-believers and people of other castes are welcome to attend.

Just as we have seen in other movements, music is a powerful part of worship. It builds understanding of what it means to follow Jesus. They learn to sing much of Scripture. The Psalms, the Lord's Prayer, the birth of Jesus, and most of the main events of the Bible have been put into hymn forms. Much of the music is created spontaneously in the villages and then spreads to others. So far they have published 100 of their hymns but there are many more. One young man with unique talent has appeared. When he hears about the need of a hymn on a specific subject, he returns with it the next day, both words and music. He is a Dalit Charles Wesley! One fourth of the hymnal focuses on their culture, their predicament and how Jesus helps them. One song compares Jesus to the smell of sandalwood that soon evaporates, while His fragrance continues forever. Some Bhangis, unable to enter the Hindu temples, have invented their own shamanistic gods who require the sacrifice of animals. Hence there is a hymn that puts all of these gods and goddesses together and compares them with Jesus in a ludicrous manner. The people find this very humorous and laugh as they sing. Still another hymn declares that the Dalit Avataris will not be treated like monkeys on a stick any longer. The references to their own culture and predicament is obvious. An American visitor wrote "the grace and presence of God is almost visceral in the villages. It simply must be experienced to be believed" (Branson, 2004).

The official hymn of the movement summarizes its major themes.

Source of peace for the Dalit people
(repeat)
You are the mighty Christ,
You are the mighty Christ.

Chorus; We are redeemed in Jesus' name;
And find peace in Jesus' name.

You left your glory to become a Dalit
(repeat)
Suffering shame and death,
Suffering shame and death.

You gave six branches to help the church grow strong
(repeat)
In them we Dalits find our strength,

In them we Dalits find our strength.

We seek the blessings of education
(repeat)
Grant us this powerful gift,
Grant us this powerful gift.

Dalit people rise to claim Jesus' victory
(repeat)
Lead us to our crown,
Lead us to our crown.
(Prasad,E 2004)

One young man is writing plays that dramatize the parables. He uses drums as he tells the story all night. After part of the story is told, there comes a chorus time in which all the people participate. This is repeated over and over to the end. It is a very joyful night of celebration.

Over the years they have created ceremonies that look quite Hindu to more traditional Christians. But Philip insists that they are more faithful to the Gospel than many imported practices. Two striking illustrations of contextualization can be seen in the celebrations of Christmas and Easter. Christmas is called 'Mahajayanti,' the greatest birth, a new term they have created. It is close to the term designating the birthday of a Hindu incarnation and as a result the people are able to celebrate Christmas openly with growing participation by the community at large. Special ceremonies have been created for each of the fifteen days of Christmas. The ceremonies for the nine days of Easter are a remarkable example of showing the relevance of the biblical message to the life of Dalits. Using the healing of the paralytic in John 5 they are taught that they too, can get up and walk. Through faith and education a new paradigm of life emerges. The second day the women are honored, using the story of the woman at the well in John 4. Her life was changed by Jesus and she ran to tell others. The third day, again using John 5, the men are encouraged to get up and walk in joy. The fourth day is for the children who can now see a future very different from the past. On the fifth day, based on the parable of the Good Samaritan, believers are to eat sacrificially. The money saved is to be given to someone in need from outside of their community. On the sixth day they remember the suffering of Jesus who understands their own pain. That helps them to face their own pain and begin to change. On the seventh day they remember their humiliation in the past and the Exodus, the liberation from Egypt. On the eighth day they celebrate the risen Lord and their own liberation as a consequence. And on the ninth day they see themselves as a resurrected people and contemplate the struggle to maintain their new life.

The Hindu wedding celebration has been baptized. The form is the same but now the content is biblical. Traditionally the groom and bride are tied together and walk seven times around a fire. The bride follows the groom, declaring her duty to help her husband get money and power. This has been changed. Now as they walk they quote Scripture verses about the duty

of a husband to his wife and wife to her husband. As they circle the fire the last time, they walk together. The bride wears any color but white, since that is the color for a widow in mourning.

There are also ceremonies for the giving of new names, baptism and the twice-born ritual, celebrations of engagements and weddings, last rites, the dedication and appointment of pastor couples, renewal in the sacred bathing pool, praying for the sick, and Communion. There is written guidance for the morning and evening personal prayers and meditation required of all members.

Their twenty articles of faith incorporate important theological points, seen especially from a Dalit viewpoint. The pastors must memorize these and teach them to the people. They also refer to the governance of the Church. We can see how they are consistent with the faith of the historic Church, but adapted to their context.

STATEMENT OF FAITH

"The Gramin Prachin Mandal is a religious association of Dalit Avatari brothers and sisters who abide by a set of religious beliefs, both as local groups and as individual members of the Gramin Prachin Mandal.

Article 1. There is only one God who is the heavenly father of all humankind. He created each and every man and woman equal to one another and in His own image.

Article 2. Humankind has violated God the Father's love, and God sacrificed Himself to save people from hell.

Article 3. Dalit Avatari teaching is God's gracious speech.

Article 4. God the Father chose the believers from before the creation of the world so that they would walk before Him as holy and sinless people.

Article 5. We believe that God did not give this vision to the proud and knowledgeable of the world or to those who consider themselves great, but the Heavenly Father's heart was full of love for the broken and shows forth the greatness of his Dalit Avatar through us.

Article 6. There is a second spiritual birth, which is a secret gift of life-power that has been revealed for the Dalits through the only Dalit Avatar, Jesus Christ. On this basis Jesus Christ's compassion woke up the sleeping spirits of the Dalit Avataris and they have been born again in a second spiritual birth. These men and women who have been born again of the Spirit receive peace, prosperity, and eternal life.

Article 7. The all-powerful God alone is Lord of the whole universe. He breathes His spirit into the human body. For this reason the human spirit receives peace,

power, and hope in worship and devotion to Him.

Article 8. On account of the spiritual power of their second birth Dalit Avataris renounce sin completely.

Article 9. Believers give up their former conduct on being born again and adopt the conduct of the spiritually reborn. They receive blessings through their awakened inner self, through daily meditation, and through doing good deeds.

Article 10. It is an absolute commandment to remember God's powerful miracle. (A reference to their own Exodus).

Article 11. To present a religious offering is an essential act for the believer's salvation.

Article 12. The local congregation is a spiritual stronghold for the nurture of believers and its spiritual security is handed over to teaching and ruling elders.

Article 13. According to the teaching of the holy Avatar, decisions about quarrels will be made through the Mandal Panchayat, the bodies made up of elected elders who govern the church at the local, presbytery, and national levels.

Article 14. The whole set of religious beliefs is summed up in the two top-most commandments: Love God and neighbor.

Article 15. It is the commandment of the holy Avatar that there be full equanimity within the biradari (community) and that the exercise of any tyranny over the biradari is a serious sin.

Article 16. Eating the fruits of labor and honesty is the absolute religious duty of the members.

Article 17. It is an important duty of the members of the Gramin Prachin Mandal to show respect to teaching and ruling elders and elderly people.

Article 18. It is the religious duty of members of the Gramin Prachin Mandal to protect their families and fellow believers.

Article 19. It is an absolute religious duty of believers to rely on themselves economically.

Article 20. The governance of the Gramin Prachin Mandal is through teaching and ruling elders elected by believers in accordance with the Holy Scriptures. (Webster 2003:36-38)

LEADERSHIP SELECTION AND TRAINING

Coming out of the traditional western Presbyterian system of pastoral preparation, Philip faced a serious dilemma. Clearly a highly contextualized method of choosing and preparing pastoral leadership was essential. Seminaries in India, modeled on those in the West could never serve the movement adequately. Furthermore their methods were in serious contrast to the way Hindu and Muslim

systems trained their priests and mullahs.

At first, Philip wrote, the vision was to see 1000 new believers each year. So he established a program to train twenty pastors annually. But then delegations began to come from villages that the evangelists had not reached. They were asking for pastors. Each had a similar request. "Please send a pastor to our village because we have many believers and must have guidance for practicing our faith." Relatives had visited them and told of the Dalit Avatar. Philip and the other leaders called in all the existing elders for a week of prayer. They confessed their sin of limiting God to their own thinking. He wrote, "God poured His Spirit on our old men and women who began dreaming dreams of masses of Dalits streaming into the household of faith" (WMC 2000-2001:7).

Philip and the other leaders soon realized that the use of male pastors alone limited the ministry and resulted in few pastoral contacts with women. This led to an important change, especially significant in a culture that for centuries had considered women to be inferior to men. They began to appoint pastor couples; husbands and wives would serve together in ministry. And when elders were elected they would include equal numbers of men and women.

As the movement grew far beyond its initial projections, the leaders realized they needed an infrastructure capable of receiving and nurturing massive numbers of new believers. They created a system in which twelve village congregations would be yoked together, each served by a pastor couple who would visit two each day. The twelve congregations, with a projected adult membership of 500, could support their pastors.

At the beginning pastors were given one month of training, then three, and now they begin with six months of study in one of the two regional seminaries constructed by the ministry. The average age of the village pastors is twenty-five, the supervising pastors, thirty. The system of training continues to evolve, but the following describes the current model. Some are illiterate at the beginning and most men have only survived five or six years in the village schools. In most cases the women come with even less. The goal is that eventually each one will receive a college degree. But it is clear that at this time at least, there is very little social distance between pastors and people.

1. "Their selection is based on the strength of the couple's faith, content of their known character, and how the elders in their communities value them for making friendships, respecting others, and helping those needing their assistance.

2. Everyone accepted will be tested for previous educational skills and all will be given formal education. starting when they learn to read and write, up to a college education.

3. Those needing to read and write first will be given fourth grade skills in reading Hindi, English, and doing math. This is accomplished in the first three months of training.

4. The first session of training will last for six months. They will return to the campus at least three times a year for fifteen-day periods. This will continue their formal education while they serve twelve congregations in their respective presbyteries.

5. During the first six months they will learn to read and write fluently. They must know how to read the Bible, the book containing the Articles of Faith, the hymnal, the Book of Ceremonies, and the Book of Order and Discipline. They must memorize the worship services and all the ceremonies so that they do not have to use books. They must memorize the 20 articles and be able to share these with anyone by accurately quoting them and explaining their meaning. They must be able to share who the Dalit Avatar is and why people need to accept Him in their lives. They practice most of these over and over again.

During the first six months they also receive preliminary training in the book, WHERE THERE IS NO DOCTOR. This teaches them to diagnose and treat simple but deadly diseases like diarrhea, stomach worms, night blindness, etc. They learn when to gather resources and take a person to a doctor.

6. During their subsequent returns each quarter they will pursue a written prescribed course which will eventually lead them to a Completion Diploma. In these courses they will continue to climb towards a college degree, pursue Biblical learning, learning of Hindu and Muslim holy books. They will become good at teaching prevention of diseases and getting medical care for their people. They will be taught now to resolve conflicts with the Hindus, improve their people's economic condition, and motivate parents to send children to school. In essence they will know who Bhangis are, identify with them, and give them spiritual guidance and legs to climb out of the pit of Bhangi existence" (Prasad,P 2004: 7,8).

Not all of those who finish the course become pastors. Depending of their gifts, some assume other functions in the movement.

Currently two seminaries are in operation. As of June 2003, 1,329 pastor couples were in the field. Over the last ten years more have been trained but many have gone on to get higher education and serve in administrative and policy positions in the movement. The first seminary, located at Pavitrasthan, has been expanded and now can train two groups of 120 pastor couples per year. The continuing education program functions in the other seminary.

People in India often show respect by touching the feet of the honored one. That

was not a part of Dalit culture because they were untouchables and never considered worthy of honor or respect. They could not even touch others. They were not considered worthy to give honor to anyone else. Now the Dalit Avataris take delight in showing respect to their leaders by touching their feet.

> A second reason has to do with the almost diabolical way oppressed people have of tearing down, cutting up, smashing any of their own number who rise above others of their class. Therefore the touching of the feet is being used as a practical way of helping people get beyond their internal oppression" (Prasad 2004:23)

Thus the people often line up in order to touch Philip's feet and be blessed by him. But they also touch the feet of their pastors, other leaders, and even guests. On special days students are honored by having their feet touched. And in the Nine Days of the resurrection different groups are singled out to be honored in this manner. One day is set aside for children, another for women, two groups that were never previously honored in that way.

CHURCH STRUCTURE AND GROWTH

The growth of the GPM has been partially dependent on funding from Presbyterian churches and individuals in the United States. A church is asked to contribute US$25,000 per year for five years in order to fund a presbytery that will become self-sustaining and self-evangelizing after that period. By June 2003, there were twenty self- supporting presbyteries and eleven others with current supporting relationships with American churches. These were moving toward self-support. There were 29 others in process of organization and growing, but without the resources to engage enough pastors to organize new congregations, acquire bicycles and build houses for the pastors and presbytery centers. The hope is that churches and families in the United States will fund these and 21 more presbyteries. The goal is that these 70 presbyteries will cover all of the state before moving into adjacent states.

Presbyteries are formed in the following manner. The ministry selects a district where the movement of evangelism has been most active. The name and pertinent facts about the presbytery are provided to the partner church. An experienced supervising pastor is selected to lead a team of twelve pastor couples. Each of these is responsible for twelve villages within a ten-mile radius. The pastors receive clothing, Bibles, hymnals and other books, a portable pulpit, utensils for the sacraments, basic medicines, and literacy materials. After five years each of the 144 village groups is examined regarding their faith. Each must show willingness and ability to contribute to the maintenance and support of the pastor couple and the evangelistic ministry. Every believer is expected to tithe. Along with the economic enterprises of the movement this provides

the basis of self-support. The villages that are willing to assume this responsibility are formally consecrated as congregations and each one receives the privilege of electing a ruling elder. These elders, along with the pastors make up the governing body. This builds on a similar practice in which Dalits of twenty to twenty-five villages formed councils of five elders with authority to maintain law and order in the community.

The presbyteries are responsible for the functioning of the congregations and the continuing work of evangelism. They are also responsible to create educational pathways for the children and help implement economic opportunities that enable believers to move away from their traditional degrading occupations. Each year the presbyteries are permitted to select ten boys and ten girls to attend a Christian residential school. They see this as a crucial extension of evangelism, "designed to prepare educated believers, confident of their new identity, with essential skills to lead the Rural Presbyterian Church, India, into reaching 160 million Dalits for the Lord Jesus Christ in this century" (WMC 2002-2003:36,37).
A number of presbyteries constitute a synod.

Thus to some degree the rapid growth of the GPM depends on gifts from outside. They are used for the infrastructure of the new presbyteries, and also the construction of their seminaries and schools. However the leaders insist that after the five years of subsidy, each presbytery must be completely self-supporting. Outside funds continue to support special projects and students in the boarding schools. The ministry has been incorporated in the United States with a governing board with Philip as President. It also files an annual audit with the Indian government under the provisions of the Foreign Contributions Regulation Act. Over 200 local Presbyterian churches plus a number of individuals give support. But even if funds from abroad were to be cut off completely, the movement would continue to grow, although perhaps not as rapidly. This seems to be a healthy example of the effective use of funds from the West that does not create dependency. Because each mandal and presbytery is self-supporting and self-governing with a strong sense of responsibility to share the Gospel with others, the movement is believed to be infinitely reproducible. In mid-2003, 59% of the 16,171 village congregations, or 1347 village circuits, supported their own pastors. The goal is that Dalit Avataris will eventually be able to share the Gospel beyond their own social class. (WMC 2002-2003;4)

THE NEW LIFE OF THE DALIT AVATARIS

The movement has moved to a two-tiered concept of the Christian life. New believers are baptized and expected to follow the basic norms of the new life. These include family prayer and meditation every morning and evening and participation in corporate worship. The giving of offerings

is also essential, not only for the support of the Mandal, but because it symbolizes the profound change in the people's lives Traditionally, Bhangis could not give anything, not only because of their poverty, but because no one, not even the gods, would accept anything from their hands. They were considered polluted and evil. They could only receive the left over scraps thrown at them. Thus we can understand the power of a ceremony in which the people turn their hands over from a cupped position of receiving scraps thrust at them, to a giving position of living in dignity. Although their average income is twelve rupees per day (about 25 cents, US) they are expected to tithe. The offerings may be in the form of money, eggs, vegetables, and if that is not possible, believers give a prayer or blessing. The story of Jesus, who used the gifts of a boy to feed 5,000, is used to show how God takes even their meager gifts and multiplies them.

The people exhibit a strong sense of solidarity out of their poverty. Often when a member is ill and needs medical care, the village group combines its resources to send the person to a physician.

The new life begins, not only with baptism, but with a naming ceremony. The background is Hindu Law of Manu. It stipulates that members of the higher castes each have two names denoting something auspicious and indicating happiness or success. But untouchables are to have only one name and a degrading one at that. Dummy, crazy, and feet are examples. So even names are used to oppress them. Thus there was the need to counter this by devising a ceremony to give respectable names to the people and establish the custom of giving family names as well.

Passages from Proverbs about the importance of a good name are used and the new names given to Abram and Simon Peter in Scripture are used as examples. Then three names are given. The first signifies that each person is important before God and that He knows them by name as His sons and daughters. The middle name is related to the church fellowship. It indicates that the person is part of the wider community of those who believe in Christ. These names are based on books of the Bible. The third is a family name. It keeps the name of the family alive for the future and gives it an identity. These names are taken from a list in the church and express an honorable profession, a talent, or a religious expression.

Before the ceremony the pastor meets with the family and helps them select the new names. In the worship service an elder lights a candle. The pastor tells the people they will burn the old name and adopt new ones that reflect their new life in Christ. Then the old name, written on a piece of paper, is burned and the new names given. We can only imagine the power of this ceremony in the Dalit community.

The second level of the Christian life begins with a 'twice born' ceremony. This is deeply rooted in Hindu culture. The perception is that higher caste Hindus have a better moral life than untouchables, that the latter lie, cheat, and steal, get drunk, and beat their wives. The reason is given that while in their teens, Hindu men of the three higher castes participate in a "twice born" ceremony. They take a vow to live on a high moral standard and avoid conduct that would degrade them. Then they wear a white string beneath their clothing as a symbol and personal reminder of that vow. This ceremony was denied to the lower castes and of course, to untouchables. When the Dalit Avataris considered the words of Jesus to Nicodemus, "you must be born again," they felt they needed to design a ceremony and symbol showing their commitment to Jesus, the second birth, and His way of life. This would also imply religious and spiritual equality with high caste Hindus. The ceremony functions as a reaffirmation of their faith and expresses the desire to continue to grow in the new life. An important difference from Hinduism is that this ceremony is available for both men and women.

After those taking this step are taught its meaning by their pastors and make their promises, a medallion is hung around their necks. They reaffirm their belief in God as Creator of all things and their acceptance of Christ as Lord and Savior, the Dalit Incarnation. They recognize again that He came to save them from their life of degradation and honored them by taking on Himself a life of oppression, suffering, and death. And they commit themselves to live a life of faith and devotion, conforming to the image of Jesus who makes all things new. They promise to leave the old way of existence, develop the inner life, and live as new men and women in Christ. If anyone who has taken the vow falls into a life of sin, he or she will be disciplined by the church and made to return the medallion. This ceremony is becoming more and more popular and now around 30% of the members have participated in it.

Deeply ingrained in Hindu culture are bathing ceremonies. Even though baptism by immersion is similar, leaders of the movement felt that more was needed. Ritual bathing is repeated among Hindus. It symbolizes the ongoing process of life and constant need of cleansing. We are reminded of the multitudes bathing in the Ganges each year. Now the GPM has designed a service of bathing and included it in the worship book. The nine days of resurrection centering on Holy Week is the time when most people do this each year. The center at Pavitrasthan has a large pool and now busloads come each year to bathe there. So many came last Easter that the ceremonies continued day and night. Thus they plan to build more such facilities. The ceremony is built around the six branches and rededication to Jesus. The service is read from a platform above the pool, the people submerge themselves in the water and spend time in meditation, rededication, and prayer. Everyone,

including children, take part. Then the people get out and process six times around the pool, as they meditate on the six branches.

EDUCATION

An essential element in the movement is the strong focus on education. This is a logical result of their recovery of dignity and self-hood before God. It is also necessary if Dalits are to escape from poverty. The third motive is to prepare spiritual, economic, and educational leadership for the movement. It is, of course, a radical reversal of the fate imposed on them in the past.

The GPM has carefully worked out its philosophy and program of education, from the primary through university levels. A soaring eagle, drawn by one of the members, has become its symbol.

> 1. The church has the responsibility to educate each child of the believers' families according to his or her ability and talents.
>
> 2. The church is establishing elementary schools at the circuit levels, residential high schools, and scholarships for girls and boys to attend elementary schools and high schools operated by the government and other organizations.
>
> 3. The church sees the value of higher education for the transformation of its people and provides scholarships to the children of believers who are admitted to institutions of higher learning.
>
> 4. The church is working to establish college and university level institutions to enable its children to enter the professions.
>
> 5. The church understands economic and cultural aspects of the caste system and seeks to guide its children into the many caste-neutral but well-paying professions.
>
> 6. The church knows that its ability to redeem Dalit people depends on the managerial, financial, organizational, and theological skills of its workers. Higher education is essential for the future of the movement.
>
> 7. Higher education creates greater prosperity. This is necessary for the movement to continue its work of evangelism among Dalits all over India. (WMC 2002-2003:37).

Currently eleven residential schools are functioning, most of them former missionary schools. There the Bhangis are a minority, studying with caste Hindu and Muslim children. This was quite intimidating for the Dalit children and at first they did not do well, conforming to the existing cultural expectations. But now, with special coaching and focused prayer by their mandals, many excel and the group as a whole performs very well. There are also fourteen village schools, most housed in the presbytery centers.

High caste Hindus have enrolled their children in the village schools because of their excellent reputation. The policy of the GPM is to allow 30% of the enrollment to be Hindus. This gives Dalit children opportunities to establish relationships with caste Hindus and begin to break down cultural stereotypes.

In August 2002, the Dalit Avatar high school was opened, designed to accommodate 500 boys and 500 girls as boarding students and an additional 1000 day students. This was such a significant step, unthinkable a few years ago, that several thousand Dalits came long distances to witness its inauguration. It has even become a place of pilgrimage. Future goals include a business and science university on the same site, and colleges alongside the two seminaries. Two other high schools have also been opened, along with a computer lab and library.

Since the ministry can only educate a fraction of its children it uses an additional strategy. Special camps are held to train parents to deal with authorities to allow enrollment of Dalit children in the local schools.

Historically, as most Dalits in India have moved up economically and socially through the Christian Faith, they have turned their backs on their own people. The GPM has adopted a strategy designed to motivate future generations to continue to focus on the movement and its goal of evangelizing all untouchables. Hence their educational objectives.

> 1. The first objective is to teach the second generation about the mercies that God has bestowed on is fathers and mothers, making it spiritually strong by grounding it in the Word of God and daily prayer. A pastor is assigned to each school to help the children learn the teachings of Jesus and the articles of faith. The children recite a pledge each day based on the six branches of their symbolic tree, focusing on the spiritual, intellectual, physical, economic, social, and evangelistic branches.
>
> 2. The second objective is to prepare the new generation for leadership roles in the GPM and help them succeed economically and professionally in the broader society.
>
> 3. The third is to build the educational infrastructure of schools, colleges, universities, and professional training institutions. (WMC 2000-2001:9,10)

This seems to be working to a remarkable degree. An example is Rozishan Vishwassi, currently the Chief Executive Pastor of the GPM. He was a boy when his parents were among the first families to enter the movement. Encouraged by them and the church, he eventually graduated from the University of Kanpur and became a village pastor. Philip encouraged him to continue his studies and he received an MA degree in 1995 and B Ed in 1996. He led the seminary until 2001 when he was elected Executive Pastor. He is also a

second year law student. He says this is necessary because hostile Hindu organizations are beginning to bring a number of bogus legal cases to hinder the movement. His wife tells that she was only a year away from learning to haul human waste on her head along with her mother when a pastor encouraged her father to send her to school. Now she has a BA degree and teaches in the Dalit Avatar High School. Others, with similar stories, are giving leadership to the church and its educational institution.

ECONOMIC CHANGE AGAINST THE CULTURE

It is obviously hard for the adults who have known only the degrading job of handling human waste and receiving leftover food for their work, to abandon that task and venture out in faith. But so far, Philip said, most have turned their backs on such work. At times this causes conflict. But the process of evangelization, the changing of the self-image of the people, and education, have led to remarkable economic change. Certain jobs are open, even in the present culture, to untouchables. These include the transportation business, teaching, nursing and laboratory work. Many of the men now work in construction and have built their own schools. Centers have been established where women are taught to manufacture clothing of high quality. The ministry owns ponds for fish culture. As the people continue to tithe this expands the economic base of the ministry. The parents of Rozishan, for example, have become entrepreneurs in construction, transportation, and telephone service. Their contribution to the church pays the salary of the Chief Executive Pastor.

The counter-cultural aspects of the GPM can easily be seen. The most obvious, of course, comes from the basic biblical assertion that Banghis, along with all others, are created in the image of God and called to become His sons and daughters in Jesus Christ. The implications of this are profoundly counter to Hindu culture. They include the realization that Dalits are as intelligent and gifted as the higher castes, with enormous potential for creativity and development. Equally important is the manner in which the movement views women. While the dominant culture has taught their inferiority, especially Dalit women, the GPM has insisted on their equality from the beginning. Hence the system of pastor couples, and the care with which equal numbers of men and women are elected elders, and boys and girls chosen to attend school. The men seem to have reacted very positively to this development and husbands no longer look at their wives with shame because of their degrading work. There is now a much greater sense of partnership in marriage.

The BJP, the fundamentalist Hindu party has been dominant in India until recently and is still very active. In the urban centers, especially, politically ambitious people give funds to reactionary Hindu organizations. They have vigilante groups that track the activities of newer, non-

traditional Christian movements. At times they attack worshipers by surprise, then disappear. The authorities normally do not respond. Some presbyteries have learned to operate in that environment and themovement continues to grow. At times the press and anonymous letters have denounced Philip, claiming that he is bringing foreign funds to bribe untouchables to become Christians. One letter portrayed pastors on bicycles as a trained militia intimidating and forcibly converting the people. Two Hindu organizations called for the people to come together and destroy one presbytery center. Although this caused fear among many of the Dalit Avataris, the leaders were successful in preventing any violence or harm. (WMC 1996-1997:2-4)

Philip asserts that the BJP has not opposed them openly. Its adherents claim that they have no problem with Christianity, only with foreign culture. But there have been over forty intensive investigations by government officials seeking to discover criminal wrongdoing in the movement. In each case the officers have returned with positive reports regarding the changes taking place among the people, partly, at least, because they see their leaders, the guru and purohits (pastors), as genuinely Indian. Still, the charge is often made that Christian conversions take place only because of bribes or coercion. In 2001

> Five top leaders of the GPM had warrants out for their arrest on bogus charges that they were forcing and bribing the illiterate and destitute Dalits to become Christians. One pastor…was beaten unconscious and put in jail. The police planted a vial of opium in his pocket and arrested on charges of drug possession (WMC 2000-2001:51).

Some groups of Bhangis have changed their names and thus see themselves as more acceptable, even though they continue to clean latrines. They have expressed opposition to the GPM, probably out of fear that the movement would bring persecution against them as well.

The strangest opposition has come from some in the traditional church. This seems to have two reasons. Most people in the Indian church came originally either from the leather workers or Bhangis. But they would like to forget that fact. The existence of a thriving movement among Bhangis who continue to bear that name proudly, is an embarrassment to them. Some also criticize the movement because of its use of Hindu terms and 'dalitization,' in other words, its creative contextualization.

THE GIFTS OF THE SPIRIT

Every believer is considered gifted in some way and is expected to give something back to the community. As we noted earlier, tithing is expected. We cannot over emphasize the importance of this for people who have long been told they were worthless and had nothing to contribute to anyone.

The leaders do not emphasize the more 'supernatural' gifts of the Spirit. They believe it is important to avoid anything that looks magical because of the pervasive influence of folk Hinduism with its claims of miracles. The pastors pray for the sick in worship and ask if the person has medicine. If not, they seek the necessary help. At times they anoint the sick person with water or oil. And they call a physician. However the people have reported miraculous incidents of healing and women who were apparently barren have become pregnant. There have also been reports of dreams and visions although Philip does not encourage them. He did tell of the elder of one village who had resisted the new faith even though his people wanted to join the movement. After months of struggle he came to the leaders requesting baptism, saying he had a dream in which God told him he could go to Hell if he wished but that he should not lead his people there!

The leaders and the people have a strong sense of God's leading through prayer. Wisdom, an important concept in their culture, often comes through prayer. This brings a strong sense of the leading of God to new projects, goals, and directions. They have great confidence that if they ask in prayer, God will lead them as He has in the past.

Evangelism and growth take place in several ways. Most importantly, believers share their new faith and life with others. After the witness of laypersons a village often asks for a pastor to come and visit them. Usually after six months or a year of visits, the village asks for baptism. The growth is accelerating each year. The report for 1996-1997 gave the total membership at 146,272, with 44,272 baptisms that year. But from July 2000 to June 2001, there were 102,216 baptisms, during the same period a year later the number was 116,143. and the following year, 125.217. (WMC 1996-1997:1, 2000-2001:2, 2001-2002:1 and 2002-2003:2)

As noted earlier, it is estimated that there are 30 million Bhangis among the 200 million untouchables in India and the GPM has stated that its ultimate goal is to reach all the untouchables in the nation. Some other Dalit groups are beginning to look at this movement among Bhangis with interest. And currently there seems to be a groundswell of desire for change among other untouchable groups. Some have publicly embraced Buddhism, others, Christianity.

As for its impact on the broader society and church, the leaders believe this must come later. At the present they focus only on the Dalits for at least three reasons. Although a few caste persons have become affiliate members, the social and cultural barriers are too high for the great majority to become part of a worshipping group of Bhangis. And if higher castes were to enter the movement, it would soon loose its primary focus on the contextualization of the Christian faith among Dalits, even though some of the emphases might fit into the broader Hindu context. Furthermore, if people from the

castes entered the movement, it would become almost impossible for Dalits to rise to positions of leadership. Thus some of the key goals of the movement would be defeated. Looking at the broader society as more Bhangis move into the mainstream of educational and economic life this will certainly have a major impact. But it will take time before they are viewed differently by their culture. Thus while there is a vision for change in Indian society, GPM leaders believe that it will only come by showing change within the Dalit community first.

This is the dilemma of a brilliant and successful movement of contextualization. As we have seen, Andrew Walls suggested that the missionary movement always lives in the tension between the 'indigenous' and the 'pilgrim' principles. The church in a given culture is always called to be indigenous, that is, the people of that culture must feel 'at home' within it, to know that it is for 'them,' and is not foreign. But on the other hand, believers are always called to be pilgrims as they discover their identity with the larger Body of Christ that includes men and women of a myriad of cultures and languages. The latter is obviously a long-range process and only time will tell how this takes place. Philip believes it will be fifty years before Dalit Avataris see themselves as part of the wider Church. Certainly at this point it exists on the margin of the traditional Protestant denominations in India. Even though in the West it is known as Presbyterian, in reality it is a post-denominational movement. The term Presbyterian is used mainly because of Philip's own affiliation and the fact that it is supported by Presbyterians in the United States. But the Church of North India, whose roots are Presbyterian in part, has not embraced it.

The influence of the GPM on the more traditional churches in India is another question. Even though they have ignored and criticized the movement, some of the new music of the Dalit believers is finding its way into their worship. And we hope that a number of aspects of contextualization and leadership training will be incorporated into their life.

No movement is perfect. Each one sees failures among its leaders and people. One of the problems here is that of greed among the people who have been so destitute. A few pastors have run away with the funds entrusted to them. Each year scores of pastor-couples are disciplined and on the average thirteen are removed for various offenses. Believers are also disciplined for various offenses. But there is a process of restitution for those who show repentance.

CONCLUSION

It is clear that nearly all of the characteristics of new movements discussed in Chapter II can be seen here. And even though at this point it has not looked beyond its own people to the wider church and society, the vitality and dynamics of the GPM have positive

implications for both if they are taken seriously. It is a powerful instrument of transformation for the Bhangis and potentially for all untouchables in India.

I believe there are three especially critical issues for the future. The first concerns leadership transition. Philip, who is greatly revered by the people, insists that his leadership is no longer essential, that the movement will continue to grow without him. Apparently he has placed a committed and capable leadership team in place as he divides his time between India and the United States. He insists that he is a Mahaguru, a teacher of teachers, with no formal financial or leadership link with the GPM leaders. But they consult him on emerging situations, asking him to comment from both theological and managerial perspectives. My impression is that he has conducted himself with great wisdom. But only time will tell if the movement will continue to show the same dynamism when he is no longer present as their visionary leader.

The second issue concerns the coming generation. Historically it appears that movements of renewal have only maintained their dynamic for two or three generations before losing their vitality. There is a commendable focus on teaching the children the history of their past and vision for the future. But as new generations arise with little or no personal experience of the Bhangi life style, their memories will become more remote and their commitment to the movement may wane. History teaches us that the amazing growth and transformation we have seen thus far will continue only if the Holy Spirit brings renewal within the leaders and people again and again.

The third issue concerns leadership selection and training and the danger of institutionalization. The goal of taking each pastor couple to a bachelor's level of training is impressive and desirable, especially in that culture. The question is whether or not this will gradually separate them from the mentality and life style of the largely illiterate village people. And will this create a separate clergy class that eventually finds its fulfillment and status in maintaining the institution. This has happened in other, similar movements in history. I believe it can be avoided only as long as the movement continues to grow and constantly recruits new pastor couples from the villages. And it is important that all the pastors continue to have equal status, even though they have different levels of responsibility.

We cannot reach any conclusion other than that this is a genuine movement of the Holy Spirit today through a remarkable person who has been led, little by little, into the creation of a contextualized model of the Church among some of the most oppressed people in the world. The result has been a remarkable degree of economic and social transformation among one of the most oppressed groups in the world. While no movement is completely reproducible in other contexts, I believe the GPM has much to teach the broader Christian movement as we move

into the new century. It clearly has special relevance for movements of evangelization and transformation among the poor and marginalized, and may have important lessons for the Church in other contexts as well

Chapter 4

Watchman Nee and the “Little Flock” in China

In recent years we have become aware of the remarkable growth of the Christian movement in China. It is estimated that in 1949, when the Communist revolution triumphed, there were approximately three million Roman Catholics and 700,000 Protestants in that nation. Today, despite attempts to destroy the Church, especially during the Cultural Revolution in the l960's and 1970's, the Church has grown in an extraordinary fashion. Today estimates range as high as fifteen million Roman Catholics and fifty to eighty million Protestants. The latter are generally divided between the government sanctioned 'Three-Self Church' and the 'house church' movement, even though there is some overlap between them. That is, some 'house churches' are registered with the government, but most are not. Thus here can be no doubt that one of the most remarkable Christian movements in all of history has occurred in China over the last half-century, and that this has occurred in the midst of severe persecution.

A number of streams of spiritual life and evangelism have contributed to the growth of the house churches in China. But one of the most important was the 'Little Flock,' led by a remarkable Christian leader, Watchman Nee. His influence has gone considerably beyond his own movement, even into the 'Three Self Church' in China and beyond. Hence his importance as a genuinely Chinese indigenous leader with lessons for emerging Christian movements elsewhere today. As we shall see it shared many characteristics with other movements that have emerged on the periphery of the institutional church throughout history: a remarkable visionary leader motivated by a profound experience of grace, a flexible church structure, leadership chosen from the local assemblies, and the recognition of the gifts of every believer.

EARLY LIFE AND CONVERSION OF WATCHMAN NEE

Nee came from a family with a rich heritage. In 1857 his grandfather was baptized when he was a student in a mission school established by the American Board of Commissioners for Foreign Missions, in Fuzhou. In 1876 he became the first ordained pastor of that mission. One of his sons, Nee Wen-xiu, studied in the American Methodist school and after passing an examination in the Confucian classics, became a state employee. He married Peace Lin, a strong woman with a remarkable background. Born to a poverty stricken peasant family, she was sold to the Lin family, who, instead of using her as a slave, adopted her as a daughter. When her adoptive father became seriously ill and neither

Chinese nor western physicians could help him, a Methodist minister prayed for him. He was healed and the family was baptized into the Methodist Church. Peace studied in a Methodist school and because of her obvious ability was accepted into a program that would eventually take her to medical school in the United States. But her mother was opposed and instead a marriage was arranged with Nee Wen-xiu. The wedding took place just as the Boxer Rebellion was breaking out and anti-foreign fervor was spreading.

After the birth of two daughters, Mrs. Nee ardently prayed for a son and promised the Lord that "if I should bear a son, I will present him to you.' On November 4, 1903, the son was born. He was named Shu-zu, meaning 'he who proclaims his ancestors merits.' Later, when he committed his life to Christ he sought a new name that would express his sense of duty to his people as God's spokesman. He first called himself,'One who gives warning,' later changing it to Tuo-sheng, a gong-note, or tocsin, reminding him that he would be a watchman for God. He would discipline himself to be God's priestly bell ringer and would warn his people of peril and raise up the people of God for service. Hence his English name, Watchman Nee.

Along with Christian instruction in the home and church, Nee learned Chinese calligraphy and the literary and moral principles taught in the Confucian classics, These had formed the basis of Chinese culture for two millennia. He studied in three different mission schools. The last was Trinity College, which taught the Christian message by interpreting Chinese classics in light of the Bible.

The political and social context of China was changing rapidly. Sun Yat-sen's national revolution overthrew the Qing Dynasty in 1911. Peace Lin, Nee's mother, became a revolutionary agitator. She asserted her release from female subservience, publicly advocated women's rights, lectured, and served as Secretary of a woman's patriotic society. As she did so, her Christian life waned. She said that by 1920 she had almost become an unbeliever.

Anti-Christian feeling was growing along with anti-foreign sentiment. The May Fourth Movement in 1919 was a violent reaction against the insensitivity of the Versailles Treaty to Chinese interests. In 1922 the Anti-Christian Federation was formed. At the same time there were different approaches to the growing nationalism within the churches. Between 1917 and 1919 the True Jesus Church was formed with strong Pentecostal emphases combined with some indigenous elements. It grew greatly in central China. It was exclusionist and at times militantly anti-foreign. In 1921 the Jesus Family was established in Shandong province. This movement established Christian communities in which all property was held in common. It emphasized direct revelations through dreams and visions along with glossalalia

and healings. Both of these movements taught the imminent return of Christ. The more traditional churches organized the National Christian Council of China in 1922 and in 1927 sixteen denominational groups formed the Church of Christ in China, comprising one fourth of the Protestants in the country.

This was the context in which Nee, not yet a Christian, was influenced both by the nationalism of his mother and the anti-religious attitude of his fellow students. He later told how he despised preachers as employees of missionaries. Some students at Trinity College were baptized into the Anglican Church at this time but Nee refused to do so. An excellent student in all subjects except Scripture, he cheated in order to pass his Bible exams.

Tension was growing between the equally strong-willed mother and son. When she beat him unjustly, accusing him of breaking a valuable ornament in the home, his resentment escalated. When Peace Lin discovered his innocence her pride prevented her from apologizing for her mistake. Just at this point a remarkable woman evangelist, Dora Yu, came to Fuzhou. Miss Yu, like Peace Lin, had been destined for medical school in the West. But while in the Mediterranean on her way to England, she heard a clear call from God to return to China to preach the Gospel. She did so with no salary, trusting God alone for her needs. Peace Lin had attended one of her meetings as a student in 1898 and was deeply impressed. Now she went again to hear Miss Yu, taking her family. Resentful over the beating, Watchman refused to go. But at the meeting Mrs. Nee had a profound experience of repentance and grace. She confessed to her husband that she had lied and diverted money to games of chance. Then in front of her whole family she asked her son for forgiveness, saying, "For the Lord Jesus' sake, I confess to beating you unjustly" (anonymous source).

Watchman was deeply moved at this and determined to hear the evangelist himself. Later he described the result.

> I was ... struggling to decide whether or not to believe in the Lord….As I tried to pray I saw the magnitude of my sins and the reality and efficacy of Jesus as the Savior. As I visualized the Lord's hands stretched out on the Cross, they seemed to be welcoming me and the Lord was saying, 'I am waiting here to receive you.' As I made my first prayer I knew joy and peace such as I had never known before. Light seemed to flood the room and I said to the Lord, 'Oh Lord, you have indeed been gracious to me. As a seventeen year-old youth, he vowed, "I will give Christ all of my life, my loyalty, and my love"(anonymous source).

He believed that Christian repentance must include confession of past sin. This brought his first crisis. The guilt over cheating in Bible exams at Trinity weighed heavily on him. To admit the sin was very

difficult because he had always taken pride in winning the highest honors in class. And confession could be costly, since the penalty for cheating was expulsion. Fortunately the Principal understood his change of heart and allowed him to continue.

Soon after his conversion Dora Yu visited Fuzhou again and Nee withdrew from Trinity to study in her Shanghai Bible school for one year. But he returned with a totally different direction in his life. In place of his previous ambitions he now chose to be an evangelist, the profession he had once labeled "the most despised and base of all occupations." He became very intense in his spiritual life, carrying a Bible with him everywhere, and reading it constantly. He witnessed to all his classmates, confessed his wrongdoing, and asked forgiveness of each one he might have offended. He prayed systematically for each one as he witnessed to them. Before long all but one were converted!

Now he said he had a lust to preach and witness. Preaching became his very life. He and a small group of other students preached in the streets of the city, in neighboring villages, and in local schools and colleges. Since they were considered to be among the elite of their society, they were well received by all social classes. As they preached some of their number maintained a twenty-four hour prayer vigil. Within a year there were scores of new converts and many house meetings for prayer and Bible study were established.

SEEKING A MORE AUTHENTIC FORM OF THE CHURCH

Through the ministry of Dora Yu a group of outstanding young men was called to ministry in 1921. As they studied the Scriptures together they concluded that believers were to celebrate Communion frequently, contrary to the practice in their more formal churches. As they began to break bread together every week, share testimonies, and encourage all to participate, they experienced a much more profound sense of worship and fellowship. Nee described the first time. "As long as I live, I will remember that experience. I was never so close to the heavens as on that night…On that day we knew what it meant to worship and remember the Lord" (Anonymous source). They continued to meet weekly in the home of Leland Wang, a former naval officer, who was recognized as their leader. That small group can be seen as the original assembly of the 'Little Flock.'

Nee continued in this small fellowship from 1921 to 1923. Like the 'Holy Club' at Oxford the members pursued a deep devotional life and avidly studied the Scriptures. They evangelized actively in the streets and many were converted. Now a third remarkable woman, Ruth Li, entered Nee's life. She had once been a convinced atheist, and as principal of a government normal school in Nanjing, had confiscated the Bibles of the Christian students and publicly burned them. But two students and a teacher committed

themselves to pray for her and finally she embraced Christ. She resigned her post and became an evangelist. In 1922 she led an evangelistic crusade in the city and because of her friendship with Leland Wang, stayed for four extra days of meetings in his home. Because of the number of those who responded, Wang, Nee, and others continued to preach to increasing numbers. Because more space was needed they rented a house. Nee began to be especially concerned about the spiritual growth of the new converts and began to publish a mimeographed paper, "Revival," with some of his Bible studies. Publishing his studies and insights into the Christian life would eventually become an essential and growing part of his ministry.

A remarkable aspect of Nee's life was the influence of four remarkable women in a culture that traditionally taught that they were to be submissive to men. The fourth was Margaret Barber, who had served under the Anglican Church Missionary Society since 1899. But while in England in 1909 she became convinced that believers' baptism was essential and was baptized by immersion in an independent chapel. Forced to leave the mission with its financial support she returned to Fuzhou to live by faith in 1920. She soon began to pray that God would raise up young Chinese men and women to reach their country. With the assistance of a Chinese preacher, Li Ai-ming, she established a training school which Nee and his friends sometimes attended. Under her influence, Nee, his mother, and brother, asked Li Ai-ming to baptize them by immersion on Easter Sunday, March 28, 1921. Others followed their example. When the Methodist superintendent heard of their meetings to break bread, and their baptism, he came to express his concern. A few days later Nee wrote him, asking that his name be removed from the Methodist roll. He said, "We are doing this not because of any personal animosity, but simply because we wish to obey the Scriptures…The real issue is whether or not we will obey the Scriptures." This act expressed his desire to be radically obedient to Scripture and to Jesus Christ, the Lord of Scripture. It is ironic that probably without realizing it, Nee followed more closely the example of John Wesley here than did the Methodist Church at that time. He and his colleagues simply wanted to be biblical Christians in their context just as Wesley in 18th century England. And like Wesley, Nee would seek to create a form of the Church and its leadership that he believed to be biblical and more relevant to his context in 20th century China.

In the midst of this frenzied evangelistic activity Nee's vision began to expand in two directions. He believed that too many Christians were superficial in their faith. He began to focus on the necessity of solid biblical teaching designed to lead people to serious, growing discipleship. Secondly he saw the need for the birth of local churches that would continue to grow in numbers and depth. These emphases along with personality differences led to

division. In a devastating blow, Nee was asked to leave the group led by Leland Wang. As he sought direction for his future ministry Miss Barber was his primary mentor. Her teaching on the Christian life, the work of the Holy Spirit, and the walk of faith impressed him deeply. He often expressed his debt to her. Above all, he said, she focused on the lesson of the cross. He would eventually seek to become a person of the cross, refusing to defend himself when falsely accused. Her anti-denominationalism also influenced him. So did her attitude toward money. She lived by faith, often down to her last coin. He decided to do the same, even though he had come from a family with some financial resources.

He studied the scriptures avidly, using various methods including word studies in Greek and Hebrew. He became known as one 'consumed by God's Word.'

Oriented by Miss Barber he read holiness authors from the Keswick movement including Jessie Penn-Lewis. The theme of spiritual warfare within human nature, important in her thought, became a strong influence. He was already seeking a simpler, more flexible church structure. Reading the works of J.N. Darby and other Brethren writers encouraged this. The catholicity of his reading was remarkable. It included Luther, Knox, Wesley, Finney, Spurgeon, Edwards, and Bunyan, great exegetes like Westcott and Lightfoot, along with missionary figures like Hudson Taylor, A.B. Simpson, and David Brainerd. He also read the life and writings of Madam Guyon, the French mystic, and Cardinal Newman. And we remember that he was well versed in the Chinese classics, Now he determined to spend one third of his income on books, which he ordered from England.

In 1924 he became seriously ill with tuberculosis but continued to preach and teach. He became very weak and was forced to rest while Miss Barber and others cared for him. Finally he appeared to be dying. He became unconscious and his friends feared that he had died. Miss Barber continued to pray over him, read Scripture, and constantly affirmed, 'Christ is the Victor.' Miraculously his health began to improve and in four months he was completely well.

In 1927 Nee moved to Shanghai and began a new phase of ministry. It was a period of rapid social change in China. Earlier the overthrow of the Manchu dynasty and the beginning of the Chinese Republic brought great new opportunities to Christian missions. From 1910 to 1920 many of the newly educated classes expressed interest in the Christian faith and joined the churches. Medical and educational work expanded rapidly. But by 1928 the popularity of Christianity and western education had subsided. The memory of the China's defeat in the two opium wars and the May Fourth Movement brought strong anti-foreign feelings. From 1925 to 1928 a fresh outburst of anti-imperialistic feeling among students and the formation of the Anti-Christian Alliance resulted in riots. Chinese Christians and

missionaries were killed, and many of the latter fled to the international settlement in Shanghai. Some Chinese churches severed their links with foreigners.

Nee never participated in these events, but one of his brothers was killed in a revolutionary demonstration. However he was certainly part of the new China and must have felt, subconsciously at least, some resentment over the domination of Westerners in the churches even though he felt indebted to the missionaries for bringing the Gospel to China. Thus we can see how his discovery of a simpler model of the Church in the New Testament, coupled with his nationalism led him to begin his indigenous church movement. A third factor came from the rising Communist movement. Its agitators called Chinese Christians employed by foreign missions, 'running dogs of imperialists.' We can understand Nee's desire to clear himself and his movement from this accusation.

Still another factor was his conviction that the level of spiritual life in the existing churches was superficial. He felt that most had lapsed into lukewarm religious secularism. Quality was being sacrificed for quantity. But he saw spiritual hunger among many young Chinese who were disillusioned with the existing churches. These factors plus his own constant biblical studies and his personal quest for authentic discipleship led him to establish his own movement. He became convinced that the only answer was a return to the patterns of Truth and church fellowship he found in the New Testament. So he decided to focus both on evangelism and ongoing discipleship. Jesus was to become for him, not only the One who brought forgiveness of sin, He was to be our life here on earth. He wrote, "God's purpose is to gain a group of people who are like His Son" (Anonymous source). And to accomplish his goal, a new kind of leadership had to be produced. "In God's work," he wrote, 'everything depends on the kind of worker sent out and the kind of convert produced" (Kinnear 1984:69).

THE FORMATION OF THE LITTLE FLOCK

On a Sunday late in 1927 Nee, Ruth Li, Charles Judd, and Peace Wang met in the latter's home to worship and break bread together. Judd was a member of the China Inland Mission and encouraged Nee and supported the early Little Flock meetings. Peace Wang was the daughter of a wealthy magistrate who had been persecuted and driven from her home when she became a Christian. She worked as an independent evangelist. Nee soon purchased a house where he established his own congregation, largely of students. He preached each Sunday morning and met with believers around the Table of the Lord in the evening. He was convinced that if they followed the New Testament model of evangelism, a strong local church, whose members were being discipled daily, would result.

Nee rejected all denominational labels and wanted to limit himself to the simplest

biblical terms. The building was called the 'Christian meeting hall,' his magazine, 'The Christian,' and the literature office, 'The Gospel Publishing House.' He spoke of the Christian life as 'the Way,' and referred to Christians simply as 'believers.' But when he published his first collection of hymns in 1928 it was entitled 'Hymns for the Little Flock,' taking the term from Luke 12:32. It included translations of foreign classics, others from a Brethren hymnal from England, and original compositions by himself and Miss Barber. The title appealed to him because it was unpretentious and effective in Chinese. His own preference was to use the terms, 'Christian Meeting Place,' or just, the Church. But after the publication of the hymnal, people began calling his congregation the 'Little Flock' (as we will do in this chapter). He quickly changed the title of the hymnbook, but the label stuck. Even though the movement itself deplored the name, it would become known across China by that name. The China Christian Year Book for 1935 mentioned the Little Flock for the first time. It spoke of its rapid growth and mentioned that it was drawing members and some leaders from the older churches. Most mission-related churches became quite critical of the movement at this time. Regarding the name, Nee always insisted that those in the movement should not use the term Little Flock. He wanted them to define themselves simply as Christians.

It is clear that Nee shared the concerns we have seen in other movements. How could the Gospel be heard by men and women in his context, not as a foreign message, but as one for the Chinese, relevant to their lives and culture? Secondly he sought a deeper, more radical understanding of the Christian life, one he believed would be more profoundly biblical. Thirdly he wanted a form of the Church modeled on the New Testament community as he understood it. This of course implied a more flexible form of the church, one not dominated by the clergy. That in turn implied a different model of selecting and preparing leadership. And the centrality of the Scriptures was paramount. Much more than simply a source of doctrine, they constituted the Word through which God speaks constantly to His people. And at the beginning, at least, the meetings consisted of small, face to face, fellowships for study, challenge, prayer, and the breaking of bread.

The issue of Nee's own theological and ecclesiastical identity became important in the 1930's. How should he relate his movement to the wider Christian community? He read widely and learned from a variety of Christian thinkers, including Roman Catholic mystics. He recognized the presence of true Christian believers in various traditions, but came to believe that the local congregation that followed the New Testament model as he understood it, was the only true Church. In 1931 he invited a number of well known Chinese evangelists and pastors to a conference, hoping to persuade them to adopt his pattern. But he was

unsuccessful. The following year he was welcomed into the fellowship of the Exclusive Brethren in England but was soon disillusioned by their complacency and self-righteous attitude toward others whom he admired. After being welcomed initially, he was excluded from their fellowship when he took the Lord's Supper with Christian leaders who were not part of the Brethren. On a personal note, in 1934 he was married to Charity Zhang, a friend from his school days. She had become a believer after attending meetings in the Shanghai fellowship.

In 1938 and 1939 he visited England again where he was welcomed by T. Austin-Sparks, a former Baptist who stressed a moderate form of exclusivism, stressed holy living and believed in a simple church structure. Together they attended the Keswick Convention where Nee led the group in prayer and addressed mission candidates. He participated in the Convention's united communion service. He also visited Paris and Copenhagen. In Denmark he gave a series of addresses based on Romans 5-8 entitled, 'The Normal Christian Life,' which later formed the basis of one of his best known books. Thus, for the next fifteen years after 1927, Nee gradually formulated his thought. He learned from his wide reading, contacts with friends in England, and a number of missionaries of the China Inland Mission, and blended his ideas into the Chinese context.

THE SHAPE OF THE CHURCH AND ITS LEADERSHIP

Above all, Nee sought to be biblical and christocentric in all that he did. He was also a serious student of church history. He believed he stood at a critical point in history, especially the history of China. Dissatisfied with the institutional church of his day, he sought a form of the church that he believed to be biblical and therefore, far more relevant and effective in his culture. Thus he rejected everything that he believed was not in accordance with Scripture, and regarded the correct understanding of the Church to be of the greatest importance.

He taught that the purpose of the Church, established by Christ, was to manifest His glory and serve as God's household on earth. On the practical level the purposes of God would be accomplished by three kinds of ministries: evangelism, the building up of believers, and service. But as we will see, service was to be directed mainly to believers.

Nee believed that the term 'ekklesia' in the New Testament did not imply any type of organization, it only referred to a group of people who had come to believe in Jesus Christ. “A New Testament church was not a building, a preaching center, an organization, denomination, or sect, it was simply the meeting together of all the people of God in a locality for worship, prayer, fellowship, and mutual edification" (Anonymous source).The Church was composed of all spiritual men and women who were united with Christ, believers who were living out the life of Christ, one with Him, filled with the Holy Spirit. In a broadly

ecumenical statement he wrote, "The church is Christ in Christians around the world, throughout all the centuries, put together…. You have a portion of Christ and each one of us has a portion of Christ. When all of these portions of Christ are put together, there is the church" (anonymous source).

This obviously implied great flexibility of structure. Thus any group of believers in Jesus Christ gathered together constituted the church in that place. This might imply that Nee was indifferent to questions of polity and structure in the church. However we will see that that was not the case. He recognized the need for structure with defined leadership, albeit one that was simple, infinitely reproducible, with a minimum of hierarchy. He was convinced that he found such a structure in the New Testament.

A second aspect of his understanding of the church is more controversial. It centered on his interpretation of the phrase "ek tou kosmou," out of the world.
For him the word 'kosmos' referred to the world order governed by Satan. It included politics, education, literature, science, arts, commerce, law, and music. Thus he categorized everything in the world into two opposing alternatives: the things of God and those of Satan. The clear implication was that Christians were called to stand in opposition to the 'kosmos' and become completely isolated from their societies. This concept also fit into his dispensationalist premillenialism, in which the Kingdom of God was understood as purely spiritual and highly individualistic. While this concept might strengthen the movement under a regime of persecution, it could easily lead to irrelevance in a more open society.

Nee's reading of Revelation, chapters two and three guided his understanding of church history and the place of his movement within it. He saw four phases: Roman Catholicism, the Protestant Reformation, the Brethren movement, then the point when the latter became just another denomination. He believed that his movement was like the Philadelphia church, composed of local churches whose only creed was the Word of God and whose only label was Christian. In other words he believed that his movement had become a genuinely post-denominational church and pointed the way to the unity of the Body of Christ. An essential principle was "one locality, one church. All the churches in the Bible were local… All the children of God in the same locality must be one" (anonymous source).

Nee was saddened by the denominational divisions imported into China. In Fujian province where he was raised he was confronted by a number of missionary societies that differed in their teachings and methods. He could find no biblical justification for their differences, and affirmed that the New Testament knew nothing of Methodist, Anglican, or Presbyterian churches. In his interpretation of Galatians 5:20 he saw denominationalism as a work of the flesh and consequently as sin. Therefore

believers should leave such unclean organizations and encourage others to do the same. He criticized western missionary societies because of their divisions, their importation of Anglo-American customs and practices, translations of Scripture that he believed to be inaccurate, and their inability to fit in with Chinese culture and community. He saw Hudson Taylor as an exception.

But while he was critical of many aspects of Western missions he did not fall into the extreme anti-foreign and anti-missionary tendencies of many. He maintained western contacts and encouraged many missionaries to join his movement. He even appointed one, Thornton Stearns, as an elder of the Shanghai church (anonymous source) And when missionaries were leaving China in 1951 he met with several from the China Inland Mission. He invited them to return when it became possible, and to become teaching elders in the local churches (anonymous source).

Nee and his followers believed they were participating in God's recovery of the true Church. They believed it had been degraded for centuries but was now being restored according to God's original intention according to His unchanging standard revealed in His Word. The New Testament model of the Church should be the norm for today. And this meant that there could only be one church in a given locality, whether a village or a city. But elders might conduct meetings in different places in a city such as Shanghai. He was also willing to break down large cities into different administrative units with a local church in each one. This insistence on 'one locality, one church,' came not only from his reading of Scripture, but from his concern for church unity. The unity of the Body of Christ was an overarching concern; first because it was biblical, and secondly, because disunity denied an essential aspect of the Gospel and produced a negative witness.

Nee rejected the form of ministry in traditional Protestant churches because he felt it had become too much like the Roman Catholic priestly and mediatorial system. He sought to return to the New Testament (and Reformation) teaching of the priesthood of all believers. As we have seen, this seems to be a constant factor in renewal movements throughout history. He wrote, "I am not against pastors but against the office of pastors…the position of the pastor which obliterates the work of Christ" (anonymous source) Thus he recognized the pastoral gift, but not the pastoral office. When he used the term 'minister of the Word,' he was not referring to a professional minister but rather to any member of his churches. "A minister of the Word is one who has the revelation of Christ, one in whom God has been pleased to reveal His Son" (anonymous source).

Issues revolving around structure and leadership are critical in any movement that seeks to take seriously the gifts and ministry of every believer. How can the church be structured in such a way that it

recognizes the need for leadership in administration and teaching while still encouraging every believer to discover and use his or her gifts in ministry. A related question is the process by which leaders will be selected and prepared for their ministries. A third issue will focus on the relationship of the leaders to their local congregations.

So even though Nee spoke often against traditional church organizations, his church was soon well organized. He gave very detailed instructions to his younger colleagues in matters of church organization, government, and administration. The polity, as we might expect, was basically congregationalist, with autonomous churches free from the control of any centralized authority. But the local church was not to be a democratic assembly as we shall see.

Church Offices: Apostles

Nee found three church offices in the New Testament. One group, the apostles, served the universal Church, the other two, elders and deacons, served local churches. He distinguished between the original apostles who were witnesses to the resurrection of Christ, and other apostles, such as Barnabas and Paul's other companions, who were sent out on their missionary journeys. He defined an apostle as one "especially commissioned of God to found churches through the preaching of the Gospel, to bring revelation from God to His people, to give decisions in matters pertaining to doctrine and government, and to edify the saints and distribute the gifts." An apostle is in constant movement. "A true apostle is a traveler, not a settler" (Anonymous source). Furthermore apostles had no rules to follow and no superiors to obey. They were to be directed only by the Holy Spirit.

Apostles were not to lead local churches. By the authority of the Holy Spirit they were to appoint elders in the new congregations they established. And only apostles had the right to appoint elders, following Acts 14:23. Because a church always covered a city, to appoint elders for a local church was to appoint them for the locality, village or city. But the apostle had no authority in the local church once elders had been appointed. When visiting a local church, an apostle might advise and make recommendations but he had no administrative authority. However we must ask if his spiritual authority would not normally be recognized in most cases, giving him significant influence in administrative as well as theological matters. Nee regarded himself as an apostle. And his implicit if not his explicitauthority must have been great when he spoke on any issue.

How were apostles to be chosen? Nee called the 'responsible brothers' together to make the decision according to the principles of the New Testament and the guidance of the Holy Spirit. After praying and fasting they chose 'faithful ones' from the 'responsible brothers' to whom such responsibility could be given. They laid

hands on them, and committed them to the Lord. At the end of the 1930's, forty such apostles were at work. (Anonymous source)

Elders/Overseers

The term refered to two aspects of the office. Elder referred to the person, who was to be a spiritually mature member of a local church. This was of course in keeping with Confucian culture in which filial piety and respect for elders was a high value. Elders were to be over thirty years of age. Overseer referred to his functions: teaching, administration, and caring for the flock. Their qualifications were given in Titus 1:6-9 and I Tim. 3:2-7. All elders were to be men. The authority in the local church was placed in their hands. Church government, business affairs, the care of material things, as well as teaching, were their responsibility. The deacons were to carry out their decisions. But each church was to have multiple elders. No church was to be ruled by one person alone. That could easily lead to pride and dictatorship. Nee's understanding of the decision making process showed wisdom and was in keeping with Chinese culture.

> There is no room for despotism or democracy. Nothing should be settled by the opinion of one man or by voting. The final decision making in the church is always in the hands of those who possess spiritual authority. But everybody should be given an opportunity to speak. Let them speak and you listen, trying to feel the movement of the Spirit until you can finally stand up and say, 'Brothers, the few of us have decided on this matter.' In the church there is no such a thing as the minority obeying the majority or vice versa. In the church we have only brothers and sisters expressing their opinion, leaving those who have attained spiritual maturity to choose. After the decision is made, the whole church should dedicate themselves with one accord to carry it out (anonymous source).

Thus the elders were to be simply 'brothers,' chosen because of their spiritual maturity by the Holy Spirit through the apostles. They were to lead the church as its servants.

Deacons/Deaconesses

The second office in the local church was that of deacon/deaconess. That was the only office open to women. Each church was to have several deacons, the number depending on the size and needs of the local congregation. Like the elders, deacons were to be appointed by the apostle, who was to seek to discover those whom the Holy Spirit had already indicated. The qualifications of deacons were revealed in I Tim. 3:8-13. They were to carry out administrative and pastoral functions under the authority of the elders.

We can see here a heavy emphasis on authority and submission. Everyone in the

church was expected to be submissive both to the spiritual authority of the elders and to each other as well. We remember that the focus on obedience to the elderly, especially men, was one of the five 'perfect virtues' taught by Confucius. This insistence on authority and submission, coupled with a strong sense of discipline, would serve the movement well under persecution.

It seems strange that despite the crucial role played by four different women in Nee's conversion and spiritual journey, the office of deacon was the only one open to women in the Little Flock. Nee based his understanding of the role of women on his reading of Scripture, but was influenced no doubt by his early association with the English Brethren and by Chinese culture. He insisted on the basis of I Cor. 11:2-16 and 14:34 that women should cover their heads and not preach or teach in the churches. He based this on his understanding of the order of creation in which God the Father is the head of Christ, Christ the head of the Church, and men the head of women. He insisted that this subordination did not imply inferiority, but only difference of function. His mentor, Miss Barber, did not agree with him at this point.

So women in most Little Flock churches quietly play the role of helpers, involved in many activities but out of the public eye. Charity Zheng, Nee's wife, always remained in the background, supporting her husband in every way. Even Nee's mother, still a dominant figure at home, was simply one of the sisters when in church. Peace Wang, Ruth Li, and other women leaders were heavily involved in personal counseling, praying for the sick, and meeting other needs.

However that has changed both because of persecution and the passing of time.
Many Little Flock churches do not adhere strictly to the prohibition against women teaching or preaching. Often when 'responsible brothers' were not present, women evangelists including Peace Wang and Ruth Li have preached and taught. And currently women lead many house churches. In some cases this is because their husbands have been imprisoned or killed but in other cases it appears that their ministries are recognized as valid in themselves.

Baptism, which is by immersion, and the Lord's Supper are to be administered by the elders, but when necessary other laymen, called 'responsible brothers' may do so. Thus 'responsible brothers' and 'responsible sisters' seem to be an unofficial category of leadership. But women are not normally allowed to baptize or serve the Lord's Supper.

Alongside the strong focus on Nee's understanding of the Church and the Christian life, a broader principle prevailed. A writer with long experience inside the movement insisted somewhat paradoxically, that while its adherents stand apart from organized churches they do not reject their brothers and sisters in Christ.

> "They receive those who speak in tongues and those who do not speak in tongues; those who have been immersed and those who have been sprinkled, those who wear a headcovering and those who do not…those who practice foot washing and those who do not...They receive all Christians, no matter what kind of Christians they are...As long as a person receives Jesus Christ as his personal Savior, regardless of the concepts he/she holds regarding other things, God receives him/her immediately. So the Little Flock churches must receive people in the same way" (anonymous source)

Nee insisted that each local church was autonomous, that its authority was final. There was no organization higher than the local assembly. It should neither submit to the control of any organization nor exercise control over any other church. In his interpretation of Acts 15 Nee denied that the Jerusalem church exercised authority over Paul and Barnabas or the Antioch church. Furthermore he made no distinction between Chinese and foreign believers in a given locality. All should be part of one church.

Nee was greatly influenced by the faith principles of Hudson Taylor and George Muller along with Margaret Barber and Dora Yu. This was related to his understanding of the priesthood of all believers. A priest was to offer himself/ herself completely to God. This included time, talents, and finance. He insisted that every church be self-supporting. Offerings were not taken during worship, instead a collection box was placed at the back of the meeting place. Workers had no fixed salary. Many, if not most, were self-supporting. The financial needs of some were met either by part-time work or offerings from the church or individual believers. In general the believers were generous and all the churches were self-supporting.

EVANGELISM AND GROWTH

Nee was a zealous evangelist. When he was not poring over Scripture he wrote magazine articles, evangelistic tracts, and instruction manuals for his co-workers. At other times he was on the streets modeling his admonition, 'witness to at least one person a day.'

He believed that the church in China must give priority to evangelization, for him, China was the primary mission field. It could be reached with the Gospel only if the entire church was mobilized and every believer became an evangelist or missionary. He wrote, "The entire church must work...If the church does not grow to a stage when the entire church works and serves, it is no church" (anonymous source). He taught that every person, no matter where he/she went, should be preaching the Gospel.

In order to reach out to other areas, he found two fundamental methods in Scripture, what he called the Antioch way

and the Jerusalem way. The first involved sending out apostles to plant churches in other areas of the country. As we have seen, after establishing churches, the apostles were to appoint elders to lead them and then move on. They were to follow the example of Paul, Barnabas, Timothy, and Silas.

He called the second method, the Jerusalem way. It was mission by emigration and soon became even more effective. Beginning in the early 30's, the movement sent mature believers to places where no Christian witness existed, for the specific purpose of evangelizing. Groups of families, representing various trades and professions, doctors, teachers, shoemakers, barbers, were chosen and carefully prepared for the venture. These gave themselves to the church, which in turn supplied travelling expenses and three months' living allowance. At the end of that period they were expected to support themselves while engaged in evangelism. The new converts would immediately be given basic training in Christian living and service and eventually be sent to other places as emigrants to repeat the process. Obviously this method brought the possibility of very rapid multiplication of churches. Nee believed that by using this method, all of China could be evangelized within fourteen or fifteen years. Hundreds of families went out from Shanghai and Fuzhou in this venture and by 1948 they had established over two hundred new assemblies. The founder of a new church would be called a 'responsible brother.' After the new congregation was established an apostle or two or three senior elders from other places would come and appoint the 'brother' and others as elders. This method was important in the years leading up to 1949, and Nee and his associates worked day and night writing training materials to orient the workers.

For Nee, the main objective of the church was to lead its people into service. A church was not a church until all were involved in service. There were five aspects of this service: evangelism, follow-up of new converts prior to baptism, visitation of the new converts, the giving of help to brothers and sisters in difficulty because of illness, family problems, funerals, and weddings, and the care of newly arrived members from distant places. Thus the concept of service apparently was focused only on the church and its members or potential members.

Nee suggested that each member should bring three or four others to the Gospel meetings, sitting between them in order to give them maximum attention, helping them to find the passages of Scripture and hymns. Then the believer should attempt to persuade his/her friends to embrace the Gospel, praying with them and getting them registered for follow-up work. Using these methods the movement grew to number 70,000 believers in seven hundred congregations by 1949, ten per cent of all Protestants in China.

DIFFICULTIES DURING AND AFTER THE JAPANESE OCCUPATION

The Japanese invasion of China in 1937 brought serious problems for the churches, Christian work in general was allowed to continue but under greater surveillance and attempts at control by the occupying forces. After the attack on Pearl Harbor by the Japanese and American entry into the war in December, 1941,the situation changed. American and British missionaries left or were gathered into internment camps. Because of necessity and pressure from Japan the churches moved toward greater unity and independence from the West. At the same time many schools, hospitals, and church buildings were destroyed. Most pastors had to find means of support outside the churches.

The Little Flock church in Shanghai suffered financially during the occupation. This placed a great burden on Nee since the movement was growing rapidly and workers needed to be supported. He was critical of mission churches with their salaried pastors who constituted a burden on local congregations. He had set up a chain of assemblies led by full-time workers who received no salary of any kind, but now had to assume responsibility for some of them. There were also full-time itinerant apostles to be sustained. The church in Shanghai alone had two hundred workers who needed support. They might receive some gifts from churches or individual believers, and were taught to live the life of faith. But to some degree they were Nee's responsibility. Their finances came from a special fund that he and two or three other senior leaders controlled. Now the Japanese war curtained economic activity, caused inflation, and left many workers nearly destitute. Nee had taught that during exceptional periods workers might work to support themselves and some now did so.

Nee also took this step. In order to support himself and his co-workers he accepted an invitation to manage a pharmaceutical factory established by his brother. In 1942 he became chairman of the board. The company employed many of Nee's co-workers, enabling them to continue their ministries, while the profits went to support the two hundred workers throughout the country.

However the affairs of the company weighed heavily on him and occupied more and more of his time. His preaching ministry suffered and this caused acrimony and division in the Shanghai church. He was accused of leaving his ministry and drifting toward the world. At the end of 1942 the elders decided that he could no longer preach there. Believers all over China were greatly troubled by this turn of events. Nee was deeply hurt and felt betrayed by his friends but refused to defend himself. He continued to provide financial support to his co-workers, including some who had opposed him.

A further setback came when the Japanese attempted to force unification on the churches of Shanghai and the Little Flock refused join the larger body. As a result the church was forced to close. In response the movement continued to

function as house churches, meeting in private homes. This practice, an indication of things to come, continued until September, 1945. At that time the mother church was reopened under the leadership of Elder Yu Chenghua, an opthomologist.

As the church continued to struggle to re-establish itself, Nee, still under discipline, asked Witness Lee, one of his most capable leaders to assume leadership of the Shanghai church. In a few months confidence was restored, members of the house churches returned to corporate worship, and there was great growth. This necessitated new structures in 1947. The growing numbers attending house groups were divided into districts, which were further divided into sections. Believers met at the central church on Saturday evenings for fellowship and Sunday mornings for the ministry of the Word. Three times each week they met as 'families' in fifteen different locations. Sunday evening was for the breaking of bread, Tuesday evenings for prayer, and Friday evening for instruction of new converts. The elders continued to be in charge of the whole church but each 'family' was led by a 'leading brother' with several 'deacons in training' to help. This spread the witness throughout the city and provided a means of recruitment and training of new leaders.

As the numbers continued to grow, pastoral care was a concern. Now the 'families,' each numbering from forty to two hundred, were divided again into platoons averaging fifteen persons. Often they lived near each other. Two persons in each platoon had the responsibility to care for the spiritual condition of the members. This system, like Wesley's classes, preserved the intimacy of the original smaller meetings, and encouraged the development of the gifts of each one.

In a disturbing development, Lee began the practice of 'fencing the Lord's Table,' which had previously been open to all believers. Now each communicant had to have a badge and be introduced by an elder before participating. Lee also further emphasized authority and submission, and a form of hierarchy evolved. An order of seniority was expressed by a row of chairs at the front.

NEE'S RETURN: BETWEEN THE JAPANESE WAR AND THE COMMUNIST VICTORY

Finally in 1948 Nee was invited by the elders to return to the Shanghai church. After a time of mutual confession and prayer there was reconciliation. When Nee spoke again for the first time in the church, the building that could normally hold 400, was packed with over 1500 believers. The first seat in the row of chairs was again reserved for him. Within a month two hundred new believers were baptized and plans were made to purchase land for a larger meeting hall.

Coming out of the turmoil of the Japanese war, and aware of the civil war in China between the Nationalists and Communists, Nee and his colleagues felt a great sense of urgency. 'Render unto God the things

that are God's' became an important theme and was expressed in the term 'handing over.' This included handing over oneself, handing over the church to the evangelization of China, and handing over possessions for the task. Nee handed over his entire factory to the Shanghai assembly. Others handed over clothing, jewelry, savings, and even their companies for the use of the church. Soon the church experienced great material prosperity. Before long this would attract the attention of new Communist government.

In 1948 Nee could see what lay ahead. He told his co-workers, "There is clearly trouble ahead of us and we are going to suffer as Christians, but the church in China will survive these trials" (Anonymous source). He initiated intensive training programs for his workers. These covered themes such as the qualifications of a Christian worker, the ministry of God's Word, principles of spiritual authority, problems of sickness, business affairs of the local church, principles of the extension of the Gospel, and how to study the Bible. By mid-1948 he was training one hundred new workers.

At the end of 1949 when Chiang Kai-shek moved to Taiwan he was accompanied by thousands of refugees from China, including members of the Little Flock. Now Nee sent his most trusted co-workers abroad, his wife, Charity and others to Hong Kong, Witness Lee to Taiwan, and others to Manila and Singapore. When he visited Hong Kong his co-workers urged him over and over again to remain but he refused. He considered himself to be an apostle and noted that the original apostles had remained in Jerusalem despite persecution. So he returned to Shanghai.

NEE AND THE LITTLE FLOCK UNDER COMMUNISM

After the People's Republic of China was established in 1949 the government took a number of initiatives to consolidate its power. Among them were steps to bring the church in China under its authority. Christian leaders were expected to sign a 'Christian Manifesto' to show their faithfulness to the government. The 'Three-Self Reform Movement,' established in 1950 was renamed the 'Three-Self Patriotic Movement' (TSPM) in 1954 and all churches were pressured to join. Christian leaders who did not were labeled 'counter-revolutionaries.' Denunciation movements were initiated in 1951 to rid the church of those whom the government considered disloyal. By the end of 1951 nearly all missionaries had left China and all missionary institutions in the country had been confiscated.

The first denunciation against Nee came in 1951. He was accused of totalitarian control over 470 churches and disseminating 'anti-revolutionary poison.' In 1952 authorities insisted on a denunciation meeting in the Shanghai church. It was unsuccessful in their eyes. But on April 10, 1952 Nee was arrested, charged with being a 'lawless capitalist

tiger,' and accused of various crimes in addition to gross immorality. He was imprisoned and would never know another day of physical freedom. Some Little Flock assemblies joined the TSPM beginning in 1951, but most began to withdraw in 1953. The Shanghai assembly withdrew in 1955.

In 1956 authorities concentrated again on Nee and the Little Flock. They saw it as a major obstacle to their control of the Chinese church. Nee was tried and condemned as head of a 'counter-revolutionary clique.' His writings and evangelistic work were said to be a cloak for activities against the state. In January a twelve-day series of denunciation meetings was held in one of the churches. The entire congregation was required to attend. A second series began in February with over 3000 in attendance. Finally in April the church publicly announced its 'rebirth' and formally joined the TSPM. However it appears that the great majority of Little Flock members remained outside the TSPM and met in homes, giving further impetus to the house church movement.

In June Nee was brought before the high court in Shanghai again. There the authorities announced that the Little Flock had excommunicated him. He was sentenced to fifteen years in prison, beginning in April, 1952. Ruth Li and Peace Wang, who had refused to condemn him received the same sentence. Around the same time, in 1955, another strong Christian leader, Wang Mingdao, was imprisoned. These two men, perhaps more than any others, represented the conscience of the church in China.

Little is known of the last twenty years of Nee's life, except that he suffered terribly. It was said that his weight dropped to less than one hundred pounds. His days were divided into eight-hour periods of harsh labor, 're-education,' and then loneliness in his dark cell. There was a report that he was offered the possibility of public reinstatement as a Christian leader if he would lead his movement into the TSPM, but he refused. He also refused to denounce any of his co-workers. He continued to evangelize any within his reach. In 1968 a visitor to a western city asked for political asylum and said he had been a guard in the Shanghai prison. Through Nee's witness he had become a Christian. Even though his fifteen-year sentence was completed in 1967 Nee was not released because he had not responded to the re-education process. On May 30, 1972 he wrote to his sister-in-law reporting poor health. Forbidden to mention the name of God, he declared, "the inward joy surpasses everything" Anonymous source). The following day he died. After his death a note was found under his pillow with the following words in his shaky handwriting.

> Christ is the Son of God. He died as the Redeemer for the sins of mankind and was raised up from the dead after three days. This is the most important fact in the world. I shall die believing in Christ. Nee Tuo-sheng (Watchman Nee)

(anonymous source).

Nee's wife, Charity Zhang was released from prison in 1957 but without civil rights. She suffered terribly and was tortured during the Cultural Revolution. She died in 1971.

THE CONTRIBUTION OF THE LITTLE FLOCK TO THE CHURCH IN CHINA AND BEYOND

The 'Great Proletarian Cultural Revolution' lasted from 1966 to 1976, bringing great suffering to the people and total suppression to the church. All churches and seminaries were closed and Bibles, hymnbooks, and other Christian books were seized and burned. Church buildings were confiscated or destroyed, homes of Christians were invaded, and thousands of Christians were publicly ridiculed, imprisoned, tortured, or killed. But just when many believed that the church in China had been destroyed, a new phenomenon, the house church movement, appeared.

Meetings in homes for prayer and Bible study had always been a common form of church life in China. As we have seen it became a feature of the Little Flock in Shanghai during and after the Japanese occupation. Even before the Cultural Revolution many Christians who did not want to be part of the TSPM gathered in homes, even though it was illegal. Now, with the total suppression of the church as an institution, Christians were driven underground and house churches became the only strategy for survival. But more than survival, there was revival. It began to occur among Christians all over China, stimulated in part at least, by Nee's writings and example.

The story of one family is an example of the faithfulness and heroism of many.
In 1941 the father founded a Little Flock assembly in a city in the north, and in 1945 was made an elder. During the 50's he was severely persecuted and in 1956 was imprisoned for two years as part of Nee's 'counter-revolutionary clique.' Arrested again in 1960 he was sent to an area near the Russian border to do hard labor. Members of the church helped sustain the family but two young sons and the grandfather died of starvation. Soon afterward the mother died. After the beginning of the Cultural Revolution the assembly hall was destroyed, Christian homes were searched, and all Bibles and Christian literature were burned. On his return, this man remained faithful, leading his family in worship behind heavily shuttered windows. During the latter years of the Cultural Revolution he restored the fellowship, leading worship in his home. In 1977 the house church was discovered and he was arrested again, remaining a prisoner until the end of 1980. But the younger generation continued in leadership and the house churches flourished. After he returned, his fellowship grew to five thousand believers (anonymous source).

There were many reports of miraculous activity, especially during the Cultural Revolution. These included healings, protection against raids by enemies, xorcisms, and deliverance from natural disasters. Nee believed that such phenomena occurred today but taught that the gifts of the Spirit were primarily for evangelism. And evangelism was now the major focus. House churches grew and flourished, especially as the Cultural Revolution began to subside. Evangelists traveled from village to village and people gathered in their homes for worship, prayer, and Bible study.

One writer suggested eight qualities that enabled the house churches to remain faithful and grow during the years of persecution.

1. Suffering purified the church. There were no ulterior motives for people to join.

2. Love and loyalty to the Lord Jesus became central in the thinking of Chinese Christians. They discovered that faith in Christ meant obedience and taking up the cross.

3. Under persecution Christians of many traditions learned to worship together, denominational distinctions were largely ignored.

4. Loyalty to one another was essential. They learned to support each other in times of hardship and realize the importance of mutual trust, for if anyone betrayed the group, great suffering followed.

5. The church witnessed more by actions than by words. With little opportunity to preach to non-Christians, believers showed their faith by lowly acts of service and love for their neighbors.

6. The Word of God was precious. Suffering from a lack of teaching, with Bibles with Christian literature scarce, they showed their love for the Bible by making copies and sharing portions of Scripture.

7. The power of prayer became very real to them. They experienced the healing ministry of the Holy Spirit and saw people delivered from disease and the oppression of evil spirits in answer to prayer.

8. It was a church rooted in the home and integrated into the family system. This spread the Gospel effectively.

(anonymous source)

Government policy became less restrictive in 1976 and now some Christians could meet openly. In 1979 a growing number of churches were reopened, the TSPM was re-established, and pastors and evangelists released from prison. It is estimated that by then the number of Protestant Christians had grown to between four and five million, primarily because of the house church movement.

Today, after the restoration of the TSPM, there seem to be three primary categories of churches in China. The first of course are the 'Three-Self' churches, sanctioned by the government and numbering fifty thousand congregations and meeting points, with approximately sixteen million believers. The second is made up of various networks of house fellowships. The third group is composed of house churches that have registered with the government. The Little Flock assembly led by the man described above, fits into the latter category. The latest statistics given in Operation World claims ninety million Christians in China, including Roman Catholics, who number around fifteen million. This would indicate around fifty-nine million adherents in the various categories of house churches. The same work suggests that members of the Little Flock have reached between fifteen and twenty million (anonymous source). This figure comes from a number of sources including interviews with many house church leaders. However it is not possible to give a figure with precision. Some Little Flock churches have kept their separate identity, others have merged into the wider house church movement, and as we have seen, some are registered with the government.

However we can assert without doubt that the church in China has seen remarkable growth over the last fifty years, without parallel in history. It is also certain that Watchman Nee and his movement have played a significant role in that growth. Well beyond those groups identified as Little Flock churches the influence of Nee is strong. His simple church structure provided a model for many others during persecution. His works on the church and the Christian life are valued and read by other house church leaders and even by many in the Three-Self churches.

Nee's influence has been important in the Pentecostal/charismatic movement as well as the house churches in general. Even though Nee was not a Pentecostal, his writings on sanctification and holiness have been well received in such circles. Some in the True Jesus Church and the Jesus Family have found Nee's writings to be among the few they accept beyond the Bible.

Among the areas with greatest church growth since the 1970's are three coastal provinces: Fujian, Zhejiang, and Jiangsu. Some claim that five to ten per cent of the population in some parts of these provinces are now Christians. These areas were important centers of the Little Flock and the True Jesus Church earlier.

Today, in addition to new believers, a typical house church may include former Little Flock members along with Baptists, Presbyterians, Anglicans, and others. And while many groups still maintain the Little Flock identity and follow Nee's teachings explicitly, it is more important to note that most house churches exhibit the characteristics of Nee's movement. They are indigenous and flexible, having developed heir own forms of ministry. They are rooted in family units and thus a

part of Chinese social structure. And they can meet anywhere. Leaders are raised up from within the group as their gifts are recognized, training is usually non-formal or informal. The authority of apostles and elders is often emphasized. And they focus strongly on the study of Scripture. Believers share their faith boldly and care for the practical needs of other members. They even reach out to those, government officials and others, who have persecuted them.

There were specific aspects of the Christian message that appealed powerfully to men and women suffering under a totalitarian government and then the Cultural Revolution. It was a message of hope to people who were hopeless. House church growth was especially great in rural areas among peasants. They were seen as poor and ignorant by their society but they became rich spiritually as they worshipped and studied the Scriptures. There they discovered they were called to become sons and daughters of God through Christ. So the Gospel message brought meaning to their lives. A third aspect, especially important in Chinese culture, was the issue of filial piety and harmony in the home. While harmony in the home was emphasized in Confucian culture, it was common for mothers-in-law and daughters-in-law to live in conflict. Often when they became Christians a radical change came and harmony ensued. This constituted a powerful witness to outsiders.

Thus while the house church movement has been shaped by many factors and leaders, the influence of Nee can scarcely be exaggerated. He was extremely important in the unparalleled growth of the Chinese church.

NEE'S INFLUENCE BEYOND CHINA; GROWTH AND SCHISM

The Little Flock movement spread quickly to Taiwan where it is now the second largest Christian group in the country. The movement has also spread to other countries in Asia as well as Europe and North and South America. Most of its members are Chinese although in some cases others are included.

Now the movement seems to have divided into three factions. The first and largest continues to follow the original teachings of Nee. A second group, led by Stephen Kaung, has become much more flexible and co-operative with other groups. It does not insist on the 'one locality, one church' doctrine and recognizes other congregations in its neighborhood as true churches. The third faction, led by Witness Lee, is far more problematic. As we have seen, Lee had demonstrated a tendency toward legalism, exclusivism, and authoritarianism in Shanghai. After Nee's imprisonment, Lee became increasingly autocratic, demanding unquestioned obedience from the elders and increasingly dogmatic on doctrinal matters. This led to a schism in the movement, some following Lee, others, Nee.

There seem to be three unique emphases in Lee's movement. First is the method of worship that emphasizes ecstatic prayers in unison, leading them to be called 'yellers' and bringing disfavor on the house church movement as a whole. Secondly, Lee introduced a 'second baptism' doctrine. Believers may be re-baptized many times, some believing they should be immersed each time they sin. Thirdly, Lee demands unquestioned obedience, saying that when he commands in his spirit, the Lord commands with him, for he is one in spirit with the Lord. It is reported that a number of Little Flock assemblies in China have joined Lee's movement, becoming ultra-exclusionist and accepting his heterodox doctrines. This is clearly a tragedy for the house church movement as a whole and a betrayal of Nee's spirit and teaching.

It is more difficult to trace Nee's influence beyond China and its people. But his works are widely read by evangelical Christians in many parts of the world.
His works have been published in over thirty languages. Two of his books have each sold over a million copies each. His imprisonment stimulated a great amount prayer for the Chinese church. In our era when most of the reasons for which traditional denominations were established appear to be irrelevant, the simplicity and directness of Nee's message holds great appeal for many. For him, Christian discipleship was an all or nothing issue.

I recall an outstanding Presbyterian missionary colleague in Brazil, a nurse-midwife. She had a remarkable ministry as a nurse and mentor to young evangelists and nurses in a remote area of Brazil. When she tragically killed in a bus-truck accident, two books were found on her lap. One was a work on midwifery, the other, The Normal Christian Life by Watchman Nee.

CONCLUSION

It is not necessary to point out the similarities between this movement and others we have mentioned in the past, even though the contexts were very different. But what lessons can we learn here? First, it is clear that movements of renewal and mission never occur without a profound encounter with the God of holiness and grace by their leaders and participants. Only such an experience will enable their adherents to remain faithful and follow their vision in the midst of misunderstanding, opposition, and persecution. It is also clear that the movement must be nurtured by groups of prayer, study of Scripture, and worship. Without participation in groups with deep fellowship, such movements collapse.

Secondly, a flexible church structure that values and encourages the gifts of every believer is necessary, especially in a context of persecution. But I believe such a fellowship is equally important in every context, including the 'post-christendom' West.

A third lesson to be learned from the Little Flock is the desire to transcend theological

and structural issues from the past that have little to nothing to do with the twenty-first century. Even though Nee was not totally successful in doing so, it seems that his movement aided the cause of Christian unity in the house church movement. How that concern is to be applied elsewhere remains to be seen. In this 'post-denominational' era, how do we hold on to the important values of our own traditions and at the same transcend them in affirming our unity with the whole Body of Christ? Certainly that will be one of the keys both to world evangelization and social transformation in the future.

I have three primary concerns about the Little Flock. Will it begin to see itself, not only as a great evangelistic movement, but as an important factor in changing Chinese society? It has espoused a world rejecting theology that considered almost every sphere outside the church to be the dominion of Satan. Persecution by the government surely reinforced this idea. Yet it has welcomed the poor and marginalized into its ranks and served its own people who were in need. Often it has reached out beyond its own members. As this movement continues to study the Scriptures in a context of greater freedom, will it discover biblical themes that call for ministries of compassion and become a positive force of transformation in China? David Aikman believes that the house church movement, in which the Little Flock is an important component, will become such a force (Aikman 2003). Often it is not until the second or third generation arises in such movements that they begin to look beyond their own constituency to the broader society.

The second question is one that every new movement must face: how to maintain its open structure for leadership selection and training over against the almost inevitable tendency to formalize the process. The Methodist movement is an example here and much of the Pentecostal movement seems to be following the same path. On one hand we recognize that church leaders need serious theological study, on the other it is clear that this often leads to the creation of an elitist, hierarchical church structure and tends to destroy its vitality. It is difficult, if not impossible to find historical examples of movements that have solved this dilemma. Furthermore the concept that the apostles answer to no one except the Holy Spirit can easily lead to abuses as it has with Witness Lee.

The third issue is the stance of the Little Flock toward the wider Church. As we have seen, Nee exhibited both an ecumenical and a sectarian side. Two of his colleagues who took the movement out of China moved in opposite directions. Witness Lee's movement became more exclusionist and heterodox, Stephen Kaung's group became more open to other churches. But one of Nee's driving concerns was the unity of the Church. Openness to other Christians in the house church movement has apparently been a feature of the Little Flock in recent years. We can only hope that Nee's considerable influence will become a unifying force in

the Chinese church and perhaps point the way to greater unity elsewhere.

There can be no doubt that Watchman Nee was one of the greatest evangelists in history. He stands as an example of deep, consistent devotion to Christ, faithfulness under persecution, and powerful leadership. The twenty-first century church still has important lessons to learn from him.

Chapter 5

A Student Led Revival in Ethiopia

This story, like many others, points to the importance of students in the history of the Christian faith, especially in movements of renewal and mission. It is also another demonstration of the remarkable way in which the Holy Spirit raised up and used a group of new converts, with no theological training or status in any existing church. They launched a movement of evangelism that reached far corners of their nation, established a growing church, gave impetus to a continuing student movement and had a renewing effect in the broader evangelical movement in the country.

THE CONTEXT

The Ethiopian official mentioned in Acts 8 is considered the founder of the Ethiopian Orthodox Church. However its recorded history goes back to the middle of the fourth century when King Ezana in Axum was baptized by a Syrian monk, Frumentius, who later returned as the first Ethiopian bishop. Axum was already a cultural center and now became the center of the Orthodox Church. One of the oldest Christian churches in existence stands there today. The old Ethiopian language, Ge'ez was developed there and is still in use. It is the only alphabet developed in Africa.

This Ethiopian church remained in contact with the wider church in the Greco-Roman world until the Council of Chalcedon in 454. Linked to the Egyptian church the Ethiopians rejected the Council's doctrine of the two natures of Christ and taught that He had only one nature in which the human and divine were united. Consequently both the Eastern and Western churches considered it schismatic. The Muslim conquest of Egypt made contact with the Egyptian Coptic Church more difficult and further isolated the Ethiopian Church.

Through the centuries, the Church, closely allied with the crown, came to own one third of the country's land. In its theology and liturgy it developed a strange mixture of Jewish and Christian practices, The church was a powerful, conservative force in society, and the Emperor was its patron. It prescribed various rules for the people, but any biblical message of grace and salvation seems to have been lacking. Even though it was considered the official religion of the nation, only thirty per cent of the population was considered Orthodox. The Church was strongly opposed to any innovation, especially those of Protestant missions, even though some missionaries initially hoped to stimulate renewal within it. Consequently when Western missions arrived in the nineteenth century they were allowed to work only in areas where the people were either Muslim (40%) or followed traditional religions.

Unique among African nations, Ethiopia had never been the colony of a European country except for the Italian occupation that ended in 1944. Haile Selassie, who ruled as Emperor from 1930 until 1974 encouraged a degree if modernization with a written constitution in 1931. But he continued to retain absolute powers. He attempted some reforms but feudal landlords, corrupt officials, and the Church resisted these. He enjoyed international prestige but as he grew older a number of factors led to increasing discontent, especially among students. These were the denial of freedom of speech, the slow rate of economic development, the absence of civil and political rights, and the failure to reform the feudal land-tenure system.

The devastating famine of 1972-74 was the last straw. The government failed to admit the seriousness of the drought and delayed relief measures. Over 200,000 people died, and in 1974, after widespread protests and months of strikes, military leaders took control. The new government imprisoned and then executed a number of high-ranking civilians and military officials and declared Ethiopia a socialist state. Land was nationalized and 'The People's Democratic Republic' was created. Conditions became worse, thousands died of starvation, many others died in fighting between various factions, and over a million fled the country. The Marxist regime continued in power until 1991.

This was the context: political corruption, economic destitution, and totalitarianism, in which the movement began and grew. Starting during the rule of Haile Selassie, and continuing under the Communists, a few students, with great zeal and dedication, spread their revitalized Christian faith to many areas of their society and nation. And they did so in the midst of persecution by the government and the Orthodox Church.

THE BEGINNING

Three streams contributed to the early leadership of the movement. The first consisted of youth from the Orthodox Church who persisted in seeking God until they experienced His presence and grace in a profound way, The second came from a small nucleus of students at Haile Selassie I University in Addis Ababa. The third primary group were young people influenced by the Finnish and Swedish Pentecostal missions. Revivals broke out in other areas, Harrar, Asmara, and Nazareth around the same time. It was clearly a movement initiated by the Holy Spirit in various areas of the country, genuinely indigenous in every respect,

The experience of Haile Wolde Michael, one of its key leaders was important.

> Prior to his conversion to Christ in his own bedroom by himself (he) served as a deacon in the Ethiopian Orthodox Church during his early teens. At this time…church services became empty rituals and meaningless to him. He fasted, prayed, and gave alms

> hoping that these might solve his problems. But nothing changed. Conviction of sin, fear of death, and emptiness of life became unbearable. He…read the New Testament and increased fasting, praying, and alms giving. However his conviction of sin, fear of death, and emptiness of life increased proportionally…This went on for three solid years. …One day, at about 2:00 AM, the overwhelming presence of God filled his bedroom. He cried to the Lord for mercy and deliverance. Both were granted! His bedroom was filled with the presence of God. But his soul was filled with God Himself…He felt he was dipped in a pool of God's love. There he trusted the risen Christ and Christ alone for his physical and spiritual life. That very night he renounced worshipping of angels, saints, and Mary. He was free once and for all! (Michael 1993: 173,4)

Because the Orthodox Church opposed his new faith and practice, he left it. Now a student in a junior high school, he received permission from its director to form Bible clubs and preach to the students every Saturday. When he entered a high school in Addis Ababa he was allowed to preach for fifteen minutes every weekday to a thousand students. He also conducted Bible studies in the school auditorium on Fridays after school and circulated written sermons. He continued his ministry in the junior high school. It is important to observe that often in Ethiopia students at the junior high and high school levels may be in their late teens or even twenties.

He gathered students from the major high schools of the capital city. He hoped to establish witnessing centers in each one and then expand the ministry to every province in the nation. However the Patriarch of the Orthodox Church heard about and ordered the plan canceled.

For five years Michael continued his ministry without any association with an existing church or mission. However he felt he needed more power both for his personal life and his ministry. He had never heard of the baptism of the Holy Spirit nor had he experienced fellowship and prayer with any Protestant friends. One day, five years after his conversion, as he was worshipping the Lord, focusing on the suffering of Christ on the cross, he wrote, "he was filled with an overwhelming presence of God! The love of God flooded his soul, his mind, his spirit, and his whole being….Suddenly he found himself speaking in tongues unknown to him" (Michael 1993:175,6), Soon afterward, in 1966, he joined the university students' group and became one of its leaders.

The second and third streams that made up the movement came from Protestant youth that were also seeking a deeper Christian life. One group consisted of students at the leading university in the nation. Haile Selassie I University was modeled on the American system. The students studied for five years, but the fourth was spent in 'national service' for

the government in one of the nation's fourteen provinces. This national service would soon provide opportunities to spread the movement, even under the Communists. The students constituted an elite, receiving free board and tuition in addition to some spending money. Competition to be accepted was fierce and the students were among the brightest in the nation.

In the fall of 1965 four students who had attended the summer conference of the Swedish Pentecostal mission, decided to leave their dormitory because no religious meetings were allowed there. They lived together in a small house and pooled their resources to pay the rent. Their purpose was to study the Bible and pray together daily at a fixed time. Like the 'Holy Club' at Oxford in the eighteenth century they prayed and committed themselves to the Lord. One of their concerns was to prove that Christianity was relevant as opposed to the view that it was a white man's religion. As one said,

> We…wanted to serve Him and were ready to give our testimony to others…. We asked the Lord that He might grant us a holy and good life that might influence others. We prayed and dedicated the house to the Lord. After this we invited others…. After a few months the room could not contain us any longer, 40-50 students were crowded in the small house (Engelsviken 1975: 35,36).

Another student described their meetings.

> We gathered together, knelt down, started to pray. One of us would open the Bible and read. We had no explanation of the text. During the prayer time we could see that God was working in some of us and the people who were coming to our room. Many great things happened in that room in the lives of the students. Some who had never known about the Lord Jesus… were converted. Some were healed. Many, many were filled with the Holy Spirit. We could hear words of prophesy and many others of the gifts of the Spirit were manifested through the people (Engelsviken 1975:35)

After ten months the group moved into a larger house, even though it required a step of faith to pay the rent. Then, as we have seen, in 1966 two other streams of new life joined them. One was composed of students from the junior high to university level who had come from a nominal Orthodox background. In their deep spiritual hunger they began to study the Scriptures and pray, either individually or with a few friends. And like Haile Wolde Michael, many others had profound experiences of salvation and the Holy Spirit.

The third stream consisted of other students who had been in contact with the Swedish and Finnish Pentecostal missions. One decisive event came when the Swedish mission brought a Kenyan

evangelist, Omahe Chacha, to speak at a conference in 1963. He was a humble man of prayer, and taught the importance of the baptism of the Holy Spirit. The fact that he was an African, not a white man, seems to have been very important in giving credibility to his ministry. But physical manifestations such as tongues and falling down were not necessarily seen as valid signs of the Spirit. Ethiopians had a long experience with possession by evil spirits. A Lutheran observer noted that

> There was at first considerable skepticism concerning the gift of tongues since speaking in unknown languages was not infrequent among witchdoctors and possessed people in Ethiopia. Tongues in themselves were no proof of divine influence. Only in the context of the Christian Gospel and tested by other Christians were phenomena like tongues and prophecy accepted as genuine gifts of the Spirit of God. One may safely say that in the later development of the Ethiopian Pentecostal movement clearly ecstatic expressions became more and more rare" (Engelsviken 1975:28,29).

The influence of two women was especially important in the Finnish mission. But when the women missionaries retained leadership in the group the students withdrew. Both their understanding of Scripture and their Orthodox culture prevented them from accepting leadership roles for women. An even more important issue was the insistence that the missionaries retain control, refusing to allow the Ethiopians to take leadership when they wished to expand the ministry. Consequently these students, influenced by the two Pentecostal missions and the Kenyan evangelist, joined the other two streams in 1966.

The work continued in various locations in Addis Ababa with the rented house near the university as its center. At this point there was no structure or elected leadership. It was a spontaneous and voluntary work by the students. Their main characteristic was their simple faith. They believed that God would do what He promised in His Word. They prayed for the sick and witnessed healings. They prayed for one woman whose X-rays showed advanced tuberculosis and who had been given only a short time to live. She was healed, subsequent X-rays showed no signs of the disease. There were other cases of healings. Demon possession and devil worship are common in Ethiopia, so exorcisms were frequent.

Some missionaries encouraged the group at first but in general they held themselves aloof, believing it would ultimately fail or that the leaders would come to them for help. After all, young students with no resources, most of them recent converts, were the leaders. They had no theological training and no status in the organized churches or missions. As one of them said, "God wanted to use us in spite of our spiritual qualities or devotions. He just

used us in His own will and timing. We were very young people with no social significance" (Zelelew 2004a:4).

The movement grew rapidly, largely without structure or designated leaders. The students began systematically to reach other schools in the capital. Within a radius of from thirty to one hundred miles distant there were four other institutions, a teachers' college, a technical college, an agricultural college, and an air force academy. Graduates from those centers would take the movement to other areas. Most cities had high schools as well. So the students designated those who had friends in the various centers to go and make contact with them. Usually they were successful in starting groups after a few visits. To quote Engelsviken again,

> The group gatherings consisted of Bible study, testimonies, and prayer. The universities and high schools acted as green houses where the life and growth began but soon spread all over Ethiopia. Wherever the young witnesses went they took the revival with them. Most students would go home during the long summer vacations, and as more and more of he students graduated from their schools and were employed as teachers, nurses, soldiers, businessmen, or agriculturalists, they would use their position in the local communities, their salaries, homes, and time to spread the Gospel Engelsviken 1975:44).

But the zeal of the students and the rapid growth of the movement soon brought persecution.

PERSECUTION

At their first national conference in 1966 they discussed the issue of organization. Some wished to remain a free revival movement within the existing churches and missions, but the majority decided to organize an independent Ethiopian church. However, as we shall see, one student stream remained more broadly interdenominational with some different characteristics. Those who organized a church called it the Full Gospel Church. In Amharic it was known as the 'Molo Wongel.' As the work grew in Addis Ababa it became necessary to give it more structure and choose leaders. A small group consisting mainly of the earliest leaders and members chose seven men to be elders and two to be deacons. The congregation ratified these choices. The elders functioned as pastors.

Ethiopian law required that missions and churches register with the government. It stated that it was illegal to hold meetings for more than five people. Normally religious meetings were an exception and the constitution guaranteed freedom of religion. So the church submitted its application for registration in April, 1967, expecting a quick answer. The rule was that if no answer was received within sixty days they could consider permission granted. But that was not to be the case.

While the group was still waiting for a reply from the government, a congregation thirty miles from the capital was attacked one Sunday morning. A crowd gathered around the house where one hundred were worshipping, broke down the doors, took the people outside, beat them brutally, and burned all the Bibles and hymnbooks. Many of the people were severely injured. When the police came they arrested the worshippers and took them for interrogation. After a short time they were released. The Pentecostals appealed to the Emperor who summoned officials to investigate. Despite trumped up charges of sexual immorality, the Pentecostals were vindicated after a public hearing. But their attackers were not punished. More serious persecution, led by Orthodox priests, occurred in spring, 1968, when some Pentecostal leaders were beaten and left for dead. Similar incidents followed, instigated by local officials. Some believers were tortured; others were forced to leave their jobs and places of residence.

Finally the application for registration was rejected by the government, which was strongly influenced by the Orthodox Church. A document was sent to officials throughout the country urging them to close the movement's chapels. This forced the movement to function underground in homes, similar to the house churches in China. While the Pentecostals probably suffered the most, other Protestants, primarily those from the Mennonite, the Mekane Jesus (Lutheran and Presbyterian related) and the Kale Haywet (related to the SIM, formerly the Sudan Interior Mission), churches, also suffered.

The Emperor could not challenge the Orthodox Church, because he needed its support to remain in power. And when the Patriarch had been inaugurated in 1971 he declared, "Today when I am taking this position in front of our King and faithful Orthodox believers, I swear to destroy any religious groups which are unfit to the Orthodox Church" (Michael 1993:191).

Finally in August, 1972, police surrounded a house in Addis Ababa where over three hundred Pentecostals had met for worship. The police presented the pastor with a letter signed by the Minister of Public Security and stamped with the Imperial Ethiopian Seal. By the order of the Patriarch of the Ethiopian Orthodox Church all Pentecostal believers who insisted on meeting to worship were to be arrested and punished. Those arrested were sentenced to six months in prison (Engelsviken 1975:207).

Under the Marxist regime persecution intensified. The government considered the church to be in competition with the revolution for the loyalty of the people. An official document stated that "in this struggle the revolution must be prepared to act forcefully and resolutely (Michael 1993:193). Its strategy was first to eliminate small groups with no foreign backing, like the Full Gospel movement. Then it moved to suppress the larger, mission-related churches. They were branded as agents of imperialism. Over a

ten-year period at least 2000 churches were closed. All non-Orthodox churches were persecuted, and many leaders imprisoned, while others simply disappeared. In October, 1979, thirty Christian youths were publicly flogged while suspended from their ankles. They had refused revolutionary commands, which they considered incompatible with their Christian faith. Others were tortured in prison (Michael 1993:193).

Yet the movement grew greatly. By 1986 the mother church in Addis Ababa had grown to 19,000, and in 1990 the total movement counted over 150,000 members (Michael 1993:194). Today, according to the former General Secretary of the Evangelical Churches' Fellowship of Ethiopia, it numbers over 500,000 (Berhe 2004a). The overall Protestant movement has grown in equal fashion, from four per cent of the population ten years ago to approximately twenty per cent, or fourteen million believers, today. As we will see, much of this growth seems to be the result of the influence of the Full Gospel movement in the other churches.

DYNAMICS OF THE MOVEMENT

This reminds us of similar movements in other times and places in history and even of the church in Acts. One characteristic we have observed in other places is that even when a movement is initiated by expatriates, leadership must pass quickly to indigenous leaders if it is to continue very long. This was evident, for example, in the Korean revival that began in 1903, and the East African revival that started in the 1930's.

Thus part of the strength of this movement lay in the fact that its leaders were Ethiopian and were independent of foreign money and personnel. So it avoided what might be seen as a weakness of mission related churches. And unlike other early Pentecostal movements, it was initiated and led by students rather than the marginalized poor. Thus it seemed to represent modern education, social progress, and a religion not linked to a corrupt government. To many it seemed to be the Ethiopian church of the future.

Even more important was the difference between the dead and ritualistic forms of the Orthodox Church, which had lost contact with the Scriptures, and the vitality of the revival experience. Here people could say with conviction, "I have met Christ. I have been filled with the Holy Spirit." They could point to healings, exorcisms, and holy living in contrast to traditions from the past and legends about saints with no relevance to the present (Engelsviken 1975:195,6).

Haile Michael, the first full-time pastor of the Addis Ababa congregation listed ten characteristics of the early movement (Michael 1993:178-186).

First came a new appreciation for and understanding of the Bible.
He asserted that Bible study and preaching were absent from the Orthodox Church. For Full Gospel believers the

Bible became most important. It was read morning and evening by each one, and taken everywhere. It was also read, studied, and discussed in small groups.
Before praying for the sick an appropriate passage was read. They believed that the Bible taught them about the nature and plan of God, the nature and destiny of humans, sin and salvation, and the direction of human history.

Secondly came a new understanding of the need for, and the power of prayer. Believers prayed an hour each day, individually and in small groups. At times they held all night prayer meetings. Because they believed in the power of prayer, they expected, and witnessed, miracles of healing, the conversion of families, the meeting of personal needs, and protection during persecution.

Small group activities were important. The movement had its beginning in such groups. There they studied Scripture and prayed together, encouraged one another, and brought the sick and their non-Christian friends to be prayed for. These meetings did not replace the regular meetings for worship and Bible study, but they tended to be more spontaneous. These groups became the context in which believers could identify their gifts, discover areas of special interest, and begin to demonstrate leadership.

Lay leadership and participation was essential. All the early leaders were laymen. Until the movement began to appoint pastors all of the leaders were laymen of necessity. But even today lay witness is an important characteristic of the group.

Evangelism continues to be the major focus of the church, apparently to the exclusion of social ministries. The group teaches that the main reason that a believer lives in this world after his or her conversion is to win others to Christ. 'Did you share Christ with someone today,' was a kind of watchword among them. Belief in the imminent return of Christ was another important factor.

Personal holiness is another important emphasis. The movement does not teach the possibility of perfection in this life, but does call its people to purity of life, to be the 'salt of the earth.' This seems to be defined primarily in terms of personal morality rather than social ministries. They were to do their best for the glory of God, as students, workers, wives, husbands and parents, and as children. When a non-believer was converted, complete separation from the old lifestyle and old friendships became obligatory. This would have a negative effect on community building and brought dichotomy between the spiritual and the worldly, but it made a clear demarcation between the Christian and the non-Christian life.

An important theological rediscovery in renewal movements always seems to focus on the spiritual gifts of every believer. The movement emphasized the more spectacular gifts, tongues, believed

to be evidence of the baptism by the Holy Spirit, healings, prophecies, visions, words of knowledge, and the casting out of demons. The conviction that every believer received the gifts of the Spirit led to great boldness in witnessing and evangelism, and to the encouragement of lay leadership.

Bold faith was another characteristic mentioned by Michael. They showed faith in God's ability and willingness to do every good thing that would glorify His name and benefit His creatures. They believed God would save Ethiopians, that He would heal the sick, that He would give the Holy Spirit to believers, that He would provide finances for the spread of the Gospel, and that He would protect His people in persecution.

Sacrificial giving sustained the movement. The majority of its first members were students. With no support from any outside group, they had to depend on their own resources to sustain and extend the ministry. Students invested their small stipends in church planting and sponsoring others to plant churches. An early participant asserted that no one was considered to possess any material resources privately, they looked on their possessions as belonging to all (Zelelew 2004a:15).

New music was the tenth characteristic mentioned by Michael. We have noted that recontextualization and revival usually involve new, more indigenous music. This was no exception. The Protestant churches historically had used hymns translated from the West. But Ethiopian music has five notes while western music has eight, in addition to completely different rhythms. We can imagine the difficulties this created in worship. But now hundreds of new songs were written by men and women using the vernacular language and style. And worship in all the Protestant churches of course, was in the everyday language, rather than Ge'ez, the liturgical language of the Orthodox Church. New songwriters and singers were developed. A missionary observed, "The emergence of indigenous songwriters was a great achievement of the renewal…historical to the growth of the church and leadership in Ethiopia" (Zelelew 2004a:19). Choirs were formed and traveled to rural areas, singing the new songs. Many of the songs responded to existing worldviews, such as Marxism and secularism. They also promoted Christian unity, piety, and courage to stand against those who opposed the faith.

An additional factor that becomes very obvious in reading about the movement, is the reality of spiritual power. Most non-western cultures are strongly power oriented. But western missions, with the exception of the Pentecostals, have usually ignored this issue or even denied its validity. Theologies that taught that miracles ceased after the age of the Apostles made it even more difficult to deal with power and the miraculous. However it is clear that the Full Gospel movement addressed this reality, so important in the Ethiopian context. One

future leader of the Student Movement reported that as a young teenager, knowing nothing of the Gospel, he had a vision of a man carrying a cross. The man told him he was Jesus and that He had died for his sins. (Zelelew 2004b). Experiences of healings and exorcisms brought confidence that the victory of God in Christ, expressed through the work of the Holy Spirit, was greater than any power of evil. This was true whether the evil was manifested through demonic activity or political or religious oppression.

We have already discussed other aspects of recontextualization. We have seen how lay persons communicated the Christian message outside the traditional churchly structures with little or no status in church or society. An important issue in Ethiopia lay in the fact that the Coptic Orthodox Church was the primary factor in setting the context for Christian worship. For example, the people never took Communion without fasting. But Protestants took Communion after eating a meal, creating unnecessary offense to the Orthodox. Showing sensitivity to this issue, the revival leaders decided to fast before taking Communion and continued to do so the entire day.

LEADERSHIP AND STRUCTURE

As movements develop and grow they must face issues of structure and leadership. How are leaders to be selected? How should they be prepared? What criteria are needed to make such decisions?

According to one participant the early leaders did nothing to become leaders. Their focus was different. They made every effort to know God and have a deeper walk with Him. They had a high sense of accountability to each other and learned from the Bible, experience, and each other as time went on. Relationships were important. These were not easily formed in a nation of social grids, ethnic hostility, and strict separation of men and women. But the power of the Gospel dismantled the walls of ethnic hostility and created a new humanity. The language of intimacy was common, friend, brother, sister. However one of the participants related that the relationship between men and women in the movement was considered to be only on the spiritual level. Some time passed before some began to look at those of the opposite sex as possible marriage partners.

Thus in the first phase the flat leadership and community structures accepted everyone equally. One early participant observed, "There was no leader among the leaders in the earlier years except that all of them were leaders" (Zelelew 2004a:13). The members would say no to designated titles and leadership positions. They worked as teams and led without titles. Spontaneity was important and the ideas of all were given attention. They cast lots to decide who should speak at certain functions. Anyone who felt he or she had a message from God could speak. Both male and female students had equal opportunity in leadership. The more mature ones were considered to be

counselors. Thus ministry according to gifts was the pattern of leadership. Barriers of ethnicity, gender, and social and economic status seem to have been eliminated.

This was remarkably countercultural in the Ethiopian context, which counts over two hundred ethnic groups. Historically the Amhara people were identified with the Coptic Church and the rulers. This factor, coupled with discrimination against other ethnic groups created resentment and hostility. Then political groups were organized along ethnic lines. At this point students in the revival had to separate themselves from ethnic based and communist oriented movements.

> Amazingly, the students in the revival came to the understanding that their identity in Christ was superior to their ethnic identities. One of the moral and social impacts of the revival was that it eliminated social barriers among the revival participants….It was impossible to see Tigres, Oromos, and Amharas pray and fellowship except under the cross and this was due to the revival"(Zelelew 2004a: 17,18).

The emergence of the full Gospel Church and the divergent stream that established the student fellowship resulted in two very different structures. The Church was organized with male elders as national leaders and senior pastors, appointed for life. There were other offices under the elders and pastors where women were allowed to function, but none of these involved preaching, evangelism, or pastoral roles. The interpretation of certain passages of Scripture plus the traditional Judaic and Coptic views on the role of women were both factors. During the years there have been some changes in leadership functions but the role of women has not changed.

On the other hand the student fellowship developed a constitution that provided for a general assembly, board of directors, national director, and staff members. Women had equal roles at every level. One of the first national staff workers was a woman. This ministry, now affiliated with the International Fellowship of Evangelical Students, currently works on forty-five college and university campuses.

INFLUENCE ON THE WIDER CHURCH

After some initial reluctance, for the most part, the other Protestant churches accepted the movement and it exerted a positive influence on the evangelical movement in the country. Engelsviken, a Lutheran who worked with the Mekane Jesus Church observed,

> Although the picture of the other evangelical churches in Ethiopia thus shows that they were very much alive and growing under the blessing of the Holy Spirit, we would be less than rank if we did not admit that there was also a lot of dead Christianity: people who had lost their faith but were still active in the

> churches….When the Pentecostal revival began it also addressed itself to members of other churches….The message of a conscious baptism in the Spirit and the power of service that it gives always has a strong appeal to people who suffered under anemic Christianity. There were many who had been baptized, and confessed faith in Christ, but who were longing to experience God in a more real way. They wanted victory over sin, courage to testify, love for others, Christian fellowship, and strength in prayer and Bible study….The Pentecostal message and the Pentecostal experience met this longing also in the lives of many Christians who belonged to the other evangelical churches. The Pentecostal movement became both a revival and a renewal (Engelsviken 1975:101).

He also spoke of the positive influence on the youth in other churches.

> Many who had grown up in a Christian milieu found their Christianity which they had taken for granted, challenged by the zeal and certainty of the Pentecostals. Some joined the Pentecostal movement…but others remained in the churches where they belonged but experienced a renewal which transformed their lives and Christian testimony. Many of them became leaders in the local churches, especially among the young people (Engelsviken 1975:47).

Speaking of the other churches, another observer wrote:

> Congregational services are now viewed by many as the opportunity to minister to one another as well as the time to worship God. In spite of difficulties there is a renewed realization of the primacy of evangelism. In many places a legalistic ethic has been replaced by an emphasis upon purity of attitude and intention (Fagher, 1988, p 386, quoted in Michael 1994:198).

Thus this student led revival became an important factor in bringing renewal to the wider evangelical movement in Ethiopia and contributed to its remarkable growth. Unlike some similar movements it also contributed to greater unity among the Protestant churches, and was a factor in the formation of the Evangelical Churches' Fellowship of Ethiopia. The former General Secretary of the Fellowship is a member of the Full Gospel Church. Unfortunately there seems to be little effect on the Coptic Orthodox Church, even though in some areas it is less antagonistic toward evangelicals.

CONCLUSION

Most characteristics of new movements described in Chapter II can readily be seen in this student led movement. It was

initiated and led by youth who sought and received a powerful transforming experience with God during a time of social unrest and change in their society. Their vision for evangelism and the renewal of the entire church resulted in remarkable growth despite persecution. The study of Scripture, especially in small groups was one of their primary methods. At first leadership emerged informally from the groups, but became more formalized later. The recognition of the gifts of the Spirit and the priesthood of all believers was especially important in its growth.

The movement contributed to greater unity among the various Protestant churches and was a factor in bringing wider renewal. It contributed to remarkable church growth. In 1926 there were only 1,100 Evangelical Christians in the nation. That grew to 150,000 in 1950, and one million by 1973, and five million in 1991. Today the number is estimated at fourteen million, or twenty per cent of the population (Berhe 2004b). It has also stimulated the growing multi-denominational student ministry. In a nation of over two hundred different tribes it has helped break down ethnic and social barriers for those within the movement.

However even though women are accepted as equal in the Student Movement, their role in the Full Gospel Church is limited. It appears that the flexible structures of worship and leadership that were seen earlier, have become more rigid. Pastors and elders are appointed for life. This will probably create resistance to further innovative movements in the church.

Although Ethiopia is one of the most poverty stricken nations in the world, the churches have a growing sense that they are called to mission beyond their own borders. Some have gone to Muslim nations to work as self-supporting missionaries, others have gone on short-term mission to India (Berhe 2003).

Our greatest concern is that while the revival has had a moral impact on its participants, apparently it has had little or no social impact. This, despite the fact that it arose among university students who were concerned about the problems of their society. The exclusive focus on evangelism was one factor in this lack of social concern. Another was a reaction against Communism and its unfulfilled promises. A third factor was persecution. That forced the movement to turn inward and focus on survival even as it continued to evangelize. A probable fourth factor was the feeling that because the Western missions were engaged in a number of medical and educational ministries there was no need for the Full Gospel Church to engage in them. One pastor reported that in his local church's budget, eighty per cent went for evangelism, only one per cent for social ministries (Tefera 2004). Yet it is reported that there are one million orphans in Ethiopia and 450,000 abandoned children on the streets of Addis Ababa.

A second issue, common in new movements, is the need to continue to affirm flexible forms of leadership selection and training that recognize the gifts of every believer. Historically this always becomes a problem as the Church becomes more carefully structured and engages in theological reflection. Some pastors now study at the Pentecostal Training College and other institutions. This is a critical issue for movements like this one. Serious theological study and well-prepared leaders are essential. Yet the continuing vitality of the movement certainly will depend on encouraging every believer to continue to be engaged in ministry. This means the Church must continue to open every level of leadership to those who demonstrate the necessary gifts, even though their training might be non-formal. These two factors must be held in some creative tension.

Thirdly, will the present leadership, with roots in the early movement and years of experience, be open to new activity of the Spirit? There is evidence that such stirrings are arising on the periphery of the Full Gospel Church, often among students. Many of them bear similarities to the original movement. Yet the older leaders apparently do not accept them. (Tefera 2004) We can cite other cases in history where, as the original movement matured and became more rigid, it rejected innovative groups that bore similarities to their founders. One example can be seen in the English Methodist movement not long after the death of John Wesley. The Primitive Methodist Church in England and later the Salvation Army, were rejected by the parent church when they attempted to return to many of the emphases and methods of Wesley himself. Because such struggles are a constant danger, every movement must recognize the continuing need for renewal. Renewal is never an event that happens once and for all time. We are all called to recognize the ongoing need for a new work of the Spirit.

Often the second generation of leaders begins to see the need to focus on such issues. And there is evidence that younger leaders in the Church are beginning to address these issues. The late Haile Wolde Michael, one of the first pastors of the movement, addressed the issue of leadership training in his dissertation for the Doctor of Missiology degree at Fuller Theological Seminary in 1993. He asserted that the Church needed eight kinds of leaders: national leaders/coordinators, regional leaders/coordinators, pastors, elders, evangelists, Sunday school teachers, cell group leaders, and counselors. While some are full-time, most are not, and most are lay persons. He suggested that they be trained in context, using both formal and non-formal programs (Michael 1993:231-236). Currently there are two others from the Full Gospel Church who are studying at the School of Intercultural Studies at Fuller. One is examining issues of leadership, the other studying issues of holistic ministry in the context of poverty.

We can only conclude that this was a work of the Holy Spirit, tried in the fires of

persecution. It has had a powerful impact on Church and nation. Our hope and prayer now is that the spiritual and material forces unleashed by this movement will be used to help transform its society according to the values of the Kingdom of God.

Chapter 6

The Radical Project: A New Model for Mission

This program deserves its name. It calls for radical discipleship and addresses a number of significant issues for mission today. I see five of special importance. But there are others, as we will see.

The first is to begin to shape a missionary orientation and mentality in youth as they approach the time when they will make crucial decisions about the direction of their lives. The strong pulls of materialism and family ties are not easily overcome. This is true in economically advanced nations, but also in countries and churches where many of the earliest believers came from poverty. It is easy to understand that with the upward social mobility often motivated and aided by Christian faith, the second and third generations are oriented toward professional careers and material success. But many of these are just the ones whom the church needs to call to the missionary task.

The second issue addressed by this project is the process by which young missionary candidates begin to function effectively and feel at home in cultures very different from their own. The Radical Project leads them through a number of steps. Classroom instruction is the first. A second is a relatively short experience in a language and culture different from their own, before returning for further classroom work and reflection. This is followed by longer period in a third culture, where the candidates learn a new language before going to their places of service for two years. There are two other essential factors in this process. First, the candidates live in community at a subsistence level, forming a team and sharing their resources. And the communities now include youth of different nationalities and languages. There is strong evidence that this training significantly reduces the number of those who are unable to cope with culture shock when they go to their fields for long-term ministry.

Financial support is a third important question for missionaries from any country, but especially those from the Majority world. One of the most frequent causes of missionary attrition is the lack of promised support. And to pastors and churches in Latin America, for example, the support level required by their missionaries to other parts of the world often appears far too high. A related issue is that the support level required by some western missionaries often contributes to their isolation from the people they hope to reach. The Radical Project addresses this in two ways. First, because of the simple lifestyle and communal aspect of the teams, the required support is significantly lower. Secondly, it appears that because the candidates visit churches in teams and communicate creatively, they are more effective in raising the necessary funds.

The fourth aspect is one that requires a great deal of attention today. How can the whole Body of Christ overcome the fragmentation that has plagued much of the missionary movement in the past, and give a powerful, united witness to the Gospel? This is especially important in the least evangelized areas of the world. And with the missionary movement from the majority world growing so rapidly, it is imperative that older Western missions work with them in a partnership of equals. The Radical Project approaches this in at least three ways. Its personnel are multi-denominational and multi-national. It works in partnership, but not dependency, with a mission agency based in the United Kingdom. And when candidates arrive on their fields they work with evangelical ministries already there.

The fifth is the focus on the 'ten/forty window.' That is defined as a rectangular-shaped window ten degrees by forty degrees north of the equator spanning the globe from West Africa to Asia. It includes sixty countries and over two billion people. The majority of unreached peoples in the world, those who have never heard the Gospel and who do not have any church of their own people within reach, live there. For three major reasons it requires attention. First, it is the home of the world's major non-Christian religions. Over one billion Muslims, more than a billion Hindus, and 240,000 Buddhists live there. Secondly, the poorest of the poor are found there. We see a remarkable overlap between the fifty least evangelized and the fifty poorest nations of the world. Thirdly, that region has received the least attention from the worldwide missionary movement. Only about eight per cent of the present missionary force serves there (Moreau, Netland, and Van Engen 2000:938).

Before we describe the Radical Project as it functions presently it will be helpful to discover the process by which it came into being.

DAVID BOTELHO AND THE GROWTH OF A VISION

David Botelho, a man of extraordinary vision and energy, was on his way to material and professional success. He had become one of General Motors' youngest project managers in Brazil. But he heard the call to mission, graduated from the Assemblies of God seminary, and served seven years in Bolivia under the Brazilian Baptists. There he planted churches, built a school, operated a medical dispensary, and had a feeding program for poor children. In 1989 he took time off from his work in Bolivia and went to learn English at the Southall School of Languages and Missionary Orientation in England. There he lived with Fred and Sandy Nuckley, who were not involved with any mission at the time. There, in the providence of God, he came into contact with World Horizons, a mission based in Wales. It characterizes itself as follows:

> World Horizons is a PRAYER BASED, PIONEERING, PROPHETIC MOVEMENT OF MISSION...

Prayer based: Prayer is the heart and the focus of all we do. Our starting point is to listen to God, to hear the burdens on His heart. Our response is to cry out to God for His will to be done on earth, and to do whatever He asks of us, whether it is to pray more, or to be the answer to our own prayers.

Pioneering: We like to work into the new and the unreached; to go where others are not going, and to see something new come to birth.

Prophetic: Our work is based on hearing from God, rather than following human strategy.

Movement: World Horizons is primarily a network of people, joined together by relationship and a common goal, rather than being a rigidly structured organization.

Mission: We exist because half the world has yet to hear about Jesus in a way that they can understand. Our goal is to share the gospel with them; to make disciples of every nation. (Nuckley 1999:18,19)

The mission now has over two hundred personnel serving in more than thirty countries. Within the World Horizons global community each part retains its autonomy but is interdependent. Personnel from other missions cooperate in its training programs.

Many Western missions might not have immediately embraced a Brazilian visionary like David. But to its credit, World Horizons did.

David's vision was to build a base in Brazil where Latin Americans could be prepared and sent into mission. A Brazilian businessman gave a well-situated piece of land located in the mountains of the state of Minas Gerais. It came as the answer to a prayer agreement between David and Fred. This became the base and was named 'Monte Verde' (Green Mountain). In 1990 the Brazilian branch of World Horizons, 'Missao Horizontes,' was organized there with a board composed of people from different Latin American Protestant denominations. David became its director. Except for the land, a telephone, and a rent-free office, he and his family had virtually no resources and lived by faith. Most of their support had ended when they left their work in Bolivia. But at a World Horizons conference in Britain in 1991 he and the Mission leaders prayed that he might be used to unleash the Brazilian church into the unreached people groups of the world. From this small beginning the Radical Project emerged. When some suggested the Brazilians have their training in Wales, David wisely insisted that the primary steps in their preparation take place in Latin America.

Then came a challenge to send one hundred Brazilians to spend a year in Spain in 1992 during the Olympics and Expo 92. Only twelve went. Some had to

leave when Brazil's currency was devalued and support dropped but six are still there. The first training program at Monte Verde in 1993 enrolled eight students, and in 1994, twelve. That year David and others visited Paraguay and made the decision to open a base there in 1995.

A further step came in 1996 when David and his wife, Cleonice, took six Brazilians to Niger in West Africa. This led to a plan to send more Brazilians there. The project was named 'Projeto Africa Sahel (PAS). The Sahel is the sub-Saharan region of Muslim Africa.

THE SECOND STEP; 'PROJETO AFRICA SAHEL'

Impressed by his trip to Niger David challenged the Brazilian churches, Bible schools, and other mission groups to recruit one hundred people to work in that area. They prayed that the Lord of the harvest would call and send out workers to the Sahel, which they considered to be part of the 'ends of the earth.' Two hundred and twenty people applied but only eighteen had support or were considered ready to enter the program. Each one had to come with promised support equivalent to $150.00 per month in Brazilian currency. During the first year their training included studies on biblical and cross-cultural issues, Islam, the spiritual life, team building, and orientation regarding the common fund. This fund insured that each member had the same level of financial support, no matter what they raised personally. Each was given US$10.00 per month spending money, which meant great sacrifice for many who were used to higher incomes.

The team traveled several thousand miles promoting the project and raising additional support. This was to pay for travel, rent, equipment, medical expenses, and other necessities for their mission. They succeeded in raising over US$300,000, all from Brazilian sources.

For their first cross-cultural training they went to Paraguay, one of the poorest South American countries with a very small Evangelical population. A special feature is the bi-lingual nature of the nation. The majority speaks Guarani instead of Spanish. And there is some hostility toward Brazilians because of past wars over the border. This experience helped prepare the candidates for crossing even greater barriers of language and culture in Niger. They began to study French while in Brazil. This was important for West Africa. During this first year of training two members of the group were asked to leave the project. One had difficulty in accepting decisions of the leadership, the other had medical problems.

David and his colleagues believed that the Sahel would be the opening into Muslim Africa for which they had been asking God. Niger enjoyed religious freedom. It had a small evangelical Christian community and thirty missionaries from seven countries were already working

there. People from the Sahel had free access to their neighboring countries. Christians from the South could easily take the Gospel message to the North. The presence of missionary support bases in the country reduced the cost and facilitated the entrance of the Brazilians.

On the other hand there were great obstacles. Niger is a desperately poor country, infant mortality is said to be the highest in the world, epidemics are common, the great majority of the people are illiterate, and ninety per cent are Muslims.

The team left for Niger in January, 1998. They had visited two hundred churches and seven thousand people had promised to support them in prayer. They went to Niger by way of London where they received more teaching on Islam, visited a mosque and Islamic shops in multi-cultural communities of the city. They also went to the World Horizons base in Lanelli, South Wales, where they received further team building and orientation along with more information about team-life in West Africa.

They spent the first six months in Niger in the capital, continuing to learn French, the major language of the region. In addition they make contact with the local people. They also studied the possibility of various social projects: basic hygiene, agriculture, health care, and literacy. They visited other groups, prayed for them, and learned more about specific needs. Then during the last six months the Brazilians worked with the teams already in ministry there.

At the beginning, and then mid-way through their experience in Niger, David visited them. He and Fred also met with them for debriefing in London on their return. During that process they began to realize how much they had changed. Ten of the sixteen returned to Brazil in January, 1999, after one year. The other six remained in Niger for an additional year.

This initial two-year experiment seems to have fulfilled the hopes of shaping a long-term vision in the lives of the participants. Of the ten who returned to Brazil, four planned to return to the Sahel, two to North Africa, two to the Middle East, and one possibly to a former Iron Curtain country. The other planned to help with the next project before deciding on her future. (Nuckley 1999:59). Thirteen are still involved with Horizontes today, working in West Africa, the Middle East, Asia, and Brazil.

The reaction of the Western missionaries in Niger was extremely positive. The British leader of World Horizons team in the Sahel wrote regarding the Brazilians:

> in all, things are going smoothly and we are very happy with the group, you have done an extremely good job of training them. It's been a surprise to us to see them all working together. One thing that we didn't understand was that the team had its own leadership structures already within it. This has made things a lot easier than we expected. (Nuckley 1999:61)

He spoke enthusiastically about the possibility of many more coming, and the prospect of opening bases in Mali, Burkina Faso and beyond.

As a consequence the wider World Horizons community recognized the value of the program. Its leaders from Africa, Asia, the Middle East, and southern Europe met in 1998 and after hearing the report from Niger, requested Latin Americans from the next group.

We should not think it was always easy for a Brazilian and a UK based mission to function together. It was a bold step (but a very wise one) for World Horizons to accept David Botelho into the mission and trust him to develop the Latin American ministry in his own way.

Often communication was difficult. Different languages, cultural differences, especially in decision making, frequent travel by David, irregular telephone service, and inadequate e-mail servers all created problems. However it is to the credit of both sides that there now is a high degree of mutual trust. The fact that David was already a multi-cultural person, with experience in Bolivia and travels to the UK and Africa, was important. The willingness of the mission to be flexible was essential. The work of Fred Nuckley was also significant. He and David had become friends when David studied English in 1989. Because of their relationship Fred was invited to join World Horizons where he became their liaison with Latin America. Certainly the friendship and trust between these two men was an essential factor the successful cooperation. I believe the presence of these three factors points the way for other models of cooperation between Western and Majority world mission agencies.

THE RADICAL PROJECT: THE TEN/FORTY WINDOW AND BEYOND

We have already seen that the Sahel project developed as a result of positive interaction between leaders of World Horizons in the UK, David Botelho, and Fred Nuckley. In 1999 as they reflected on the experience in Niger they began to look still further and adopted the basic concept of the 'Radical Project.' Shortly after that at an international leaders' meeting of World Horizons in Egypt, the leader from Niger heard of the new project and told them he wanted thirty-five from the next group. It seemed certain that God was confirming the expanded vision.

The purpose of the Project was to mobilize missionaries from Brazil and other Latin American countries, begin their training in Brazil, and send them to work in the 'ten/forty' window. Or as a recent paper put it, it was

> Aiming to produce 1,040+ new Latin workers for the 10/40 Window and Beyond who have longevity on the field. Offering Latins an opportunity to reach out overseas in a medium-term mission project with or without the full financial support of their own church. Training them to be effective cross-

> cultural workers . Partnering with organizations within the wider world mission community. Working predominately in North and West Africa, the Middle East, and Asia. Seeking to evangelise through sport, craft, literacy, heath projects, and other means (Botelho and Nuckley 2004 1)

The description of the project sent to the churches was the following:

> It will be a project of five years of preparation and living
> among unreached peoples in order through practical training, to develop workers who are able to make viable the planting of the Lord's Church among the last peoples on earth. You will be prepared emotionally, intellectually, and mentally. You will work in teams and develop a Christian character and a global and transcultural vision. You will also achieve vocational formation as a teacher of Spanish, English, or French (Missao Horizontes 1999;5)

During the first phase the Project recruited one hundred candidates. By 2003 ninety were serving in North and West Africa, the Middle East, Southern Europe, and Asia. The goal is to send three hundred more in 2005 and 2006. The second phase had sixty in training. Currently Radicals range in age from eighteen to fifty-five with most in their twenties. They include both men and women, single, and married and must have at least a high school education. (However the 'second cycle,' or high school education in Brazil is beyond an American high school level, similar to junior college). Since the majority are single, no dating is allowed during the first year. After that year, if there is interest between two Radicals they can declare their intent to the leaders and the relationship can move forward. There were several marriages in the first group.

While the training program apparently is still developing, currently it is similar to that of the Sahel Project. The first nine months are spent in study at the Monte Verde base. The focus is on biblical, missiological, and cultural issues. Then a year is spent in another Latin American country, Argentina, Paraguay, Bolivia, Uruguay, or Venezuela. There they work with local churches and ministries, and learn Spanish or Guarani, if they go to Paraguay. That is followed by another nine months in Brazil for further study, reflection, and fund raising. Then they go to England or France for six months of more language study. The last two years are spent in a country in the ten/forty window. There the participants will begin to learn the local language and culture as they work with evangelistic and social ministries.

The project deserves to be described as radical for a number of reasons. First it calls for a commitment of five years in which the candidates will live at a very simple level, close to that of the peoples to

whom they go. But beyond this, it really calls for a major reorientation of their lives, away from the materialism of most cultures, to focus on the redemptive purpose of God in history. The project is seen as the process through which this reorientation will take place. The challenge and cost of the project can become a point of great attraction for the best and brightest of Christian youth. It compares favorably to so many activities in the Church and society that call for little or no sacrifice.

Secondly the candidates live in community. This is similar to some of the best of the Roman Catholic orders and the early Moravians. It reminds us of the early Church as described in Acts. While each person must have a minimum support level promised (approximately US$150.00 per month), all resources are shared and administered in a common fund. It is important to remember that less than half of the population of Brazil achieves that salary level. If a person comes with two tubes of toothpaste, one is placed at the disposal of the group. If someone receives a box of candy from a family member, it is shared with all. Each person receives US$10,00 per month for spending money. It must be difficult for most to live with a common purse, but helps them to build teamwork and live as a family. The practice works to break down the individualism that characterizes so many of us today. Such individualism often wars against the values of the Kingdom of God. This pattern significantly reduces the overall cost, taking the teams closer to the level of those to whom they go. And I believe that when churches see the sacrificial life style of the Radicals their motivation to give will be greater. The candidates go out to raise support, not as individuals but as a community. Either all will go to their fields, or none will go.

Thus when the Radicals go to their places of service they go as teams, not as a group of individuals. Usually a great deal of time and energy is spent in attempting to build a team from a group of individual missionaries after they arrive on the field. At times that process is not successful. When teams are formed and relationships sorted out beforehand it is almost certain they will become effective more quickly. The fact that they go with pre-established relationships and leadership has made it possible for teams to go to new areas with less delay. The community spirit also helps Radicals develop a servant mentality. One English missionary in Egypt told of his amazement at seeing them scrubbing the communal staircase of their apartment house. And he added that it opened wonderful doors for sharing the Gospel.

A third radical and counter-cultural characteristic of the project is its success in drawing people and forming relationships among different denominations and theological backgrounds. Radicals learn to appreciate perspectives that previously would have been sources of division as they learn to live around a solid core of shared faith. This includes an affirmation of historic Christian beliefs and commitments shared

by Evangelicals. They do not focus on specific doctrines regarding the work of the Holy Spirit, baptism, the Lord's Supper, etc. On the field different organizations receive the teams of Radicals but they remain Radicals even as they join established ministries. This gives a new vision of the unity of the Body of Christ as well as an appreciation of the need of cooperation.

Fourthly it is radically multi-cultural. Men and women from several Latin American countries are now involved in the training program in Brazil. Currently three North Americans from a church in California are participating in the Radical II Project. And on the fields of service the teams often combine Brazilian, Paraguayan, Venezuelan, British, American, and others as members. Clearly the cross-cultural relationships bring significant challenges to the groups. However as they work through the difficult issues that often arise, they arrive at a broadened perspective. Furthermore, in our tragically fragmented world where there is so much division and hostility because of race, nationality, and culture. unity in a multi-cultural team can be a powerful witness to the Gospel.

The project makes mission radically accessible to Latin American youth. Even if a young Brazilian, for example, hears the call to mission, the obstacles must appear overwhelming. But the various features of the Radical Project bring mission to the doorstep of many, opening the doors much more easily. The relatively low cost and shared finances contribute to this. Now, after only a few years, nearly one third of all Brazilians working in the ten/forty window have come from the Radical Project. This has encouraged other groups. The Brazilian Baptist Convention and Youth with a Mission in Brazil are preparing projects based on this model.

Finally, it is radically focused on sending missionaries to the least evangelized parts of the world. It hopes to tip the balance of the world mission effort more toward the unreached people groups. That is an integral part of its personality and can serve as a model for others. The state of Uttar Pradesh in northern India is an example. It is considered the neediest state in that country. There, working with Indian churches and ministries, Radicals are involved in literacy, work with children and youth, worship and teaching. Because Brazil is so well-known for its excellence in soccer, sports evangelism is effective in a number of countries (Botelho 2003:IV-25,26). In Niger, two Radicals started a soccer league in one of the poorest areas of their town. Local officials became aware of the league and now supply funding and support. Recently the governor came to see the league and donated a soccer ball. So now the Radicals minister there with his blessing (Decker and Keating 2003:319).

The Radicals have written a hymn that they sing as new candidates arrive at the base.

> What was once a dream has become real.
> Today the Lord has made me a Radical.

I will go onward, toward the goal,
There is no looking back,
I will throw open the Window and forever disrupt the strongholds of Satan.
We will, all together, proclaim salvation to the nations
(Decker and Keating 2003:319).

One of their greatest challenges is financial. For decades Brazil has suffered from inflation and the devaluation of its currency. Added to this is the traditional mindset of most churches that mission work is for expatriates, not Brazilians. David Botelho insists that it is time for the Brazilian church to take a leading role in world mission. He recognizes that Brazil now has one of the largest evangelical constituencies in the world. So in addition to the fund raising ventures of the teams, David does mission mobilization courses in churches. Over six thousand church leaders have completed this twelve-hour program. In some cases pastors come to the conviction that they must alter the priorities of their churches. He wrote

> We did a class for about four hundred people at a large church in Northeast Brazil. There were denominational leaders at this course and regional representatives for the 150 churches in the area. At the end of the course I challenged that group that out of their 150 churches, they should set a goal to raise up and send one hundred missionaries. The pastor of that large church followed me to the pulpit and said, 'This church alone will send one hundred missionaries.'…That church has been taking radical steps to follow up this commitment in recent months (Decker and Keating 2003:218).

He constantly challenges believers to think about how they spend their money. Coca-Cola has become an important symbol. He tells them that if Coca-Cola has found its way into every ten/forty country it is realistic to expect that Jesus Christ can also be proclaimed in them. Then he drives home the point that Brazilian evangelicals spend more annually on Coca-Cola than on mission. He suggests that if each believer drank one less Coke each day the money saved would amount to US$15.00 per month. Ten people saving that much would provide the minimum amount necessary for candidates to enter the Radical Project (Decker and Keating 2003:315)

The Radicals travel thousands of miles, visiting churches and friends to raise funds. A two-week trip may involve as many as two hundred presentations to various groups. The teams need to increase their support level from the initial US$150/month to US$400/month before going to their fields of service. Normally they must visit two thousand churches to raise this. This is a formidable task but it also increases interest in missions and raises prayer support.

The teams are dramatic and impressive. When they arrive at a church they are dressed in the typical clothing of a ten/forty country. The men do not shave but let their

beards grow in order to identify with Muslim cultures. The women might be dressed in the flowing robes of Morocco, Niger, or Senegal. They often have their faces covered as any woman would do in a fundamentalist Muslim culture. Presentations include songs and dance from various nations, drums, drama, and other creative ways of communicating. The energy and passion is convincing and contagious. We can only imagine the effect on those who encounter them. And their fund raising tours also serve to recruit more candidates. People are greatly attracted to a group with such a strong sense of its direction and destiny.

Missao Horizontes has published around forty significant books on mission, including Patrick Johnstone's The Church is Bigger than you Think and Operation World. Transparencies with pictures of the missionaries at work, maps of the ten/forty window, and graphs are used to educate the churches and give them a perspective on the world task. Over six thousand church leaders have completed a twelve-hour 'Mission Mobilizers' course. And over two thousand, five hundred people are participating in a distance course that requires twenty modules to be completed and thirty books to be read. Those who complete the five-year Radical Project and then finish the distance course receive a bachelor's degree.

As we can imagine, the Radical Project has encountered some problems. The greatest is still the assumption that mission work is for expatriates, not Brazilians. This perception is still common in many pastors and churches. A second is the existence of narrow denominationalism that continues to exist in Brazil. It is still difficult for many to think of working in cooperation with anyone outside their own denomination.

> In January, 2002 when the Radical II group was scheduled to arrive and begin training, Missao Horizontes received word that approximately 150 candidates from one large Brazilian denomination were no longer coming. One week prior to arrival their denominational leaders pulled their financial support. This represented fifty per cent of the new recruits, and threw the entire plan for Radical Two into crisis. Budgets were revised, arrangements for facilities were altered, and recruitment was re-started… The group went forward but with only sixty rather than the anticipated two hundred (Decker and Keating 2003:320)

Multi-denominational mission agencies are gradually getting more credibility in Brazil, but there are still barriers to overcome.

Despite the obstacles that still exist, it is clear that the accomplishments of Missao Horizontes and the Radical Project have been extraordinary in the few years they have been in existence. The numbers of those sent out and the consistency with which they have remained for the full five years is impressive. This indicates that the training model is one that should probably be adopted by others.

It remains to be seen how many of those who complete the five-year program will continue in missionary service. However it is clear that a positive experience in that first period will be important in motivating a significant number to continue in missionary service. This may take place in the fields they just left or in other areas.
And we can hope that those who return to their own countries after the five years will be positive influences for mission in their home churches.

But of the first group who completed the five-year period, twelve are already back in the ten/forty window and that number is expected to rise to twenty by the end of 2004. Seventy others have indicated a desire to return to the 'window' as soon as they can raise support, since now they no longer are part of the common fund.

THE FUTURE

The potential for growth in the Radical Project is enormous. As we have noted some of the largest Brazilian churches are becoming committed to the project. Volta Redonda lies midway between Rio de Janeiro and Sao Paulo. It is the site of the largest Roman Catholic church in Brazil, the shrine of the Virgin Mary who is the Patron Saint of the nation. A Presbyterian church with several thousand members is also located in the city. Recently an e-mail told of a meeting of several leaders of the city, including the council of pastors. They adopted the goal to send three hundred candidates to the Radical Project. They understand that the task of the church in Volta Redonda is to send, support financially, and pray for the candidates. Missao Horizontes will do the training, logistics, and orientation. This is with the recognition that the grace, call, and anointing of the Holy Spirit are essential. As the e-mail said, a cord of three strands cannot be broken (Barros 2003).

David's vision is for continued growth. He hopes to mobilize the whole Brazilian Evangelical Church to focus on the unreached, to make that a national movement. More research is being done to discover youth interested in cross-cultural mission. His goal is to begin with teen-agers. He hopes to enroll five thousand in a study program next year. Then he expects to challenge Brazilian mission leaders to recruit, train, and send twelve hundred new candidates using the 'Radical' model (Botelho 2004).

A recent e-mail told of interest in the project among churches in California. One church has sent three to the 2004 orientation program. (Pelz 2003:2) The missions pastor of one church described some of the issues of missions in the American church that could be addressed by this project.

> Materialism, self-centeredness, resistance to change, all exert a strong gravitational pull on youth today….Higher education today is quite excellent academically, but generally struggling to offer strong programs of spiritual formation and practical missions experience

> especially for those in their late teens and early twenties. The paternalism of the US church also breeds a sense of self-sufficiency that is hard to shed while in the environment of the States. For the above reasons I suspect that a radical relocation for training is in order. Many youth in the US will not break free from the cultural gravity to enter missions' service in the unreached areas of the world without a drastic shift in how we encourage their training and growth. The necessary humility to minister as servants and partners with nationals around the world will require an immersion in another culture and the humbling experience of learning that others have much to offer us (Wilson 2003)

Many of the same factors would apply to European youth. Thus some members of World Horizons have expressed interest in recruiting them to join Latin Americans in the project.

CONCLUSION

For years this writer has been enthusiastic about the great potential of the missionary movement from the Majority world. Certainly God is doing marvelous things through this movement. But in Latin America, at least, it has not been without its problems. At times these have included a high attrition rate, lack of financial support, inadequate preparation, and difficulty in working with ministries already in their fields of service. Of course the same can be said of Western missions.

I believe that the Radical Project addresses these, and other issues, very successfully. Furthermore it is equally relevant for the West, which faces many if not most of the problems of the Majority world.

It will be interesting to see the long-term results of this project. I suspect there will be at least four. First, because of its methods of recruiting and training, it will increase the numbers of Latin American missionaries and others, working effectively in the ten/forty window. It can also serve as a model for other missions.

Secondly, as time goes by, some of the Radical Project personnel will be led to further study of the theological, missiological, and social issues that they have encountered in their ministries. This normally happens when the Gospel crosses new barriers. And the as a result of such study and reflection, based on solid experience, the whole Church will be enriched in its understanding of the Gospel and the missionary task.

Thirdly, as Radicals are called to work with other agencies, their insights and experience will strengthen the entire missionary movement. The multi-cultural and multi-denominational aspects of their teams can become an example to the wider movement.

Finally, as some of the personnel are led to return to their home churches and countries, we can hope they will be used to stimulate the reorientation of many of their churches and fellow believers. This reorientation is desperately needed everywhere. It requires a shift from the primary focus on our own needs, to the deep desire that multitudes throughout the world embrace Jesus Christ as Lord.

Appendix A

Dispensational Theology in the 21st Century

Darrell L. Bock

BACKGROUND

Dispensationalism has been a significant theological movement within the church, especially over the last century. This theological view is best known for its distinction between Israel and the church, as well as its emphasis on eschatology and the end times that gives a role to national Israel at the end. However, recent developments in dispensationalism mean that many who know about it do not understand where it is today. These developments began to emerge in the late 1980's and have continued since that time. Unlike other new movements, this one started in a very traditional and often quite conservative, sociological environment, seminaries in the United States and in Latin America. Theological reflection led to various publications to explain the biblical basis for the new emphases. Books like *Dispensationalism, Israel and the Church* (Craig Blaising and Darrell Bock, eds.), *The Case for Progressive Dispensationalism* (Robert Saucy), and *Progressive Dispensationalism* (Craig Blaising and Darrell Bock) present and summarize the discussion.

Many dispensationalists today affirm the unity of God's people, in the midst of the administrative diversity that is a part of God's plan. God's people are one; even as the means by which God has structured those people over time has changed (Israel is not the church is not the intermediate kingdom of the end is not the new heavens and earth). So the distinction between Israel and the church is a structural one, not one that involves blessings of salvation. Every Christian affirms the distinction in structures between the periods of the Old and New Testament. What dispensationalism has emphasized is that further structural distinctions lie ahead in the future when Jesus returns in a kingdom called the millennium in which Israel will have a visible role. The theme of unity in diversity is the major theological principle that is emerging from this fresh emphasis. The major implication is that there is an affirmation that God works to bring unity, while also respecting and affirming elements of cultural diversity that are not central to the gospel. There also is a highlighting of community and of the evidentiary power of reconciliation that is a major element of testimony for the gospel to those who look at that community from the outside. Progressive Dispensationalists still hold the eschatological emphases of the larger theological tradition, but have turned the focus to the present calling and mission of the church considered at a larger structural level. What is the church to do and be in the world? How do the Old and New Testaments show the way, especially as

one considers the example of Jesus' ministry, the example of the church and the warnings and ethical values expressed in the prophets?

WHAT IS PROGRESSIVE DISPENSATIONALISM AND WHAT IS NEW HERE?

First, there is an affirmation that when God brings reconciliation among the people of God, it does not obliterate their unique ethnic and cultural contributions to the body (It is *Jew* and *Gentile* who remain one in Christ, so the reconciliation is obvious). This makes Progressive Dispensationalism different than one of the other more popular theological options in evangelicalism, namely, what has been called historic premillenialism. Historic premillenialism has tended to be unclear about the relationship between Israel and the church structurally or in the plan of God, almost assuming Israel has simply been absorbed into the church for all time. Progressive dispensationalism affirms that the church is the institution of God in this era, as Israel was in the previous one and the millennial kingdom, a kingdom that will extend over the entire earth, will be in the next era. These are distinct institutions through which God works in succeeding dispensations or stewardships of God's program. By maintaining an institutional distinction between Israel and the church, the theology reflects its dispensational roots, although it affirms more continuity in God's program than older expressions of dispensationalism. Each dispensation advances God's program and represents a progression on the previous era. Thus the name Progressive Dispensationalism, often called PD, summarizes this view, where both continuity and discontinuity is seen as one moves from one era to the next. What this theological perspective highlights is that God brings unity by bringing together diversity without making it homogeneity. Even the differences in the eras reflect some of the diversity that produces an ultimate unity.

This is very significant in thinking through Christianity and the church at a global level. The mosaic of the one body should draw on the various cultural and ethnic elements that make it up. The world seeing such variety working in unity stands in contrast to the myriad of ethnic divisions that plague and infect our globe. One need only think through the various religious, ideological, ethnic, and tribal conflicts of the last several decades to understand how a picture of people from a variety of backgrounds functioning together and yet respecting their differences can speak to a badly fragmented, sinful world. One of the fascinating developments of this theology has been that often students from the two-thirds world instinctively sense this unit and diversity emphasis and the affirmation it gives to a variety of cultural expression.

Second, there is a renewed emphasis on wedding holistic ministry to the proclamation of the word. Dispensationalists, especially in the two-thirds world, are developing churches that not only preach the gospel but that engage

in concrete outreaches to the poor and discussion of issues at a social and political level.

The Central American Theological Seminary in Guatemala City is training students to engage in such a full orbed ministry. It is not the case that the movement's focus on the future causes them to ignore the church's task in the present. I have seen churches planted in the poorest areas of Guatemala City where the church has undertaken to educate the people as well as feed them spiritually.

I am aware of a program in a major African-America church in Dallas that is fielding teams of tutors for seventy public schools in the Dallas-Ft. Worth metroplex area, even as the church runs its own Christian school. The goal of this church is to evidence reconciliation and to show that a healthy community impacts its community. In addition, this church is actively seeking partners in North Dallas, which is predominantly Caucasian, to partner with them in supporting such efforts to serve the community so the manifestation of reconciliation is obvious.

Third, fresh work has been done hermeneutically with an ethical reading of the prophets and the gospels so that the church can meet God's call to live out the great commandment and carry out the great commission. Here is the ethical and theological grounding for some of the ministry efforts noted just above. Many who think that dispensationalism means that (1) the OT is only good for discussing the end times or (2) that the four gospels are not relevant to us today because they are a part of a “law” dispensation of the past or (3) that dispensationalists are looking only to a dispensation future do not understand the current streams in dispensationalism that are emphasizing the current central relevance of the prophets or the gospels for our present task of the church in mission and ethics. A full kingdom theology is emerging that reflects such emphases.

This kingdom theology affirms that God’s kingdom programs is “already present” but “not yet” fully realized. By keeping a structural distinction between church and Israel, as well as the church and the state, it avoids a confusion of spheres, where the church is to be a theocratic, political state, rather than an exemplary, serving community, a mistake that plagued the church for centuries after Constantine and beyond in the states of Europe during the Medieval, Renaissance and reformation periods. The church is called to serve and often to suffer, not to exercise a kind of political power, but a moral power in the world, not be a rule of law but by a life of integrity at both the individual and community levels.

Fourth, collaborative discussions with other traditions that share such concerns have surfaced at the Evangelical Theological Society in North America helping us to appreciate our foundational unity in Christ and to explore how we can better work together in the large concerns

that are a part of the body's calling. The movement has attempted to exemplify how a sub-movement within Christianity can have conviction about its own beliefs and yet not lose sight of the need of the need of the entire church to work together in mission to accomplish the large task God has given the entire church. These emphases need further development as various traditions begin to interact constructively with what is happening within dispensationalism and take advantage of the new dialogue and its new, more edifying and unifying tone. This global inquiry is an example of such helpful dialogue. We need more example of such cross traditional dialogue and cooperation in the larger tasks of the church.

ANALYSIS OF TRANSFORMATION FACTORS

I will now take the 19 factors related to transformation and examine them from within progressive dispensationalism (see chapter 2 for this list). In some cases, these factors apply, in others they do not, and in some cases, the emergence of change was unlike the normal factors. We proceed one factor at a time.

1. They arise on the periphery.

In this case, the emergence of transformation did not come from the periphery, but from active, on-going study among various leaders at various institutions that affirmed dispensationalism. As they began to communicate with each other, they realized a leading that was taking them in a similar direction and that gained momentum as they interacted with each other.

2. They are motivated by a transforming experience with God, renewal at a personal or group level.

This is precisely what took place as the interactions took place. An interesting development is that several of the schools where this movement was a topic were also among the first among evangelical institutions to launch spiritual formation programs at their schools.

3. This results in a new vision of the Christian life and concern for the Church and the world.

A fresh vision of the church, her activity as a community in the midst of the world community, and of the possibility of the evidentiary power of reconciliation was a result of the discussion and dialogue as the prophets and gospels became a more important concern for understanding how the community of God’s people should live.

4. New spiritual dynamics are important, usually in the form of face to face groups for prayer, study, and mutual encouragement.

Various kinds of groups have emerged at the seminary level and in church contexts. Small prayer groups that also discuss

spiritual formation and growth have emerged at the seminaries. At the church level, ministering groups that reach and give service to their communities in areas of basic human need and in spiritual exposure have also resulted.

5. New models of leadership selection and training become essential.

Alongside the more normal, academic and class orientation of the Seminary have come some group interaction that keeps the spiritual life and prayer as a topic of focus, much as academics are a focus in the classroom. This brings better balance to seminary education. Church also have utilized a variety of forms to be effective and spiritually
vibrant.

6. here are "theological breakthroughs," that is, rediscoveries of aspects of the Christian message that have been forgotten or ignored.

It is here that unity and diversity and the power of reconciliation, between God and the person *and* between groups has received new attention.

7. There is a leveling effect, distance decreases between clergy and laity, social classes, races, men and women, and denominations.

This has taken place between denominations and traditions to a degree. Dispensationalists have always affirmed the value of the believer priest and so a lay-clergy distinction has not been a great problem fro this movement in the past. Part of seeing reconciliation is to consciously pursue cross racial and cross-social class experiences. Here is a powerful application of the Golden Rule and the second of the Great Commandments.

8. The movement is counter-cultural in some aspects, even though as time goes by, it may lose this.

The aggressive pursuit of these cross cultural experiences is counter-cultural.

9. As a result there will be opposition by many in the dominant culture and church.

There was some opposition among more traditional dispensationalists originally and some of that opposition remains. However, some of those opposed are less hostile as the movement has shown the value of some of these emphases, even causing some on the other side to think through some of these issues through their own theological lens.

10. There will be various manifestations of spiritual warfare.

There is nothing particularly outside the normal signs of spiritual battle to report here.

11. At times there will be unusual manifestations of the power of the Holy Spirit. A sense of leading about the parallel lines of thinking between various

participants gave the sense that this was a work the Spirit was prompting.

12. More flexible structures of church and mission will be needed, different from the traditional ones.

Many of the illustrations I have noted reflect either fresh structures or the fresh use and configuration of older structures.

13. The movement will be led into significant recontextualization of the Christian message: that is, how, where, by whom, and to whom, the Gospel is communicated.

How this theology has worked in Guatemala or in the inner city has sprung forth with different concerns, emphases, and practical applications than the more theoretical discussions that have taken place in seminaries or in professional societies. This recontextualization has been encouraged and affirmed as it has developed.

14. There will be growing compassion for the marginalized.

We have already covered this in the various key programs that serve the community and point to reconciliation.

15. At a later stage this often leads to concern for broader social transformation.

This process is just beginning to develop as the models are working themselves out in more local ways in this initial phase.

16. The concern for mission leads to outreach beyond one's own culture, ethnic group, or nation.

The inherent “outward” look and emphasis of this theological emphasis in manifesting the community Jesus seeks to build naturally moves in this direction.

17. As the movement matures, there will be concern for renewal of the broader church.

Given that this movement started from its beginning to engage in dialogue with other sub-traditions, a concern for the broader church was another “core value” of this movement.

18. As the movement matures, many will begin to see themselves, not only as part of their particular movement, but as citizens of the Kingdom of God, transcending their own movement.

It was a desire to serve the larger body that was an initial motivation for this effort, so that there always was attention to how the community as a whole would benefit from the transformation God was engaged in and the growth that was resulting.

19. Finally, every movement is less than perfect, and will be "messy" both around the edges and at times, at the center, since sinful human beings are involved in it.

This is precisely why the learning, growth, application, and transformation should never stop.

Conclusion

Progressive Dispensationalism is a relatively young theological development, but it has gained much attention in evangelical circles. What these developments represent is a tradition that was and is engaged in self-reflection and reform, a transformation that involves continued theological reflection that is biblically grounded and open to the Spirit in seeking continuing growth, even in areas of understanding.

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